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The Sunday EXPRESS

**EYE**

THE BOY WHO COULD BE KING

At 15, cricketer Vaibhav Sooryavanshi's game has a fearful symmetry that has cricket's greats applauding the 'new six machine'

BOOKS

Ruskin Bond on turning 92, his new book and why he can't stop writing



DAILY FROM: AHMEDABAD, CHANDIGARH, DELHI, JAIPUR, KOLKATA, LUCKNOW, MUMBAI, NAGPUR, PATNA, PUNE, VADODARA

Happening today

● **GUJARAT TITANS** will face defending champions RCB in the IPL final. The Titans entered the final after defeating Rajasthan Royals by seven wickets in the Qualifier 2.

● **LT GEN N S Raja Subramani** (ret'd) will take charge as the country's next CDS after General Anil Chauhan superannuated. Gen Chauhan took charge as the CDS in September 2022.

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INSIDE PAGES 4,10



4-STORY BUILDING COLLAPSES IN SOUTH DELHI: 12 RESCUED, SOME TRAPPED

HAMIRPUR BRIDGE DEATHS: FIR LODGED AGAINST FIRM AND OWNER

In multi-state op, police say Pak-backed terror group busted, 8 held

Planned attacks on key installations in Delhi, Mumbai, Punjab: Delhi Police

Pragynesh
New Delhi May 30

THE DELHI Police said Saturday it had uncovered a Pakistan ISI-underworld terror module and arrested eight persons, including a Nepali national, who were allegedly planning attacks on vital installations, security establishments and police personnel in Delhi, Mumbai, Chandigarh and cities in Punjab.

Police officers said the arrests of the eight, some linked to fugitive underworld gangster



The accused being brought to Patiala House Court. ANI

Dawood Ibrahim, were made in a coordinated multi-state operation, uncovering a conspiracy allegedly orchestrated by

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Pakistan's Shahzad Bhatti, his network show up on terror radar

Mohamed Thaver & Zeeshan Shaikh
Mumbai, May 30

FOR YEARS, Shahzad Bhatti cultivated an image as a social media personality, businessman and self-styled defender of religion. Through videos posted online under the '333' banner, the Pakistani national

built a following by commenting on religious controversies, influencer feuds and India-Pakistan relations.

Today, Bhatti, said to be around 45 years old, finds himself at the centre of multiple investigations by Indian security agencies which believe he is a key player in a growing

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

GAPS IN NTA LEADERSHIP AND SUPERVISION AT CRITICAL POINTS IN TESTING PROCESS

Sealed room, leadership vacuum: How NEET 2026 breached safeguards put after 2024 leak

Accused worked under 'CONOPS' (confidential operations) protocol, premises were self-contained with strict rules; at least one arrested had also worked on the 2025 NEET

Ritika Chopra
New Delhi, Mumbai, May 30

DEEP INSIDE the National Testing Agency's paper-setting operation is a highly secured premises in New Delhi that was not supposed to be breached. It's effectively sealed off from the outside: no phones, no laptops, no devices, no internet, air-gapped computers, logs tracking every document, mandatory shredding of all notes. It was designed, after the NEET leak of 2024, to be the last word in securing the medical entrance test.

The people at the centre of the NEET-UG 2026 leak investigation were trusted insiders embedded in the most protected phase of the examination process. And at least one of those arrested had worked on last year's NEET paper, too.

That the leak happened despite this has rattled the Government.

The CBI has arrested 13 people so far, including paper translators, subject experts and intermediaries accused of circulating sections of the question paper before the May 3 exam, taken by over 20 lakh students. Interviews with over a dozen officials, NTA insiders and experts associated with NEET-UG 2024, 2025 and 2026 by *The Indian Express* reveal there's a broad internal consensus on an institutional failure that created conditions for the leak.

Two things, they believe, went wrong.

One, the security framework built after the 2024 controversy, known internally as "confidential operations" or

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 10

Another NTA exam mess: Tech glitches disrupt CUET, retest for over 3,700

Sophiya Mathew
New Delhi, May 30

A TECHNICAL glitch hit the Saturday morning shift of the CUET-UG 2026, the national-level examination for admission to undergraduate programmes in participating universities, leading to confusion and panic among candidates at the affected centres.

The National Testing Agency (NTA) later announced a one-time re-test for 3,765 candidates who had completed their biometric registration but had left the examination centres before the test could resume.



VIVEK PRAKASH KRISHNA

Outside a CUET-UG exam centre in New Delhi, Saturday.

The NTA said about 95 per cent of candidates were able to complete the examination

once the issue was resolved and the test resumed.

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 10



Vinesh Phogat was knocked out of the Asian Games trials in New Delhi, Saturday. GAJENDRA YADAV

Comeback ends in heartbreak, Vinesh steels resolve: 'I will be back, Olympics my target'

Battling opponents and a hostile WFI, loses in the semis of Asiad trials

Nihal Koshie
New Delhi, May 30

"THE SYSTEM is against me today, it will be against me tomorrow, but if I continue to believe in myself, I can overcome the system. The Los Angeles Olympics (2028) remains my target."

This was wrestler Vinesh Phogat, moments after she was knocked out of the Asian Games trials in New Delhi, on Saturday, having fought against the odds to be allowed to participate in the first place.

She lost 4-6 in the semifinals to up-and-coming wrestler Meenakshi Goyat, an Asian

Championship silver medalist.

But Vinesh, the mother of a 10-month-old son, said she was not as heartbroken as she was at the Paris Olympics after failing to make the weight cut by 100 grams ahead of the final and missing out on a medal.

"This loss does not hurt. I am proud of being able to take care of my son, keep him healthy and return to the mat to fight. I hope that I am an inspiration to women," she said. She remained defiant even

in defeat in the 53kg semifinals, walking in the direction of WFI president Sanjay Singh and pointing towards the mat in a gesture that appeared to send a message to officials who left no stone unturned to stop her comeback. "I will be back," she said. The legal battle to secure participation in the Asiad trials after the WFI deemed her ineligible, coupled with court hearings following her accusations of sexual harassment against

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

PETE HEGSETH IN SINGAPORE

'No China hegemony, India critical anchor, helps maintain balance of power'



US Defence Secretary Pete Hegseth at Shangri-La Dialogue in Singapore, Saturday. AP

Flags Javelin co-production with India, urges Asian allies to up defence spend

Amrita Nayak Dutta
New Delhi, May 30

IN AN expansive articulation of American strategic intent in the Indo-Pacific, US Defence Secretary Pete Hegseth Saturday described India as a "critical anchor" to "hold the line" in South Asia and that a "powerful" India, acting in its own self-interest, "advances our shared goal of maintaining a balance of power across the region."

Speaking at the Shangri-La Dialogue in Singapore Saturday, he framed the balance of power in Asia as one "in which no state, including China, can impose its hegemony and hold the security or prosperity of our nation and our allies in question."

At the same time, though, he struck a softer note on Beijing saying Washington was not seeking confrontation despite concerns over China's military build-up. And that under US President Donald Trump, US-China relations were "better than they've been in years."

Hegseth noted India's

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



POLITICS

INDIA SIGNS DEAL WITH VIETNAM FOR BRAHMOS MISSILES

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E. EXPLAINED

The balancing act

Hegseth framing of India as an Indian Ocean anchor and defence co-production partner may be a bid to reassure Delhi that its engagement with Beijing does not come at India's expense. At the same time, he flagged a Pacific dominated by any hegemon (read China) would "undermine the equilibrium we all seek to preserve."

Abhishek gets CID summons, attacked by mob hours later

Tanusree Bose
Kolkata, May 30

TRINAMOOL CONGRESS (TMC) MP and national general secretary Abhishek Banerjee was heckled and eggs tossed at him Saturday evening while visiting Sonarpur to meet the family of a party worker who was allegedly a victim of post-poll violence.

The incident marked Banerjee's first public appearance since the TMC's defeat in the recent West Bengal Assembly elections. The same day, the West Bengal CID summoned Banerjee, asking him to appear before it on Monday.

Banerjee allegedly came



TMC MP Abhishek Banerjee after the attack in Sonarpur, South 24 Parganas, Saturday. EXPRESS

under attack while on his way to meet the family of Sanju Karmakar, a TMC worker who was murdered allegedly during post-poll violence. As he entered Sonarpur on a motorcycle, protesters allegedly

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

● THEIR REAL ESTATE COMPANY PROMISED LUXURIOUS HOMES ON FOOTHILLS OF THE HIMALAYAS, BUT SIX YEARS AFTER THEY FLED THE COUNTRY, BUYERS ARE IN LIMBO; LAST MONTH, ONE OF THEM WAS ARRESTED IN DUBAI

Champagne parties to Interpol notice: Rise and fall of a Dehradun power couple

Aiswarya Raj
Dehradun, May 30

IT WAS at a glitzy evening event in February 2015 where businessman Deepak Mittal made his mark on Dehradun's high society. Around 1,200 guests, including senior officials, attended the party in the city to launch what Mittal promised would be an elite and exclusive club — the Canyons Club, with membership by invitation only and costing Rs 75 lakh. Members would need to have at least done their graduation, while gazetted government officers, defence personnel and practising doc-

tors would get a discount. At the end of the party, which featured a performance by a Bollywood singer, the guests were sent home with gift bags carrying bottles of premium champagne.

Around the same time, Mittal, then the managing director of Pushpanjali Realms and Infratech, also launched plans for luxurious flats tucked away in the foothills of the Himalayas. The launches and parties firmly established 48-year-old Mittal and his wife, Rakhi, also 48, as prominent members of Dehradun's elite. The inauguration of the club was scheduled for February 2018, the

same year flats of the flagship housing society, Orchid Park, launched by Mittal, were to be handed over for occupation.

Soon afterwards, around 90 new buyers approached the firm to book a flat in Orchid Park — a 339-unit, eight-tower project — which was to come up on Dehradun's Sahastradhara Road. The cost ranged from Rs 46 lakh for a 1BHK to Rs 1.1 crore for a three-bedroom apartment.

The dream flats, however, were never completed. In 2020, facing allegations of money laundering, Mittal left the country with his wife — she was arrested by the Dubai police last month — and their two adult children. When he left, the un-



finished Orchid Park project was already two years past its completion date. Another of his real estate projects in Dehradun, Eminent Heights, was also

facing allegations that flats were sold to multiple people at the same time.

The Canyons Club project was never officially inaugur-



(Left) Incomplete towers at Orchid Park on Sahastradhara Road in Dehradun; (Above) MD of Pushpanjali Realms and Infratech, Deepak Mittal, and his wife Rakhi Mittal.

ated either.

Vivek Kumar, Additional SP of the Special Task Force, said, "We are coordinating with the central agencies in extradition

proceedings."

To establish credibility, Mittal had named several co-directors for the club, including prominent advocates, a senior staff member of an elite boarding school, entrepreneurs, and senior IPS officer Amit Sinha. Sinha, now a Special Principal Secretary in the Uttarakhand government, said he had joined as the club's director to promote sports in the region.

"I was not aware of Deepak's background. There were four of us, like-minded people, who wanted to get squash and tennis courts in the area for practice. When I saw that the club was not getting inaugurated and there was an unaccounted delay, I

stepped down in 2019," he told *The Indian Express*.

Fall of a power couple

Before the allegations gained steam and the Mittals fled the country, the couple was hobnobbing with film directors, bureaucrats and other prominent citizens. They had multiple projects in the city. Apart from helming Pushpanjali Realms and Infratech and serving as a director at Canyons Club, Mittal also headed Rasayana Infra Design and QK Hotels and Restaurants. Rakhi was a director at Rasayana and QK Hotels. The Mittals also own the Kanatal Resorts in Dehradun.

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



The Buddha Connection

Myanmar President U Min Aung Hlaing visits the Mahabodhi temple in Bodhi Gaya, Bihar, on Saturday. Hlaing, accompanied by a high-level delegation, including Cabinet ministers and business leaders, arrived here on the first day of his five-day visit to India. PTI

RTI activist shot dead in Punjab, police probe motive

Express News Service
Jalandhar, May 30

UNIDENTIFIED GUNMEN shot dead Jalandhar-based RTI activist and advocate Simaranjit Singh near the Law Gate of Lovely Professional University (LPU) in Phagwara on Saturday. The attack took place when Singh had reportedly gone to Phagwara for some work. According to preliminary information, the gunmen were allegedly lying in wait near the university gate and opened fire as soon as they spotted him. One of the bullets struck Singh in the head, causing him to collapse on the spot.

DIG Naveen Singla who along with Kapurthala SSP Gaurav Toora, rushed to the spot on getting the information said police found a .32 bore pistol and two mobile phones near Singh's body, while a 12 bore rifle was found in an SUV parked near the crime spot.

"Evidence has been collected and efforts are underway

to identify and trace the assailants. We are scanning CCTV footage and have formed multiple teams. We are investigating the case from all possible angles," DIG Singla said.

A case under relevant sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita has been registered, the DIG added.

The murder has attracted significant attention because Singh had been actively pursuing several public-interest issues not only in Jalandhar but across Punjab.

Sources said Singh had previously raised issues related to governance, transparency and public accountability through RTI applications and court proceedings. It is also learnt that he had allegedly supplied certain documents to the Enforcement Directorate (ED) in connection with investigations linked to former AAP minister Sanjeev Arora, although officials have not commented on whether this aspect is being examined as part of the murder probe.

Money laundering: Court orders framing of charges against Jacqueline, Sukesh

Press Trust of India
New Delhi, May 30

A DELHI court on Saturday ordered framing of charges against actor Jacqueline Fernandez, alleged conman Sukesh Chandrashekhar and 15 others in a Rs 200-crore money laundering case. The court ordered framing of charges against Chandrashekhar and 20 others for various offences, including under the stringent MCOCA provisions, in another case registered by the city police's special cell.

In two separate orders, Additional Sessions Judge (ASJ) Prashant Sharma said that prima facie, there is sufficient material against the accused.

In the ED case, ASJ Sharma said that the accused persons

"have to be charged with the offence (of money laundering) under Section 3 of PMLA, punishable under Section 4 of the PMLA, the ASJ said.

In the case registered by special cell and later probed by economic offences wing, the judge ordered framing of charges against Chandrashekhar for personating a public servant, extortion, cheating, criminal intimidation, along with IT Act provisions and MCOCA sections for committing an organised crime and possessing unaccountable wealth on behalf of members of an organised crime syndicate. He also ordered framing of similar charges, except for offence of impersonating a public servant, against Sukesh's wife, Leena Paulose.

[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

Hegseth

modernisation of its military to bear its share of the security burden, particularly in the Indian Ocean, and praised its efforts to build "heavy industrial and logistics capacity to sustain high-end military operations, including the ability to repair and maintain shared platforms and support US Navy vessels operating forward in the theatre."

The Defence Secretary announced that the US had committed to pursuing "co-production" of Javelin anti-tank guided munitions with India — "real, tangible steps to improve the collective readiness of our forces." Defence co-production of this kind, with a sophisticated frontline weapon system, is framed as deepening the bilateral defence relationship.

"This kind of industrial muscle isn't just a long-term

goal; it's an immediate operational imperative, and the United States Department of War is leading the way," he said.

Highlighting that Washington's broader Indo-Pacific strategy was aimed at preserving regional stability while ensuring that no single power could dominate the region, he said: "What we seek ... is a genuinely stable equilibrium that works for Americans as well as for our allies."

He added that the Indo-Pacific remained central to US security and prosperity, underlining that Washington remained committed to the region despite security challenges elsewhere, including in West Asia.

He further said that the era of the United States subsidising the defence of wealthy nations is over. "We need partners, not protectorates. We seek alliances built on shared responsibility, not dependency," he said.

Power couple

Now, he is untraceable, while his wife was arrested in April by the Dubai police for alleged financial irregularities while she was in the UAE.

Police said Mittal swindled the buyers of over Rs 45 crore they had put into the projects, and that he siphoned off part of it for personal and other uses, leading to delays in the completion of the projects. Currently, of the nine FIRs registered against him, chargesheets have been filed in four, a probe is underway in four, and a final report has been submitted in one. An application has also been filed in the NCLT to initiate the corporate insolvency resolution process.

While two of the proposed eight towers in Orchid Park were about 70% completed, three of the four towers in Eminent Heights were completed by the time FIRs were registered. A reward of Rs 50,000 each has been declared for information leading to the couple's arrest, and an Interpol Red Corner Notice has been issued. Steps are being taken to seek Rakhi's extradition from the UAE, a police statement said.

According to the police statement, the couple acquired citizenship of the Republic of Vanuatu through its Citizenship by Investment programme, which allows individuals to obtain an additional citizenship or passport by making economic contributions. Deepak Mittal is said to have secured a passport in the name of Deepak Kumar, issued on July 28, 2022. On the basis of the Vanuatu citizenship, he is also reported to have obtained an Emirates ID and is believed to be residing in Dubai, the statement said.

Back in India, 58-year-old

former HR professional Kavita Bhatia continues her fight to recover the money she paid for a flat in one of Mittal's projects.

In 2013, she moved to Dehradun from Delhi. In 2016, she learned of the "upcoming" Orchid Park project and was impressed by what it had to offer — Italian marble floor, European-style modular shutter doors, a German modular kitchen, and a video door phone with CCTV security and surveillance.

"Living the high life means living in style," the brochure said. Bhatia was convinced; she chose V-304, a 3BHK flat with a garden in the Violet Tower of Orchid Park. "We booked the flat and entered into a buyer-builder agreement in March 2017. They assured us that we could have occupancy by 2018. I paid them Rs 57 lakh in advance in April 2017, and Rs 50 lakh was to be paid at possession," she said.

Two months after Bhatia paid the advance, the work stopped. Bhatia had sleepless nights; she had taken a Rs 37-lakh loan and was paying Rs 60,000 per month in EMIs and rent for the house she lives in.

"The builder said it was because of demonetisation, but that had happened six months earlier," Bhatia said.

Around the same time, Bhatia was diagnosed with a breast tumour requiring surgery. "I met the directors and told them that if the project did not resume, I would make a hue and cry about it. But they remained unaffected," she said.

She made more than a "hue and cry" — in 2019, she filed a complaint with RERA. It went on to rule that demonetisation, cash and labour shortage, reasons builder had cited for the delay, could not be treated as "force majeure" circumstances.

Issuing a 45-day ultimatum for the refund, RERA order issued in February 2020 said, "The complainant is entitled to a re-

The US would continue to strengthen military capabilities and cooperation with allies to preserve regional stability, he said, adding that defence commitments have been undertaken by several Indo-Pacific partners, including India, Japan, South Korea, Australia, Singapore, Malaysia, Thailand, Vietnam and the Philippines.

In an echo of what Washington has been saying to European allies, Hegseth urged the Asian ones to increase their military spending to counter China's power and dominance in the region, adding that a stronger, more self-reliant network of allies is essential to prevent aggression while preserving the balance of power.

"There is rightful alarm regarding China's historic military buildup and the expansion of its military activities in the region and beyond," he said, adding: "A Pacific dominated by any hegemon would unravel the re-

gional balance of power."

"No state, including China, can impose its hegemony and hold the security or prosperity of our nation and our allies in question."

"Less Shangri-La, more ships, more subs," Hegseth said, underlining that the region needs to invest in defence capability more than conferences.

Responding to a question on India's recent test of an advanced version of the Agni missile,

Hegseth said "both sides there are going to see understandable threats coming from the other...but we are not pointing a finger, at least from our view right now, at either country."

He repeated President Donald Trump's claims regarding the India-Pakistan ceasefire last year giving him credit for "brokering a peace between India and Pakistan, two nuclear-capable countries."

fund of the entire amount paid for the flat together with interest at the rate of 10.15% per annum from the respective dates of payment until actual refund."

Armed with the order, she went to the nearest police station. "The officers refused to listen to me and didn't accept my complaint. For the next seven months, I went to police stations every day. I had rented an autorickshaw, and I would go there every morning and come back in the afternoon, dejected. I warned them that the Mittals would leave the country, but they paid little heed. I met every- — Garhwal Commissioner, police heads, ED officials — no one listened to me," Bhatia said.

On July 8, 2020, an FIR was filed on her complaint. Soon, other complaints began to trickle in, and the Mittals fled. The complainants included a Merchant Navy officer, a lawyer from Delhi-NCR, and a Dehradun-native living in Delhi and seeking to return after retirement. In an FIR filed in the Eminent Heights project, a lawyer who had invested in the project alleged that two flats allotted to him were later sold to a real-estate firm. The lawyer told *The Indian Express* he had invested in the project after a prominent bank financed the purchase. "Without informing either me or the bank, the company sold the flats to another party. Instead of taking action against the builder, the bank continued to harass me by demanding repayment of the instalments," he alleged.

As allegations poured in, the ED stepped in in February 2021. An ECIR was registered on February 19, 2021. "When I was in the hospital for my surgery, I got a call from the ED; they asked me to submit an application, and my son appeared instead of me. Following my discharge from the hospital, I submitted my application, but little did I know I was shooting myself in the foot.

The ED attached all properties, including the project where my flat was supposed to come up," Bhatia said.

During the RERA proceedings, the project underwent a valuation by a government valuer, which revealed that expenses incurred on the project up to August 2021 amounted to Rs 34 crore. According to an ED submission in the HC, the accused collected around Rs 31.15 crore from homebuyers between March 2015 and January 2020, but instead of utilising this for the completion of real estate projects, the funds were allegedly diverted for personal use.

In October 2023, a group of 10 homebuyers, including Bhatia, filed an application before the NCLT, claiming they had collectively paid Rs 3.51 crore towards allotment of flats, and seeking Rs 4.14 crore, including interest at 12% per annum.

Currently, a resolution plan has been submitted to NCLT, and if approved, the applicant will move ED to release the attached properties, say the applicants. Town and Country Planning Department Secretary Dr R Rajesh Kumar said that RERA is seized of the matter and is "doing everything possible legally". "We have instructed the RERA to speed up the process in the larger public interest." When Deepak and Rakhi Mittal fled, the director of their company, Rajpal Walia, was tasked by the police with finding an investor who would complete the project, but the plan did not take off.

The lawyer for Mittals was unavailable for comment. Rajpal's son Aryan, who handles his cases, claimed, "We started a project with an investor from Gujarat, but Mittal refused to transfer the shares in his and his wife's name. He didn't hand over the company to us either. Later, he sent a notice to the investor and us, asking us not to start the project, as he remained the MD."

and fund their activities.

Shukla said, "Ang Kami Lama was lodged in a Thailand jail from 2001 to 2018 in a narcotics case. There he came in contact with co-inmates Aizaz Rasool and Md. Salim alias Munna Jhingada, both from Pakistan. After coming out of jail, Lama maintained contact with Jhingada."

Senior officers said the module pointed to the re-activation of the Dawood network.

The arrests come 20 days after security personnel were alerted about the possibility of a terror attack in the Capital. Intelligence inputs, sources said, had hinted at suicide attacks and improvised explosive devices (IEDs) mounted on vehicles.

Among the possible targets were the BJP headquarters on Deen Dayal Upadhyaya Marg and other crowded areas in Central Delhi, according to sources.

In April, the Special Cell arrested 11 people following raids across Delhi and Punjab.

Munna. They were tasked to carry out grenade attacks and firing at vital installations, security establishments and police personnel in Delhi and Mumbai," Shukla said.

Arbaz and Sheikh also told police they had prepared a team to attack security personnel and government buildings in Delhi. On Saturday morning, police nabbed three men from Punjab who were headed to Chattarpur in Delhi.

A police officer said, "All the three accused, Harvinder Singh, Gagandeep Singh and Manjeet Singh, are residents of Punjab. They were intercepted on the Mehrauli-Badarpur Road around 1 am today and a heavy cache of arms and ammunition, including grenades and automatic pistols, were recovered."

Police said they also arrested a Nepali national, Ang Kami Lama, in the early hours of Saturday. He had been tasked by Munna Jhingada to arrange a hideout for the accused in Delhi

Pak-backed terror group busted, 8 held

Pakistan ISI, underworld operatives and the network of gangster Shahzad Bhatti operating from Pakistan and Dubai.

The arrests were made in Maharashtra, Punjab and Delhi and police said the alleged operatives were in touch with handlers in Pakistan and Bangladesh. According to police, 23-year-old Vijay 'Shooter', who hails from Mirzapur, was arrested from Pune on May 14. Based on the information he provided, his associate Nitish Paswan, 23, was nabbed from Sahibganj on May 17.

Special Commissioner of Police (Special Cell) Anil Shukla said, "Vijay was in regular contact with members of the Shahzad Bhatti network operating from Pakistan and Dubai. Vijay was tasked to carry out

various criminal and terror activities in Delhi, Punjab, Haryana, Rajasthan and UP. He was also tasked to recruit youth for executing terror activities in Delhi-NCR."

Nitish and Vijay, police said, confirmed that there were modules in Delhi and Mumbai which were planning attacks in both the cities, and had already done a reconnaissance of multiple bridges in Mumbai and the Dadar station.

Based on Vijay's disclosures, two men — Tauqueer Sheikh and Arbaz Khan — were nabbed from Mumbai last Wednesday.

"Both were in contact with ISI handlers Yawar Khan and Munna Jhingada. They were recruited by one Huzaifa from Mumbai, who is absconding and was working at the behest of Shahzad Bhatti, Yawar and

Shahzad Bhatti

cross-border crime and terror network.

On Saturday, the Delhi Police Special Cell arrested eight persons from multiple cities for alleged links to Bhatti's network. According to investigators, they were planning terror attacks in several cities.

The arrests have once again returned the spotlight on Bhatti. From Pakistan Punjab, Bhatti first came under the scanner of Pakistan's police in 2013, when cases involving theft and robbery were registered against him. Several other cases

followed over the years, including rape allegations that Bhatti denied. His name was also linked to Lahore's criminal underworld, particularly with figures such as Farrukh Khokhar, although Bhatti has publicly described these ties as "friendships rather than organisational ties".

Around 2015, Bhatti is believed to have moved to the UAE, where he said he owned a scrap trading business along with agricultural and dairy ventures. His current location remains unclear, but investiga-

tors believe he moves between Pakistan and Gulf countries.

Bhatti was among the social media personalities who benefited from TikTok's rapid growth in Pakistan after 2018, building a following through videos on religion, nationalism and online controversies. He frequently commented on blasphemy controversies involving Pakistani influencers, including the April 2025 shooting outside the residence of influencer Rajab Butt.

One of the more intriguing aspects of Bhatti's public life has been his claimed friendship with jailed Indian gangster Lawrence Bishnoi. The association became more widely known after investigators linked him to

Vinesh: 'I will be back'

the federation's former president Brij Bhushan Sharan Singh, had taken a mental toll.

"My first fight was against sexual harassment; this was about overcoming mental harassment," Vinesh said.

On the mat, she was technically sound against opponents much younger than her, but the challenge was not to tire.

"If the WFI had allowed me to participate in the Open National Ranking Tournament (in Gonda), I would have been better prepared," Vinesh said, while giving credit to all her opponents for the fight they put up.

But after three hard-fought bouts at the high-intensity trials at the K D Jadhav Indoor Stadium, the 31-year-old's dream of representing India at this year's Asiad in September-October came to an end.

During her bouts, seated a few metres away from the mat were WFI officials who moved the Supreme Court to challenge a High Court order that allowed her to participate in the trials.

Vinesh's camp had a run-in when some of her supporters celebrated in front of WFI officials after a challenge went in her favour during the quarterfinals against Under-23 World Championships medalist Nishu. Vinesh prevailed 7-6 in that close bout.

Every time she was on the brink, a determined Vinesh found a way to come back, smartly using even the time referees took to review a challenge on video replay to catch her breath. In all three bouts, she was

given a warning for being passive, but didn't back down when her opponents put her under the pump.

Vinesh had to fight on the mat, and off it too. Her morning started with a curveball thrown her way. She first had to convince the WFI to let her compete in the 53kg category after the federation issued a circular saying she could compete only in 50kg — the category she last competed in almost two years ago at the Paris Olympics. However, following an argument with WFI president Sanjay Singh just before the weigh-in, the federation reversed its decision. Vinesh said the delay in accepting her entry cost her precious preparation time.

Then came the wait — nearly five-and-a-half hours — for her first bout of the day. Vinesh led 1-0 against Jyothi in the first round but, after being warned for passivity in the second round, went for the kill, winning 7-1. She was quickly back in the training zone, a physio giving her a rubdown and her husband Somvir a pep talk.

Vinesh then came through in a tough bout against Nishu — despite trailing 0-5, she overturned the deficit to advance to the semifinal against Meenakshi.

"Before the Paris Olympics, I was fighting the system, but then there was an ad hoc committee overseeing things. Now the WFI has a free hand and they are being openly biased against me. I will keep fighting," she said.

Abhishek

attempted to assault him. Witnesses claimed that he was heckled, his shirt was tugged, and objects, including bricks, shoes and eggs, were hurled at him.

The motorcycle on which Banerjee was travelling was also allegedly pushed to the ground amid the chaos. Protesters were heard chanting "Chor, chor (thief)" slogans against the Diamond Harbour MP.

Banerjee's security personnel were seen attempting to shield him from the crowd. Wearing a cricket helmet for protection, the TMC leader continued moving forward despite the protests. Eggs were also thrown at him, and several buttons on his shirt were torn off.

"This is BJP-sponsored. Look at the situation. We have come to meet victims of post-pol violence, but the police are nowhere to be seen despite repeated requests," he said later.

"I will move both the High Court and the Supreme Court regarding this incident. In the last 15 years, such a thing has never happened. I do not expect security from this government. Overnight, bulldozers are deployed, but I do not expect protection. I will stand by this family," he said.

Meanwhile, several women protesters gathered outside the house, carrying brooms and raising slogans against Banerjee. Some questioned the TMC leadership's role during the RG Kar Medical College and Hospital rape-murder case. "They protected the culprits. Where were they when the entire country stood in solidarity with the RG Kar victim?" one of them said.

After the incident, Banerjee was taken to a private hospital. Former CM and TMC chairperson Mamata Banerjee, along with other family members, also headed there. Within an hour, Banerjee was seen leaving the hospital in a wheelchair, accompanied by the former CM.

The TMC condemned the incident through a social media post, which Mamata shared, adding: "Rulers become killers — shame on you, BJP."

The attack was condemned

by SP chief Akhilesh Yadav, who said, "By orchestrating a murderous attack on Shri Abhishek Banerjee ji, a key leader of the Trinamool Congress in Bengal, the anarchic BJP government in Bengal has proven that the BJP is capable of nothing but hate-filled, negative, violent politics. Even in such a sensitive environment, the absence of police arrangements points to a major conspiracy."

Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge said, "Strongly condemn the shocking attack on MP Shri Abhishek Banerjee in Sonarpur, as he went to meet the families affected by post-pol violence in the state. The deliberate lack of adequate police protection for a prominent Opposition leader speaks volumes about the BJP's politics of vendetta and persecution."

Rahul Gandhi said on X, "The attack on MP Abhishek Banerjee in Sonarpur is utterly reprehensible. An attack on an MP is not merely an assault on one individual — it is an assault on the very people who elected him, and on the democracy that is our shared legacy. This is the ugly face of the BJP's politics of revenge."

Responding to the allegations, BJP state president and MP Shamik Bhattacharya condemned the incident while denying any role of his party. "My party has no connection with this incident. Why the police were not present, as alleged by him, I do not know," he said.

Meanwhile, a four-member team from the CID went to Banerjee's Harish Mukherjee Road residence, only to be informed that the MP was not there. Afterwards, he said, "I reside in my Kalighat Road house. If they (the CID) want to give notice, they will have to come here." CID officials who returned to Kalighat Road house were told the MP was busy and would not be able to meet them right away, prompting them to wait for a few hours.

The reason for the summons is as yet unclear. Banerjee said he had not seen the notice and will consult a legal expert. The CID is probing into allegations of forged TMC MLAs' signatures on a letter submitted to Assembly Secretariat nominating Sobhan Deb Chattopadhyay as LoP.

tions across the state and questioned 53 individuals who had allegedly interacted online with social media accounts linked to Bhatti's network.

According to ATS officials, the network identifies young people expressing frustration with authorities through social media posts.

"They are promised solutions to their problems and given inducements," an ATS source said. "The recruitment process is gradual, designed to test the willingness of potential recruits. First, they are given small tasks, and once they realise the person is motivated, they are put in a separate group to create law and order problems."

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SEVERAL PARTS OF CAPITAL FACING WATER SCARCITY

Haryana will give 1000 cusecs of water via Munak canal, says CM

Express News Service
New Delhi, May 30

THE HARYANA Government has assured that it will supply 1,000 cusecs of water to Delhi on a daily basis, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said on Saturday, as several parts of the Capital continued to face water scarcity. “To tackle water-related challenges arising due to the scorching heat, an assurance has been given by Haryana to maintain a minimum of 1,000 cusecs of water supply through the Munak Canal,” Gupta said at a review meeting after speaking to Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini.

According to Delhi Jal Board (DJB) officials, the city has been receiving between 900 and 924 cusecs through the Munak Canal in the last few days. Presiding over a meeting with officials from the Water department and the DJB, the CM said that efforts are being made to press into service more than 980 tankers, which will make over 6,000 trips daily to deliver water to the affected areas.

Being a landlocked city with no independent source of raw water, Delhi depends largely on neighbouring Haryana and UP for its water supply.

Delhi’s municipal water demand is roughly 1,250 to 1,380 million gallons per day (MGD), while the DJB peak production hovers around 935 to 1,000 MGD. This leaves the Capital facing a persistent daily shortfall of over 300 MGD during peak summer periods.

For several days now, officials said the DJB has been unable to maintain its targeted water production of 1,000 MGD, with output dropping by around 90 MGD amid a shortage of raw water.

Water Minister Parvesh



Chief Minister Rekha Gupta at the review meeting on Saturday. EXPRESS

Sahib Singh, who also attended the meeting, said, “Delhi currently requires around 1,250 MGD of water during the peak summer. Despite the challenges arising from a significant decline in the Yamuna water level at the Wazirabad Barrage, DJB has been making every possible effort to sustain water production and ensure minimum inconvenience to residents.”

He added that water level at Wazirabad pond has fallen from its normal level of 674.5 feet to nearly 668 feet, resulting in a shortage of raw water and affecting water production by nearly 80-100 MGD.

“This situation has been aggravated by the prolonged dry spell in the upper reaches of the Yamuna,” he said, adding that to address this, additional raw water has been diverted from the Carrier Line Canal to Wazirabad pond.

“Emergency pumping arrangements have also been in-

stalled in the dry riverbed, contributing nearly 40 MGD of additional raw water. Along with around 130 MGD being diverted from the canal system, these measures have helped sustain operations at the Wazirabad and Chandrawal water treatment plants,” he said.

Singh said that DJB has been able to maintain daily water production of around 900 MGD and continues to supply water to the vast majority of households across the city.

Maintaining that ensuring availability of drinking water for all residents is her government’s top priority, the CM directed the officials to take immediate action considering every incident of water leakage seriously.

“Every drop of water is precious and any kind of wastage will not be acceptable... DJB officials should personally monitor the complaints received daily and, if necessary, go to the field themselves to

verify the situation,” she said.

Officials said DJB has received 11,055 complaints regarding water scarcity through its helpline in the past week, of which over 8,500 have been resolved. Gupta also directed officials to ensure that all pending complaints related to water supply are addressed on priority. She asked the DJB to deploy an adequate number of water tankers in affected areas.

The CM said that DJB has roped in IIT Roorkee to conduct a study on water leakages. “A study on the feasibility of bringing water through a pipeline from Haryana is being conducted, so that water loss and leakage can be reduced... Moreover, dredging and desilting works are being undertaken in the Yamuna near Wazirabad, new water treatment plants are being established and additional borewells being developed in the Yamuna Khadar area,” she added.

2 NEW INTERMEDIARY RANKS IN THE OFFING

Delhi Police starts review of promotion policy, executive cadre structure

Proposal focuses on creating additional promotional avenues

Sakshi Chand
New Delhi, May 30

THE DELHI Police has initiated a comprehensive review of its promotion policy and executive cadre structure in a bid to address long-standing stagnation in promotions, correct structural imbalances, and create a more streamlined hierarchy for its personnel, according to an internal proposal accessed by *The Indian Express*.

As part of the proposed restructuring, Delhi Police has also suggested the introduction of two new intermediary ranks Senior Sub-Inspector (Sr SI) and Senior Inspector to ease bottlenecks in promotion and strengthen supervision within the force.

The move comes amid growing concerns over limited promotional avenues for personnel from the rank of constable to inspector, with the force acknowledging that the existing structure has not kept pace with the expanding demands of modern policing, including cybercrime investigation, women’s safety, traffic management, and economic offences. Officers said the proposed restructuring aims to create a balanced pyramidal cadre, improve career progression opportunities, and align the force’s promotion framework with present-day operational requirements.

As per the proposal, the rank of Sub-Inspector (Executive), which is currently a direct-entry post, would become

a promotional rank. A new non-gazetted rank of Sr SI would be created between the ranks of Sub-Inspector and Inspector. Senior SI’s would be tasked with leading investigations into sensitive cases, heading investigation teams independently, and serving as sub-sector in-charges during law and order deployments.

The proposal states that the creation of the Senior SI rank would be a functional upgradation and would not entail immediate financial benefits, with personnel receiving monetary upgradation through the first Modified Assured Career Progression (MACP) scheme after 10 years of cumulative service in Level 6 of the pay matrix.

The restructuring proposal also recommends the creation of a gazetted rank of Senior Inspector between Inspector and ACP. The rank is envisaged as a key supervisory position and a feeder cadre for promotions to ACP. Senior Inspectors would be eligible to serve as SHOs, supervise probe into murder, heinous crimes and cybercrime cases, and independently lead operational teams in specialised units such as Security, Crime and Special Branch. The proposal describes the rank as an operational bridge between ACP’s and lower ranks within the executive cadre.

The proposed Senior Inspector rank would be placed in Level 8 of the pay matrix, although the proposal notes that many officers reaching the post may have already received financial upgradation under the second MACP scheme.

Under the proposal, Delhi Police is also considering merging separate male and female executive cadres from the ranks of constable to sub-inspector into a single unified cadre.

The proposal links the restructuring to emerging policing requirements, particularly in cybercrime probes. The pro-

posals has argued that the increasing volume and complexity of cybercrime cases require a larger pool of officers at supervisory and investigative ranks.

“At present, many cybercrime probes are being handled by head constables, and the proposal notes that there is a need for a greater number of inspectors and other senior investigating officers to handle such cases and effectively present evidence and investigations before courts,” read the proposal.

As per the proposal, while 33 per cent reservation for women in direct recruitment at the levels of constable and sub-inspector has been in place since 2016, the sanctioned strength of male and female cadres continues to be maintained separately. Over time, officers say, this has led to an imbalance, with the number of women personnel exceeding sanctioned posts in the female cadre and corresponding vacancies remaining in the male cadre.

“The proposal cites instances where most male constables recruited in 2006 have already been promoted to the rank of head constable, while several women constables from the 2000 batch are yet to receive their first promotion because of a shortage of vacancies in the female cadre. Similar disparities exist at the sub-inspector level...,” the proposal states.

Expressing hope that the proposal will result in providing people in the force their rightful promotions, an officer said, “People who joined in 1995 or 1997 are still working on a look-after Inspector charge rank since 2014. Most of us will retire in 2027 so at least we should live with a rank for 5-6 months, the least we deserve.”

The proposal has been shared by Robin Hibu, Special Commissioner of Police, HR Division with David Lalrinsanga, Special CP Ops for comments.

PWD to carry out fire safety audit of all its buildings, submit report

Express News Service
New Delhi, May 30

THE PUBLIC Works Department (PWD) has asked all the concerned Executive Engineers of East, South and North zones to conduct a fire safety audit of all the buildings that fall under its jurisdiction and submit reports by next month, officials said on Saturday.

In a recently issued order to all the zones, the department said, “...all the concerned EEs (Electrical) of the concerned zone i.e. East, North, South Zone are hereby directed to conduct a fire audit of each building maintained by them under their jurisdiction and issue a certificate every year on or before 25th June.”

It also said that in case, any deficiency is observed, the same may kindly be made good under the maintenance works and adhere to all the building provisions as per the National Building Code of India (NBC) safety norms.

“This certificate is to be maintained in a separate file which shall be reviewed by higher officers from time to time,” the order stated.

Recently, Delhi Government also amended the fire regulations and rules, under which third party audits have been made mandatory for all buildings in the Capital.

The amended rules also mandate the installation of an IoT-based Automated Continuous Monitoring System (ACMS) in buildings to enable real-time monitoring of fire-fighting systems such as hydrant pumps, sprinklers, smoke detection panels, and staircase pressurisation fans.

Under the amended rules, auditors will be classified into three levels based on qualifications and experience. They will be assigned unique identification numbers and barred from certifying the same premises in two consecutive cycles to prevent conflict of interest and improve accountability.

Parvesh Sahib Singh files defamation suits against AAP’s Bharadwaj, seeks Rs 5 crore in damages

Sohini Ghosh
New Delhi, May 30

MINISTER PARVESH Sahib Singh has filed criminal and civil defamation suits against Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) leader Saurabh Bharadwaj, seeking damages to the tune of Rs 5 crores, arguing that the former AAP minister’s “false” social media posts allegedly implied that Singh misused his official position in favour of accused in a Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) case.

This comes against the backdrop of the AAP Delhi unit chief already facing criminal contempt proceedings before the Delhi High Court in the excise policy case.

On May 20, Sahib filed a criminal defamation complaint before a magistrate court in Delhi, accusing Bharadwaj of publishing “false, malicious and highly defamatory tweets” on May 15 and 16.

In the said tweets, Singh says, Bharadwaj had “falsely alleged that (Singh) misused his position as a Minister to appoint his alleged associate as a Trustee in a private school Trust worth nearly Rs 500 crores” and that Singh exercised influence in favour of the employees of the school, who are accused in a POCSO case.

Singh is seeking that Bharadwaj be prosecuted for criminal defamation under various provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS), even as

Singh has moved court accusing Bharadwaj of publishing “false, malicious and highly defamatory tweets”

the magistrate court on May 22 fixed the matter for examination of Singh and his witnesses on June 9 and 11.

Simultaneously, the minister has also moved Delhi High Court with a civil defamation suit, seeking damages to the tune of Rs 5 crores from Bharadwaj.

The civil defamation suit was listed before the Judicial-side Joint Registrar Gagandeep Jindal on May 25, who has issued summons to the AAP leader. Taking objection to Bharadwaj’s tweets on social media platform X (formerly Twitter), Singh has stated in the suit that the same were “published knowing or having reason to believe that they would harm his reputation in the eyes of the public, peers, media, and society at large.”

Singh alleged that the AAP leader “for his own political benefit by way of cheap publicity, with wilful disregard for the true and correct facts, sought to contrive a connection” between the BJP leader and his purported associate appointed in the school trust.

Delhi’s first pet park near Jangpura-Def Col flyover this yr

New Delhi: Delhi will get its first dedicated pet park later this year, as the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) revives a nearly two-year-long-pending project in Jangpura, which has remained non-operational since its initial development, officials said on Saturday.

Fresh tenders for the facility, spread across around 1.5 acres near the Jangpura-Defence Colony flyover, were issued earlier this month.

The civic body is appointing a private operator under the public-private partnership (PPP) model who will manage the facility and develop additional amenities.

“Last time, we could not find a suitable second party to carry out the operations of the project. This time, we are certain that an agency will be finalised within the next two to three weeks,” an MCD official told PTI.

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2.	New Delhi	CAW Cell, Room no 104, 1st floor PS Mandir Marg, New Delhi District	9971814565
3.	East	CAW Cell, DCP Office, Mandawali Fazalpur, Gazipur, IP Extension, New Delhi	9540426425
4.	North East	CAW Cell, Old Building of R.S. Nand Nagri, Delhi-110093	8800740099
5.	Central	CAW Cell, 1st Floor, Police Station Kamla Market, Near Girdhar Lal Hospital, New Delhi	9649930520
6.	North	CAW Cell, PS Subzi Mandi, Ground Floor, Near Hindu Rao Hospital, Delhi	7678696088
7.	South East	CAW Cell, Sri Niwas Puri Police Post, Amar Colony, New Delhi	8178985651 8708464944
8.	Rohini	CAW Cell, P.S. Begumpur, Rohini, New Delhi	9911331131
9.	South	CAW Cell South, Ashok Vihar, Saket (Behind Anupam PVR)	99111 65959
10.	Dwarka	CAW Cell, PS Dabri, 1st Floor, New Building, Delhi	9971757628
11.	Shahdara	CAW Cell, 123, Block F, Dilshad Garden, Delhi-110095	98113 57769
12.	Outer	CAW Cell, 2nd Floor, PP Bakkarwala JJ Colony, (PS Mundka), Delhi-110041	9999516034
13.	South West	CAW Cell, 2nd floor, PS Delhi Cantt.	9650265605
14.	West	CAW Cell, 1st Floor, Police Station Kirti Nagar, Near Timber Market, New Delhi	6828401611
15.	North West	CAW Cell, Near M2K Cinema, Rani Bagh, Delhi	9213999334
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LG directs DDA to fix issues in Civil Lines park

New Delhi: Delhi LG Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Saturday directed Delhi Development Authority (DDA) officials to resolve maintenance-related issues at Bonta Park in Kamla Nehru Ridge near the Civil Lines area.

The LG visited the park and reviewed various facilities at the park, including open-air fitness infrastructure, yoga and meditation spaces, and recreational areas. He also interacted with people, fitness enthusiasts, senior citizens and residents who raised some concerns.

PTI

RESIDENTS SAY NO PRIOR NOTICE WAS ISSUED

‘Illegal’ mosque & temple razed in Faridabad for RRTS corridor

Abhimanyu Hazarika
Faridabad, May 30

THE MUNICIPAL Corporation of Faridabad (MCF) on Saturday carried out a major demolition drive in the city's New Industrial Township (NIT), razing alleged illegal religious structures, including a mosque and a temple, to clear the right of way for crucial infrastructure projects, said officials.

These constructions directly obstructed the alignment of the upcoming Gurgaon-Faridabad-Noida Namoo Bharat Regional Rapid Transit System (RRTS) corridor and a proposed elevated road project, they added.

The operation, which was carried out on the directives of the National Green Tribunal, began at 4 am amid heavy police deployment. The Home department had ordered a temporary suspension of mobile Internet, bulk SMS, and dongle services within a 1-km radius of the demolition site.

The mosque called Jama Masjid, built on 700 sq yard at Masjid Chowk in NIT-3, was at least 40 years old.

"The Jama Masjid was built in the 1970s and saw daily prayers. There was also a madrasa inside," Gurugram Imam Sangathan chief Mufti Abdul Haseeb Qasmi told *The Indian Express*. "The local imam told me no prior notices regarding the demolition were issued," he added.

Additional Municipal Commissioner Paramjeet Chahal told *The Indian Express* that the drive "was long overdue". He also denied that notices were not served before the demolition was carried out.

"The land on which the encroachments had come up belonged to the government... the



During the demolition drive in Faridabad on Saturday. ANI

land had been transferred to the civic body. We have been pasting notices on such properties for a while now," he said.

"We restricted the drive to one mosque, one small Shiv temple that was 400 m away from the mosque, and some shops. We will update the High Court, Supreme Court and the NGT since the drive was undertaken in compliance with their directions," he added.

A senior civic official, who did not wish to be named, said, "All due process was followed and multiple notices were issued. The masjid was an encroachment on a public road, and the temple was built on a green belt."

"Duty magistrates were deployed and the drive wrapped up peacefully by 6 pm, though we have asked the police and the administration to station personnel at the area overnight to maintain law and order."

Asked why the drive was undertaken, the official said, "The route fell under the RRTS' proposed alignment and needed to be cleared."

The police began barricading the area around Masjid Chowk at 2 am, completely restricting civilian and vehicular movement before earth-mov-

ing machines were deployed, a Faridabad Police spokesperson said.

Nuh Congress MLA Aftab Ahmed, who visited the site, condemned the drive. "It was done to target members of the minority community and destroy the mosque. The mosque is not located on the main road. They had not sent notices... The last notice was sent a year ago, saying that demolitions will take place. At that time, the panchayat had intervened."

"They put the imam and his son and several others under house arrest... or detained them... Now, just to maintain peace, they have destroyed a Shiv temple, which was built on the green belt," he alleged.

The police, however, denied the allegations. "We did not detain or put anyone on house arrest. The land belongs to the civic body and we were following orders... The mosque was located on the public road and the temple was built on the green belt," Faridabad Police spokesperson Yashpal Yadav said.

Civic officials said the anti-encroachment drive in the area will continue to ensure the timely completion of infrastructure works.

Building collapses near Saket, some students feared trapped, 12 rescued

Pragynesh & Sakshi Chand
New Delhi, May 30

AROUND 12 people were rescued and some, including students, are feared trapped, after a four-storey building collapsed at Saidulajab near Saket Metro station on Saturday night.

Delhi Fire Services (DFS) officers said that a fifth floor was under construction in the building, which also housed a coaching centre for medical students.

About 740 pm, as the building collapsed, the debris fell on an adjacent tin shed structure that worked as a makeshift canteen for the students, trapping some of the students.

The DFS said a call regarding the collapse was received at 744 pm. Initially, three tenders and one incident response team were rushed to the spot. Later, additional resources, including another tender and a light van, were deployed to assist in the search and rescue efforts.

"The ground+3 floor building completely collapsed on the adjacent tin shed canteen. Some students who were having dinner there got trapped under the debris," the DFS said in a statement, adding that rescue operations will continue late into the night.

Shah Zafar, a student who had joined the coaching centre 10 days ago, said he was right in front of the building when it suddenly collapsed. "Many students were coming down the stairs when it happened. I escaped by a couple of seconds," he recalled.

Another student questioned the condition of the structure. "Many students study here. I don't understand how people were working in



such a poorly maintained building. If this had happened during office hours, 200-300 people could have died," he said.

Most of the damage was concentrated in the building, which also housed a corporate office on the first floor.

"We don't know how old the building is, but it is in a poor condition," said Saurav (23), who got admission in the coaching centre about four

months ago.

Near the building, Tara (40) waited for news of her relative — the woman who ran the canteen. "She had started the mess with her husband and son about a year ago. When the building collapsed, she initially tried to run. But when she saw some of the students got stuck under debris, she went to help them and herself got trapped."

A young worker who worked at the canteen said res-



Heaps of concrete lie at the site of the building collapse in Saidulajab on Saturday. A crowd gathers at the site and an ambulance assists the injured. VIVEK YADAV & ABHINAV SAHA

cue personnel had not ruled out the possibility of more people being trapped. "Three or four people have been brought out safely, but rescue teams are still searching," he said.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said on Saturday that every possible effort is being made to safely rescue those trapped in the building collapse near Saket Metro station.

Maintaining that the situ-

ation is being closely monitored, Gupta posted on X: "Teams from NDRF, Delhi Fire Services, Delhi Police, DDMA, MCD, CATS and Civil Defence are carrying out rescue operations on a war footing."

She said that every effort is being made to rescue those trapped and to provide immediate assistance to the affected families, adding that safety and well-being of every citizen remain the highest priority.

Paralympic athlete shot dead, 1 held

Express News Service
Ghaziabad, May 30

BODY OF Chirag Tyagi, a Paralympic athlete was found lying at Sai Kunj in Ghaziabad on Saturday, police said, adding that another paralympic athlete Yash Khatik has been arrested in connection with the case.

Deputy Commissioner of Police (City and Trans Hindon), Dhawal Jaiswal said the case came to light after 3 pm on Saturday when police received information about a body lying at Sai Kunj.

The deceased was identified as Chirag Tyagi, a Paralympic athlete, DCP Jaiswal said, adding that based on CCTV footage, the accused was arrested.

Jaiswal said Yash allegedly told police that he used to practice along with Chirag. Earlier, both used to participate in competitions under the blind athletics category. "Chirag had submitted a complaint regarding Yash's document verification on the basis of which his qualification got cancelled. This made Yash upset and in order to take revenge he allegedly shot Chirag with a pistol," the DCP added.

Shops shut, heavy police presence in Ghaziabad locality as teenager dies after he was stabbed

Drishhti Jain
Ghaziabad, May 30

STREETS OF Khoda in Ghaziabad saw heavy police deployment on Saturday, with barricades placed at the entrance of the narrow lane where a 16-year-old boy, who died after being allegedly stabbed on Thursday amid an altercation, lived with his family.

The boy succumbed to his injuries during treatment on Friday, police said.

Assistant Commissioner of Police (Indirapuram) Abhishek Srivastava said three persons have been arrested for murder. The victim and the accused knew each other, police said, adding that they belonged to different communities.

At his home, the boy's mother — the only earning member of the family — recalled speaking to her son shortly before he was allegedly attacked.

She said her son had stepped out on Thursday morning in search of work. "He had recently cleared Class 10. He said he will work for two months before school resumes. My husband had passed away two years ago due to illness and



Policemen deployed in the locality on Saturday. AMIT MEHRA

my eldest son, who is 23-years-old, is mentally challenged," she told *The Indian Express*.

"He would have turned 17 on September 30... When I spoke to him around noon, he said he could not find work because everything was shut due to Bakrid. Suddenly, I heard shouting on the phone, but he assured me everything was fine," she said.

Police said he was admitted to a local hospital with stab wounds and was later referred to a private hospital in Noida where he died on Friday.

Majority of shops in the locality have been shut since Thursday.

Originally from Etah in Uttar Pradesh, the family moved to Ghaziabad around 17 years ago.

"I had brought him here when he was just three months old, and now he has left from the same lane forever," said Saroj, who worked at a cloth manufacturing unit in Noida.

The boy's sister, who is married, described him as "well-mannered and decent". "He never fought with people and knew how to conduct himself. I met him just two days ago,"

she said.

Her husband said that the two friends of the boy who were with him when the incident took place have claimed that they knew the accused. "They said the accused had called them to celebrate Bakrid. One of the accused had put hand around the teen's shoulder and said 'let's end the fight'. They then attacked him," he alleged.

According to PTI, UP Deputy Chief Minister Keshav Prasad Maurya told reporters in Lucknow, "The killer(s) will be given capital punishment, and they will not be spared. The government is very serious about law and order, and the guilty will not be spared."

BSP chief Mayawati, meanwhile, termed the incident as "extremely tragic and worrying". In a post on X, Mayawati said the government and the administration must take effective steps to prevent such incidents, and demanded that the culprits be brought to justice.

She also cautioned that such crimes could have wider repercussions with the state heading to polls next year, and urged the government to remain fully vigilant.



A street in Delhi after rain on Saturday. SHREYA SINGHA

Brief respite from heat as thunderstorm, rain bring down temperature

Express News Service
New Delhi, May 30

• Skywatch



Forecast: May 31, 2026

Partly cloudy sky becoming generally cloudy sky; a spell of very light to light rain

MAX: 36-38

2°C below normal

MIN: 22-24

4.6°C above normal

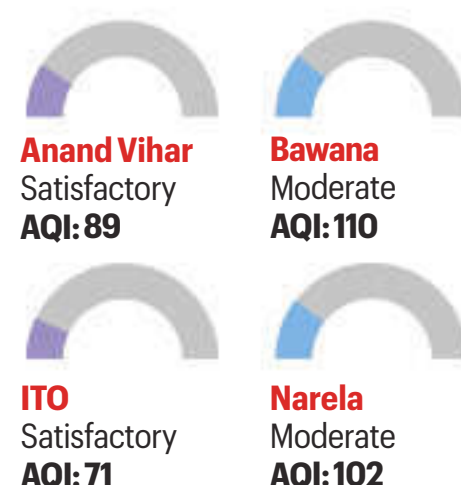
• Sunrise: 5:24 AM (June 1)

• Sunset: 7:14 PM (May 31)

• Moonrise: 6:32 PM (May 31)

• Moonset: 5:40 AM (June 1)

• AQITracker



The IMD issued multiple alerts through the afternoon on Saturday for thunderstorms, squally winds and rains. Palam recorded the strongest gust among the Delhi stations at 70 kmph, followed by Pragati Maidan at 59 kmph and Pusa at 54 kmph. Safdarjung recorded a maximum wind speed of 38 kmph while Lodi Road and Mayur Vihar recorded 33 kmph.

According to the IMD's evening weather bulletin, very light to light rain, thunderstorm and lightning accompanied by gusty winds occurred at many places over Delhi during the day. South-easterly winds prevailed at 20-25 kmph, gusting to 59 kmph over the city.

The storm activity also led to a dip in day temperatures. Safdarjung, Delhi's base station, recorded a maximum of 37.2 degrees Celsius, which was 3.2 degrees Celsius below normal.

The Capital recorded an air quality index (AQI) of 85 (satisfactory) on Saturday.

The IMD said maximum temperatures had fallen by 2-8°C over Rajasthan, Punjab, Haryana, Chandigarh, Delhi and adjoining southwest Uttar Pradesh because of thunderstorm activity over northwest India.

The relief, however, may be

temporary as the IMD forecast said there would be no large change in maximum temperatures during the next 48 hours, followed by a gradual rise of 4-6 degrees Celsius over the subsequent five days.

• OFFICER'S DAUGHTER RAPED AND MURDERED BY FORMER DOMESTIC HELP

Uncle helped Meena repay Rs 75,000 loan he owed in IRS officer's locality before he returned to steal: Police probe

Pragynesh
New Delhi, May 30

ABOUT A month before he allegedly raped and murdered the 22-year-old daughter of an IRS officer in Southeast Delhi on April 22, Rahul Meena (23) had left the officer's house where he worked as a domestic help after borrowing Rs 75,000 from local vendors and a security guard. He was, however, brought back to Delhi from Rajgarh village in Rajasthan's Alwar district by his uncle after he, police said, arranged the money for Meena to repay the debt.

Meena, however, did not return the money but instead used Rs 15,000 from the amount

to again invest in online gaming. He also continued to work at the IRS officer's house.

According to police, Meena's gaming addiction continued even after he was eventually sacked by the officer's family on March 15 following reports of him taking loans from people in the neighbourhood and he returned to his village.

He allegedly again borrowed Rs 90,000 from a man in his village. The man's wife later filed a rape complaint against Meena, alleging that he sexually assaulted her the night before he travelled to Delhi and allegedly raped the IRS officer's daughter, a IIT graduate and UPSC aspirant.



CCTV footage of Rahul Meena on the day of the murder.

Meena's uncle, who worked at a government office in Rajasthan, had recommended Rahul for a job when the IRS officer had visited the office last year, police have said.

"After joining work at the

IRS officer's house last year, Rahul Meena accumulated a debt of Rs 75,000 from local vendors and a guard deployed at a building due to his addiction to online gaming. He then fled to his village in March this

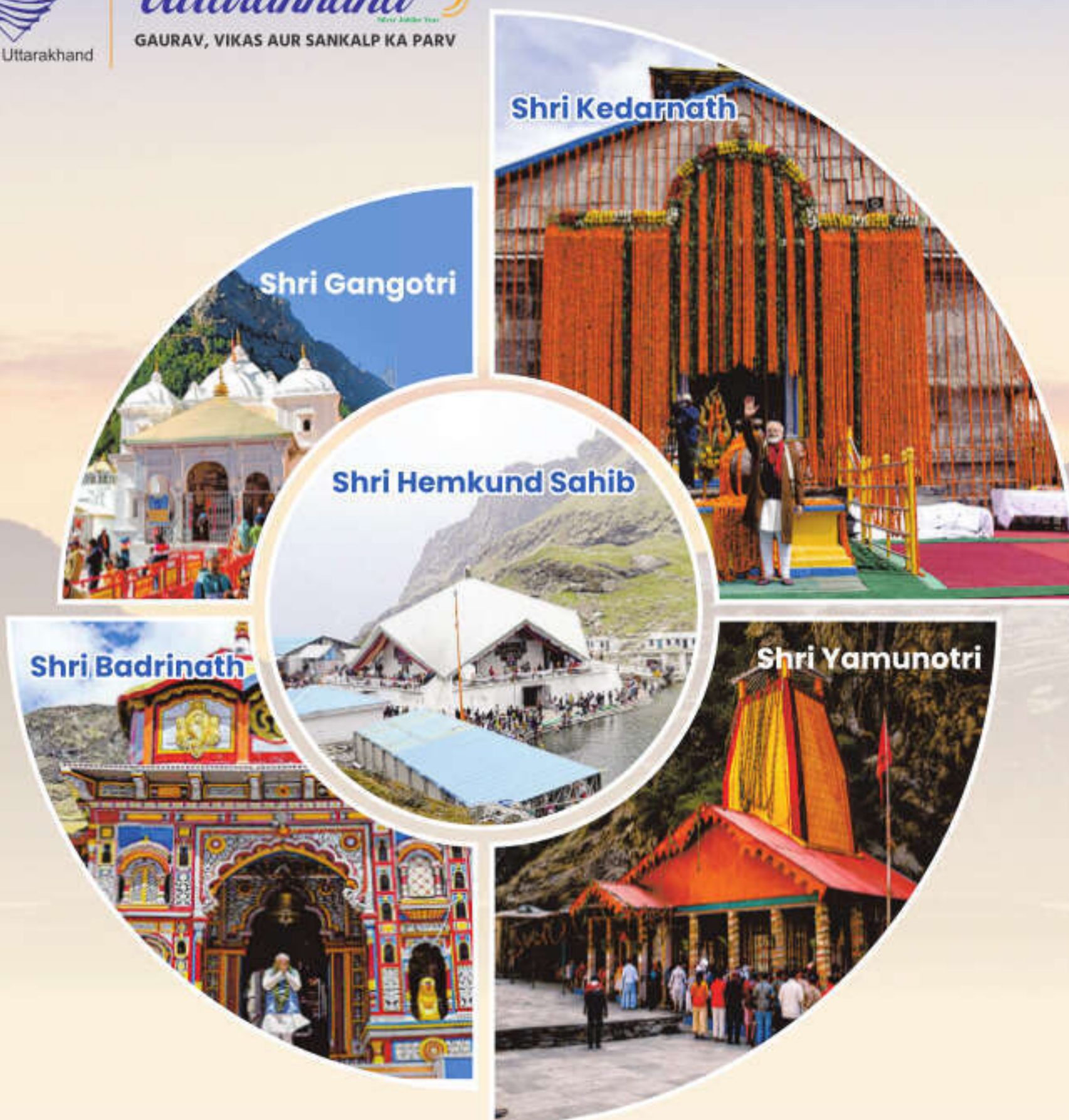
year," said an officer.

The IRS officer then allegedly asked Meena's uncle to bring him back and ensure that the money was returned.

"On March 15, the uncle arranged the money and brought him back to Delhi. But Rahul again took Rs 15,000 from the amount and used it in online poker," the officer said.

"The uncle again gave him another Rs 15,000. Meena then finally repaid the vendors in the presence of the IRS officer. He was also immediately removed from the job," the officer added. By then Meena had worked for around 18 months for the family.

Police said Meena returned to his village but his financial



SPIRITUAL AND NATURAL ATTRACTIONS NEAR THE CHAR DHAM ROUTE

1 Near Yamunotri

Janki Chatti & Hanuman Chatti, Kharsali Village, Saptarishi Kund, Lakhamandal, Kedarkantha Trek, Rana Chatti.

2 Near Kedarnath

Bhairavnath Temple, Vasuki Tal, Gaurikund, Triyuginarayan Temple, Chopta - Tungnath - Chandra Shila, Deoria Tal.

3 Near Gangotri

Gaumukh Trek, Bhojbas & Tapovan, Surya Kund & Gauri Kund, Harsil Valley, Mukhimath (Mukhba), Dayara Bugyal Trek, Gartang Gali, Kashi Vishwanath Temple (Uttarkashi), Nachiketa Tal & Dodital.

4 Near Badrinath

Mana Village, Vyas Gufa & Ganesh Gufa, Bhimsila, Auli, Valley of Flowers, Vasudhara Falls, Charanpaduka, Tapt Kund & Narad Kund, Jyotirmath (Joshimath), Satopanth Lake, Pandukeshwar, Adibadri Temple, Hemkund Sahib.



Ganesha Temple
Dodital Uttarkashi



Shani Temple
Kharsali Uttarkashi



Kandolia Temple
Pauri Garhwal



Kartik Swamy Temple
Rudrapur



Jagannath Temple
Uttarkashi



Jawalpa Devi Temple
Pauri Garhwal



Gopinath Temple
Gopeshwar, Chamoli



Kamleshwar Mahadev Temple
Srinagar Pauri Garhwal



Katarmal Sun Temple
Almora



Jageshwar Dham
Almora



Golu Devta Temple
Almora



Dunagiri Temple
Dwarahat, Almora

Important Information

Mandatory Registration: Registration is compulsory before commencing the Yatra.
Verify Contact Details: Please ensure you enter the correct mobile number during registration.
Be Prepared for Weather: Carry adequate woolen clothes, an umbrella, and a raincoat.
Accurate Health Data: Provide precise health information during the registration process.
Senior Citizen Advisory: Senior citizens are advised to undergo a medical check-up before starting the journey.
Medication: If you are on prescribed medication, carry a sufficient stock of your medicines.
Acclimatisation: Take frequent breaks at various transit points along the route to acclimatize to the high-altitude climate.
Health First: If you feel unwell, please do not proceed with the journey.
Beware of Scams: Avoid unauthorised individuals claiming to facilitate 'Darshan' at the shrines.
Keep Tracks Clean: Cooperate with us in keeping the pilgrimage routes clean; do not litter.
Safe Driving: Maintain controlled vehicle speed and park only in designated parking areas.
No Plastic: Strictly avoid the use of single-use plastic.



The Honourable Prime Minister has termed the third decade of the 21st century as the 'Decade of Uttarakhand.' In line with the Prime Minister's vision, we are working with an 'unwavering commitment' (Vikalp Rahit Sankalp) to make the state an ideal state in every field.

Pushkar Singh Dhami, Chief Minister, Uttarakhand

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Devbhoomi
Uttarakhand

VIKAS BHI, VIRASAT BHI

Divine and Majestic

Chardham
Yatra

**A WARM WELCOME
 TO ALL DEVOTEES**



My dear Countrymen,

The sacred Chardham Yatra has commenced in the holy land of Devbhoomi Uttarakhand. This divine pilgrimage to the four shrines, including the darshan of Baba Kedar, is a magnificent celebration of India's eternal (Sanatan) cultural consciousness. Jagadguru Adi Shankaracharya gave a new direction to Indian culture through his pilgrimages to Badrinath and Kedarnath. Similarly, Jagadguru Ramanujacharya and Jagadguru Madhvacharya also visited Badrinath to enrich their spiritual philosophies.

Even today, these four shrines nestled in the lap of the Himalayas remain divine centers of our eternal faith and belief. Every year, people belonging to diverse languages, traditions, and cultures come here, further strengthening the spirit of 'Ek Bharat, Shreshtha Bharat'. This year's Yatra is an extension of that very tradition.

Our scriptures state:

अग्निष्टोमादिभिर्यज्ञैरिष्टा विपुलदक्षिणे।
 न तत्फलमवाप्नोति तीर्थभिर्गमनेन यत्॥

Meaning: The immense merit (Punya) earned through grand Yagyas (sacrificial rituals) and charity is profound. However, the merit obtained through a pilgrimage (Tirtha Yatra) is even greater than that gained through those rituals.

In the resolve for a 'Viksit Bharat' (Developed India), the role of a 'Viksit Uttarakhand' is extremely vital. A few years ago, at the gateway of Baba Kedar, I had said that this decade would be the 'Decade of Uttarakhand'. Today, the progress of Uttarakhand is turning that belief into reality. Uttarakhand is setting new benchmarks in all three sectors: tourism, spirituality, and economic growth.

The great ritual of development (Vikas ka Mahayagya) that has been underway in Uttarakhand for the past few years has made the Chardham Yatra more accessible, safer, and divine than ever before. This is providing great convenience to the visiting devotees, saints, and tourists. In all these efforts, every care is being taken to preserve the natural beauty of Uttarakhand.

I would also urge every guest visiting Uttarakhand to truly enjoy this new experience. During your journey, I encourage all travellers to observe a "Digital Fast" and strive to live within the natural beauty of Uttarakhand. This will provide you with a unique sense of satisfaction.

Historically, we have always traveled from our homes to Devbhoomi for the Chardham Yatra with a specific resolve. In this spirit, I wish to urge you to take Five Resolves (Panch Sankalp):

First Resolve - Cleanliness is Paramount: Maintain cleanliness within and around the shrines. Contribute your part to keeping the rivers clean. Take a pledge for a journey free of single-use plastic and uphold the dignity of this sacred land.

Second Resolve - Sensitivity towards Nature and Environment: Be sensitive toward this divine Himalayan land. While maintaining the balance of nature, contribute to environmental conservation through initiatives like 'Ek Ped Maa Ke Naam' (A Tree in Mother's Name).

Third Resolve - Emphasis on Service, Cooperation, and Unity: Since ancient times, our pilgrimages have been a medium for universal service and social harmony. Even today, people serve pilgrims with this same spirit. I urge every pilgrim visiting the Chardham to perform at least one act of service every day of their journey. Help your fellow travellers and connect with people coming from different parts of the country. By participating in their traditions, strengthen the spirit of 'Ek Bharat, Shreshtha Bharat' through this pilgrimage.

Fourth Resolve - Promoting 'Vocal for Local': From the time you leave your home until you return, ensure that you spend at least five percent of your total travel budget on purchasing local products. Even if a local item is not immediately needed in this season, try to buy it for future use.

Fifth Resolve - Adherence to Discipline, Safety, and Decorum: Follow the rules of the journey and traffic instructions. As a responsible and alert citizen, make this pilgrimage safe and accessible. Let us ensure that our journey does not cause any inconvenience to the people involved in the organisation and management of this Yatra.

In recent years, a large number of creators and influencers have started visiting the Chardham. I urge all of you to make an effort to share the local stories of Uttarakhand and its small, unique traditions with the masses.

May the blessings of Baba Kedar and all the four shrines infuse your life with new energy, new inspiration, and new resolutions. This is my wish for you.

My heartiest best wishes to all of you for a successful, safe, divine, and soulful journey.

Yours

नरेंद्र मोदी
 Narendra Modi



Panch Kedar

1. Kedarnath
2. Tungnath
3. Rudranath
4. Madhmaheshwar
5. Kalpeswar

Panch Prayag

1. Devprayag
2. Rudraprayag
3. Karnprayag
4. Nandprayag
5. Vishnuprayag

Panch Badri

1. Vishal Badri
2. Yogdarshan Badri
3. Bhavya Badri
4. Vradha Badri
5. Aadi Badri

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 To Avoid any Fraud
www.heliyatra.irctc.co.in**

During the Chardham Yatra, you can also visit and experience the divine Panch Kedar, Panch Prayag and Panch Badri. In the Panch Badri, Lord Vishnu is worshipped in various unique forms

Cong’s move to bring Chodankar back to helm Goa unit sparks discontent



As the AICC in charge of Tamil Nadu, Girish Chodankar was instrumental in the post-poll alliance with the TVK

Asad Rehman
New Delhi, May 30

THE AICC leadership’s move Friday to appoint Girish Chodankar as the new Goa Pradesh Congress Committee (GPCC) president, replacing Amit Patkar, has resulted in rumblings in the state party unit just months ahead of the state Assembly elections slated for February 2027.

The AICC also appointed three new state working presidents – including M K Shaikh, Altone D’Costa and Carlos Alvares Ferreira – while naming Datta D Naik as the treasurer. Patkar’s replacement is being seen in Congress circles as a move reflective of the leadership’s “confidence” in Chodankar, who as the AICC in charge of Tamil Nadu was instrumental in the party stitching up a post-poll alliance there with the Vijay-led Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) following the latter’s victory on its debut election.

However, several Goa Congress leaders were surprised by the AICC’s bid to bring Chodankar back as the GPCC chief now, over three years after he had resigned from the same post in 2022 after the party’s debacle in the state elections. The Congress had then won 11 seats in the 40-member Goa Assembly as against the incumbent BJP’s 20.

Patkar is said to have made his “resentment” clear to the Congress leadership, skipping the event at the GPCC office in Panjim Saturday, where Chodankar took charge as the new party chief. According to party sources, AICC in charge for Goa Manikrao Thakre invited Patkar for the event, but he said he would not be able to attend it. Since Friday night, Patkar has been holding meetings with his supporters to chalk out his future course of action, sources said. Those close to Patkar, who was appointed Chodankar’s successor soon after his resignation in 2022, told *The Indian Express* that they will “convince” him to form a new party.

30 lakh migrants may miss Odisha SIR: BJD to EC

Sujit Bisoyi
Bhubaneswar, May 30

AS THE Special Intensive Revision (SIR) got underway in Odisha Saturday, the Opposition Biju Janata Dal (BJD) voiced concerns over the difficulties lakhs of migrant workers from the state may face during the process.

As part of the exercise, over 45,000 booth level officers began door-to-door visits across the state Saturday, which will continue till June 28. The draft electoral roll will be published on July 5, following which the

MORE THAN HALF MEMBERS IN OUTGOING SIDDARAMAIAH MINISTRY MAY BE DROPPED

Stage set for Shivakumar swearing-in as CM on June 3; rejigs on the cards

Akram M
Bengaluru, May 30

AS EXPECTED, the Karnataka Congress Legislature Party (CLP) on Saturday unanimously elected D K Shivakumar as its leader, paving the way for the Deputy Chief Minister to be elevated to the Chief Minister’s position.

The CLP’s move came two days after CM Siddaramaiah stepped down from his post following the Congress high command’s directive. Veteran party leader Siddaramaiah, who has already become the longest-serving CM of Karnataka, re-signed as part of a power-sharing agreement between him and Shivakumar in May 2023, when the party stormed to power by clinching the Karnataka Assembly polls.

The 64-year-old Vokkaliga leader, Shivakumar has also been the state Congress president for several years.

Addressing media persons following the CLP meeting, All India Congress Committee (AICC) general secretary (organisation) K C Venugopal, accompanied by AICC general secretary in charge of Karnataka Randeep Surjewala, said that the CLP “unanimously authorised Congress high command to propose a leader for CLP. The Congress high com-



Karnataka’s outgoing CM Siddaramaiah with his successor D K Shivakumar and AICC general secretary (organisation) K C Venugopal at Vidhana Soudha in Bengaluru on Saturday

mand suggested the name of D K Shivakumar as the leader of CLP.”

Siddaramaiah proposed the name of Shivakumar, which was seconded by G Parameshwara, Venugopal said, adding that the new CM will take oath along with a new set of Cabinet ministers. “Everybody thought that this transition would cause trouble for the Congress party. Everybody anticipated that a big shake is going to happen in Congress,” he said, adding that the transition happened “smoothly” as the “Congress is like a family”.

“Under the guidance of AICC president Mallikarjun Kharge and (Congress leader) Sonia Gandhi, smooth transition of power has happened in Karnataka. Therefore, now onwards, under the leadership of Shivakumar and support of Siddaramaiah, Congress is going to return to power in 2028,” Venugopal said.

Both Venugopal and Surjewala were sent by the AICC leadership as its observers for the CLP meeting following which Shivakumar led a party delegation, comprising Siddaramaiah and several Congress

legislators, to meet Governor Thaawarchand Gehlot at the Lok Bhavan to stake claim to form his government. The Governor invited Shivakumar to take oath as the CM on June 3 along with his new ministers.

According to sources, the June 3 date was decided by Shivakumar following consultations with his astrologers. Earlier in the day, he also visited the Kadasiddeshwara Mutt of which he is a devotee.

Ahead of the swearing-in ceremony, there are speculations that up to four Deputy CMs may be appointed in the new Shivakumar ministry. However, the Congress leadership has yet to take a call on the issue. Shivakumar is also learnt to have opposed the appointment of the Deputy CMs in his ministry.

Congress sources told *The Indian Express* that more than half the ministers in the outgoing Siddaramaiah Cabinet may be dropped to make way for new faces. The party is said to be focusing on younger legislators to fill the Cabinet berths.

Sources said that senior legislator K J George, who was energy minister in the Siddaramaiah government is “not keen” to be part of the Shivakumar Cabinet. He is likely to be elected to the Rajya Sabha in

the upcoming elections.

Other Congress MLAs such as G Parameshwara, H K Patil, Krishna Byre Gowda and Priyank Kharge are set to be part of the Shivakumar Cabinet, said sources. The new faces to be inducted into the Cabinet could include NA Haaris, Mahantesh Kaujalgi, Srinivas Mane and Roopakala Shashidhar, among others.

Shivakumar is expected to meet Mallikarjun Kharge and Leader of Opposition (LoP) in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi in Delhi over the next couple of days to finalise his Cabinet. While a third of the ministerial berths are likely to go to Siddaramaiah’s loyalists, another third would be bagged by the supporters of Shivakumar, with the high command picking faces for the remaining posts, sources said.

Shivakumar’s elevation as the CM has also cleared the decks for appointment of a new Karnataka Pradesh Congress Committee (KPCC) president in the coming days. Senior party leader Satish Jarkiholi, a tribal heavyweight considered a front-runner for the KPCC president’s post, is also learnt to have sought a ministerial berth. There are also talks that Parameshwara may return as the KPCC chief for a second party stint.

Punjab & Haryana HC suspends Kaithal judge, no reason given

Jagpreet Singh Sandhu
Chandigarh, May 30

THE PUNJAB and Haryana High Court has suspended judicial officer Rajeev Goyal, who was posted as Additional District and Sessions Judge, Kaithal district court. The suspension order did not specify any reason.

The one-page order, issued by the High Court’s Registrar General, however, indicates that it pertains to the period when Goyal was posted as Special Judge, CBI Court at Panchkula.

The order issued by the Registrar General, dated May 29, reads: “Hon’ble the Chief Justice and Judges, in exercise of powers under Article 225 of the Constitution of India read with Rule 4(b) of the Haryana Civil Services (Punishment and Appeal) Rules, 2016, have been pleased to place Sh. Rajeev Goyal, the then Special Judge, CBI Court (Panchkula) now posted as Additional District and Sessions Judge, Kaithal under suspension with immediate effect in contemplation of initiation of disciplinary proceedings against the Officer.”

“During the period of suspension, the headquarters of Sh. Rajeev Goyal will be at Kaithal. He will not leave the headquarters during this period

without the prior permission of the District and Sessions Judge, Kaithal. Sh. Rajeev Goyal will draw subsistence allowance as an equal to the leave salary, which he would have drawn had he been on leave on half pay, and in addition other allowances, if admissible, on the basis of such leave salary, in view of rules under Chapter VII of Haryana Civil Service (General) Rules, 2016, from the date of his suspension,” read the order.

Goyal’s predecessor Sudhir Parmar, the then Special Judge, CBI Court at Panchkula, was also placed under suspension by the High Court in April 2023, following raids by the Haryana’s Anti-Corruption Bureau at his residence.

The raids at Parmar’s residence were prompted by allegations of corruption and a purported audio recording in which it was alleged that he was allegedly showing favouritism to real-estate developers.

The CBI court at Panchkula holds judicial trial in all the cases that the Central Bureau of Investigation investigates across Haryana.

Following Parmar’s suspension, Goyal took over the CBI Court as Special Judge. On April 23, 2026, Goyal was transferred to Kaithal as Additional District and Sessions Judge.

Fair rolls lead to fair polls, says CEC Kumar

Express News Service
New Delhi, May 30

DAYS AFTER the Supreme Court ruled that the Election Commission’s Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls was constitutional, Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar on Saturday said “fair rolls lead to fair polls”.

In his first public remarks after the apex court pronounced its judgment on Wednesday, Kumar underlined the importance of “fair” electoral rolls. He was addressing a conference of legal counsels representing the poll panel, at the EC’s India International Institute of Democracy and Election Management (IIDEM) in Dwarka.

“Fair rolls lead to fair polls. That’s the moment today and India is in it,” Kumar said.

The conference began on Saturday with briefings by EC officials on “electoral roll management, SIR, and polling and counting procedures, showcasing the transparency, accuracy and safeguards that uphold the integrity of India’s electoral process,” the EC said in a post on X. Kumar, along with Election Commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi, addressed the legal counsels.

The EC had on June 24, 2025 ordered the SIR of electoral rolls across the country, breaking from the practice of the past 20 years where rolls were summarily revised annually and before each election. In an intensive revision, the rolls are prepared afresh. The EC’s order and the unprecedented method adopted by it had been challenged in the Supreme Court.

5.5 LAKH OF 1.79 CR RATION CARD HOLDERS DROPPED

Bihar ration card list trimmed by 3% using SIR and income data

Santosh Singh
Patna, May 30

JUST OVER 3% of Bihar ration card holders have been removed after the matching of their names against the state electoral roll prepared after the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) exercise earlier this year, and after a cross-verification exercise by the Centre that started in 2025.

Bihar Food and Consumer Protection Minister Ashok Choudhary told *The Indian Express* that they had completed “97.56% of the exercise”. “Out of 8,19,888 cards were flagged, 5,57,278 were marked for deletion while 2,59,197 were marked for retention,” he said.

According to data from the state government, 5.5 lakh people of the state’s 1.79 crore ration card holders have been dropped from the ration card list, with death, absence of mandatory KYC, or income criteria cited as the chief reasons.

Deaths, migration and duplication were behind 99% of the SIR deletions in Bihar, as reported by *The Indian Express*. Around 68 lakh voters in total were deleted in Bihar during the SIR, which kicked off from the state.

Sub-divisional magistrates across Bihar’s 38 districts are learnt to have been asked to display lists of people whose ration cards were cancelled.

The BJP-led Bihar government has been talking of a “cleansing campaign” across government schemes, to re-



The SIR exercise was carried out in Bihar last year. FILE

move ineligible names, with the SIR as benchmark. However, so far, this is limited to ration card holders.

A sub-divisional officer told *The Indian Express*: “We have the SIR data, and also a list of ‘higher income suspects’ for deletion.” According to the government data, Muzaffarpur (32,360), Patna (32,626), Araria (17,439) and Bhagalpur (11,931) districts have seen the highest deletions.

A Banka-based PDS dealer said: “Of about 3,000 ration card beneficiaries here, names of 400 have been deleted. Our job is only to put up the list. The aggrieved can contest it before the Sub-Divisional Officer or Magistrate.”

In Bihar’s list of 1.79 crore ration card holders, some 22.93 lakh are the poorest, entitled to the Antyodaya Anna Yojana, making them eligible for 35 kg of grain per month.

A senior official said the data gathered during house-to-

house verifications for PDS would be “synchronised across other government systems”. “When the local administration identifies that an individual’s name has been flagged or deleted from the voter list due to death, long-term migration, or ineligibility, that data is shared with the Department of Food and Consumer Protection Department,” the official said.

In August 2025, *The Indian Express* reported that a Centre-ordered cross-verification of about 20 crore ration holders, found that 94.71 lakh of them were taxpayers, 17.51 lakh were owners of four-wheelers and another 5.31 lakh were directors in companies.

Officials said these roughly 1.17 crore people were entitled to free food grains under the National Food Security Act (NFSA), and states were directed to undertake necessary field verification and remove the ineligible ration card holders.

As TMC shrinks in Bengal, can a united Congress, Left rise to fill Opp vacuum?

Atri Mitra
Kolkata, May 30

AFTER ITS crushing defeat in the 2026 West Bengal Assembly elections at the hands of the BJP, the Trinamool Congress (TMC)’s influence appears to be on the decline. This was also reflected by the results in the Falta seat after a recent repolling, where the Mamata Banerjee-led party finished fourth behind the winner BJP and the runner-up CPI(M) with the Congress getting third position.

The Falta outcome has raised a crucial question: Will the TMC be able to regain ground in Bengal’s political landscape, or whether that vacuum be filled up by the Left and Congress? It remains to be seen, however, if the CPI(M) and the Congress

could again forge an alliance in a bid to fill the vacuum in state politics left by the TMC.

In the 2024 Lok Sabha elections, the Left-Congress alliance managed to lead in just 12 of the state’s 294 Assembly segments. While the Congress led in 11 segments, including the Baharampur segment under the Baharampur Lok Sabha seat and the Suti segment under the Jangipur parliamentary constituency, the CPI(M) led in just one segment – Raninagar under the Murshidabad Lok Sabha seat. The Congress had also led in the Farakka and Samserganj segments of Murshidabad district, besides the Mothabari, Sujapur, Ratua, Malatipur, Harishchandrapur and Chanchal segments in Malda district, and the Chakulia segment in North

Dinajpur district.

The 2026 Assembly elections provided a partial answer to the question of how much of 2024 Lok Sabha vote share belonged to the Congress and to the CPI(M)-led Left. At the same time, the Assembly verdict has raised speculations over future political equations in the state given that the Congress won just two Assembly seats and the CPI(M) only one after contesting the polls separately.

Expressing concern over the Assembly poll results, a senior TMC leader said, “We never imagined our party would almost collapse after the election result. Both Mamata Banerjee and Abhishek Banerjee are not coming out of their residence, and after Falta, we are sure our main strength – minority votes –



Congress and Left parties had contested the 2021 polls together. FILE

shifted to the CPI(M) and Congress. If this continues, the CPI(M) and Congress will gain support at the grassroots level, especially the minority vote bank.”

The CPI(M), too, sees the

prospect of gaining ground at the TMC’s expense. A CPI(M)’s Bengal State Committee member said, “It was the Congress that decided not to ally with us in this Assembly election. The Congress won two

seats, and the CPI(M) and its ally Indian Secular Front (ISF) won one seat each. If Left, Congress and ISF had fought together in this Assembly election, we would have won at least 15 seats, but unfortunately, that did not happen. We are trying to strike an alliance in the forthcoming Rejinagar and Nandigram bypolls at least, and we are sure we will emerge as a second force if we are together.”

The CPI(M) leader also said, “In Falta, we were not only in second position, but in 58 largely minority-dominated booths, we defeated the BJP. On the other hand, during counting, we were ahead of the BJP in one round. So, in the near future, for the Nandigram and Rejinagar bypolls and the up-

coming civic polls, our main target is to consolidate minority votes, reverse the Hindu votetowards us, and further corner the TMC as a declining force.”

Sujan Chakraborty, CPI(M) Central Committee member, said, “The TMC basically fled from Falta, which proved that while the TMC may make place for the BJP, they can’t stop the BJP. We will have to fight against the BJP’s bulldozer politics, division politics. People have to fight for their jobs and work and we will stand beside them, while the TMC will flee from the fight.”

Echoing the CPI(M)’s sentiments on the TMC’s decline, a senior Congress leader said, “It’s true that the TMC is now a dying force, and we will have to take up

that space, especially in Malda and Murshidabad where we are organisationally strong. It is also true that those TMC leaders who are comparatively honest and can’t support the BJP’s politics will come to our party and further strengthen us. In this situation, whether we ally with the Left or not, the decision will be taken by our high command.”

State Congress spokesperson Soumya Aich Roy said, “In politics, one can’t say what will happen in the future. But it’s true that in our country, as well as in West Bengal, only the Left and Congress are continuously fighting communal forces like the BJP. The TMC made space for the BJP to corner secular forces. Now, if we have to give a solid fight against the BJP, we have to fight unitedly...”

Bihar govt renews push to evict Rabri from Circular Road home; vendetta, says her party

Santosh Singh
Patna, May 30

THE BIHAR government has issued a fresh letter to former chief minister Rabri Devi to vacate 10, Circular Road, the residence she has been occupying since 2006.

Though Rabri Devi, the leader of opposition in the Bihar Legislative Council, was allotted 39, Hardinge Road some time ago, she refused to vacate her current residence. RJD state president Mangani Lal Mandal had said that since the present house has a lift, it suited her husband, the ailing RJD chief Lalu Prasad Yadav.

Joint Secretary-cum-Land Estate Officer, Building Construction Department, in a letter to the private secretary of the Leader of Opposition in the Legislative Council, wrote on May 29: "...Kindly apprise the Honorable Leader of Opposition, Bihar Legislative Council, with the request to take possession of the earmarked Quarter No.-39, Hardinge Road, Patna, and to vacate the previously occupied Quarter No.-10, Circular Road, Patna, immediately."

RJD spokesperson Mrityunjay Tiwari called the letter "vendetta politics at its worst".

"...Lalu Prasad Ji has health issues and several changes have been made in the bungalow for his easy movement. We also wonder how a first-time minister can be allotted such a big bungalow?" he asked, referring to Nandkishore Ram who has been allotted the house.

JD(U) spokesperson Neeraj Kumar, however, defended the move, saying: "The state government has now completely streamlined the system by earmarking fixed bungalows for MLAs and MLCs."



Women cadets celebrate after the passing out parade in Khadakwasla on Saturday. Eighteen women were part of the landmark 150th course of the National Defence Academy. PAVAN KHENGRE

Army Chief: Armed forces preparing well for Op Sindoor 2.0 if it takes place

Sushant Kulkarni
Pune, May 30

CHIEF OF Army Staff General Upendra Dwivedi said on Saturday that all three services are preparing well for Operation Sindoor 2.0 if it takes place. He also said that within the next two to three years, the process of theaterisation can be seen happening on ground.

General Dwivedi, who reviewed the Passing Out Parade (POP) of the landmark 150th course of the National Defence Academy (NDA), also said that Operation Sindoor has set a benchmark on how India responds to provocation and urged the passing out NDA cadets to uphold that standard. As the Reviewing Officer of the parade Gen Dwivedi inspected the cadets lined up for their final parade.

He addressed the passing-out cadets and ceremonially



Army Chief General Upendra Dwivedi reviews the parade on Saturday. PAVAN KHENGRE

pinned medals on those who earned medals.

Answering a question about Operation Sindoor during media interaction on the sidelines of the parade, the Army Chief said, "As far as Operation Sindoor is concerned, firstly, it is still continuing. There is tempor-

ary cessation of hostilities. All the three services including the Indian Army are preparing well for Operation Sindoor 2.0 if it takes place. Presently we are looking at enhancing synergy within the three services. We are looking at equipping ourselves for the next warfare. The next warfare will not be limited to land, maritime and air alone. Space, cyber and cognitive will play a very important role."

On the subject of information warfare, General Dwivedi said, "...victory is always in the mind and not on the ground. Therefore, information warfare is only successful only if the whole nation gets together and trusts the people who are giving information. And if that happens and in the nation we trust each other, I can assure you that we will always win the war."

When asked about the process of theaterisation, the Army Chief said it is on the right track.

"As of now all the discussions on theaterisation have gotten over within the Chiefs of Staff committee. The complete report has been submitted to the defence minister. It is undergoing a review from the various stakeholders at this stage. The Chief of Defence Staff and present three chiefs have taken a conscious view that all the major interests of the three services are met with," he said.

"Whenever synergy needs to be brought, there will be some giveaway by all the three services. Service chiefs will be responsible for raise, train and sustain functions and theatre commanders will be responsible for the operation orchestration of the forces. We are hopeful that the next set up, which is coming under the new CDS, will be able to take the journey forward and in the next two to three years we should be able to see it happening on the ground..." he added.

DEAL WITH INDONESIA IN FINAL STAGES: DEFENCE SECY 'India has signed deal with Vietnam for supply of BrahMos'

Amrita Nayak Dutta
New Delhi, May 30

IN THE first official confirmation of India selling the BrahMos missiles to Vietnam, Defence Secretary Rajesh Kumar Singh said Saturday that a deal has been signed with the southeast Asian nation for the supply of the missiles, adding that a similar deal with Indonesia is in "final stages".

Singh, who is in Singapore to attend the Shangri-La Dialogue, made the comments in response to a question on potential buyers of the missile system.

"My understanding is that with both Indonesia and with Vietnam, the deal is in the final stages... In fact, for Vietnam, I understand that it has already been signed, probably not publicly announced, but it's already been signed," he said.

Signing a contract worth nearly 375 million dollars, The Philippines had become the first foreign buyer of the BrahMos missile system from India in 2022. In March, Indonesia had also said that it had entered into an agreement with India to procure the BrahMos missile system.

The details of the deals with Indonesia and Vietnam are yet to be made public.

Singh said countries generally sell sophisticated weapon systems and platforms to nations they regard as friendly partners.

"Obviously, you share technology with people you trust," he said.

He said India has a strong commitment to the ASEAN nations, adding: "...we treat all of you as 'friendly foreign coun-



In March, Indonesia said it had entered into an agreement with India to procure BrahMos. The details of the deals with Indonesia and Vietnam are yet to be made public, said the Defence Secretary

tries' with whom we can share advanced defence technologies".

He told delegates that India was ready to work with partners across the region and beyond to build resilient supply chains and trusted defence partnerships besides securing maritime commons.

"Today, resilience has become one of the defining strategic requirements of our time," he said, adding that geopolitical uncertainty, conflicts in Europe and West Asia, disruptions in maritime trade routes, supply chain vulnerabilities, technological disruptions and growing strategic competition were among factors reshaping the global security landscape.

"The lessons from recent years are clear. Defence preparedness cannot depend upon fragile or overly concentrated supply chains. Nations today require resilient, trusted, diversified, and technologically adaptive defence industrial ecosystems," he said.

He said India had undertaken major reforms in defence

production, innovation and exports over the past decade, adding that the sector had been opened to greater private-sector participation.

He said India was not only modernising its armed forces but also emerging as a dependable defence manufacturing and maintenance hub. He said government-owned companies accounted for nearly 72% of India's defence production while the private sector contributed the rest, adding that three Indian government-owned defence firms were among the world's top 100 arms-producing companies.

He said the Indian defence industry had built capabilities in areas such as missile systems, fighter aircraft and main battle tanks, and efforts are on to bridge gaps in propulsion technologies across land, air and sea domains.

"Our objective is not to create exclusive blocs, but inclusive and reliable partnerships that strengthen collective security and reduce strategic vulnerabilities," he said.

AAP's Vadodara chief held for making 'threat call' to party leader by posing as IB official

Aditi Raja
Vadodara, May 30

IN A case that has turned an Aam Aadmi Party social media offensive on its head, the Gujarat Police have arrested two men, including the president of the party's Vadodara city unit, for allegedly making a "threat call" to a party leader by posing as an Intelligence Bureau (IB) official.

Anand Superintendent of Police (SP) G G Jasani said on Saturday that the investigation stemmed from a post made by AAP chief Arvind Kejriwal on X, "raising questions about whether Gujarat Police and IB were harassing workers in the name of verification".

Kejriwal's post, the police said, followed a post by former Delhi MLA Durgesh Pathak, who alleged on X that Gujarat Police's IB wing was intimidating AAP workers. The post named a mobile number as the source of the "harassment".

In a statement on Saturday, SP Jasani said, "As the mobile phone number mentioned in the tweet belonged to a user residing in Anand, taking note of the seriousness of the matter, an investigation was initiated".

The phone number allegedly



Arvind Kejriwal had earlier asked if Gujarat Police and IB were harassing AAP workers

led the Cyber Crime police straight back to AAP. The number was traced to Nitin Dobriya, a labour contractor living in Anand. Investigation revealed that Dobriya had allegedly acted at the behest of Ashok Oza, the president of the party's Vadodara unit. Oza had allegedly called Dobriya to Vadodara. Using Dobriya's phone, a call was allegedly made to AAP worker Keshavji Chauhan, in which the caller identified himself as an official of the "Karelibaug IB Office" and threatened Chauhan under the guise of a verification exercise.

The police said that the motive was purely "internal rivalry".

CONSIDER CJP A CREATIVE EXPRESSION: ACTIVIST TO SAXENA After bid to build bridges, Ladakh L-G's 'cockroach' barb at Wangchuk deepens chill

Bashaarat Masood
Srinagar, May 30

WHEN VINAI Kumar Saxena was appointed as the Lieutenant Governor (L-G) of Ladakh, he first moved to improve relations between the Lok Bhawan and the Apex Body Leh (ABL) as well as people of the Union Territory.

Saxena took a series of confidence-building measures to mend these ties, strained during the tenure of BJP leader Kavinder Gupta as the previous Ladakh L-G.

While the steps taken by Saxena were seen as showing some positive results, his latest social media post after a meeting with climate activist and ABL member Sonam Wangchuk may rekindle conflict between the ABL and Lok Bhawan, resulting in an adverse impact on the High Powered Committee's talks that saw significant progress during the May 22 meeting, when the Centre and the Ladakhi representatives reached an "in-principle understanding on restoring democracy in Ladakh" and providing "Constitutional safeguards on the lines of Article 371 A, F, and G".

Saxena's post about a private meeting with Wangchuk



Ladakh L-G Vinai Kumar Saxena (right) met Sonam Wangchuk and his spouse Gitanjali Angmo earlier this week. PTI

has put him on a collision path with a key member of the ABL. After meeting Wangchuk, the L-G said he had a "candid" exchange against the backdrop of "constructive dialogue" between the Centre and Ladakh's representatives.

"We agreed that an air of positivity, both in terms of development initiatives and political dialogue, needs to be maintained," Saxena said.

While the L-G talked of positivity, his next remark rankled Wangchuk. Saxena said that he "cautioned Shri Wangchuk to abjure from weaving a misleading and provocative narrative, which vitiates public dis-

course" - a reference to Wangchuk's "honorary cockroach" remark.

"Democratic expression must not be taken as license for fabricating falsehoods and rabble rousing," Saxena posted. "He (Wangchuk) accepted that comparing the situation of Ladakh with Manipur was an error of judgment. He also said that he was unsure of the origins of the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) and would study the motivations of its founders and revisit his stand, if necessary."

The comments didn't go down well with Wangchuk. Though he initially preferred

silence, he later said he was "surprised" by the L-G's comments.

"During our meeting, he (Saxena) brought up his concerns around the CJP... He said the CJP is a foreign conspiracy with fewer members from India than from abroad, that they were being run from Pakistan, Bangladesh and America," Wangchuk said. "I informed him that I consider this (CJP) a creative expression and the government should not feel insecure about it, but should hear them out. What the L-G didn't realise was that he was saying these things to the person who had been arrested under the National Security Act (NSA) about eight months back on similar charges. Similar stories were constructed about my 'links' with Pakistan, China or the Soros foundation."

When Saxena took over as L-G in March this year, he set out to undo the "damage" caused by the strained relations between Ladakhi representatives and his predecessor.

During Gupta's tenure, the relations were strained to a point where not only did the ABL stop participating in meetings with him, but there was also a communication breakdown between the two sides.

True Gen-Z defined by contribution towards nation building: Nabin

Jatin Anand & Lalmani Verma
New Delhi, May 30

BJP NATIONAL president Nitin Nabin sought to address concerns ranging from NEET row to 'Cockroach Janta Party' and said India's "true Gen-Z" is defined by both its culture and contribution towards nation building.

Addressing a booth committee meeting in Dehradun, Nabin said: "I believe the BJP government in the country and in Uttarakhand is working towards providing employment to the youth and removing deficiencies where they exist... we will bring better examination forms whether UGC or NEET or any other exam..."

Terming it a "mann ki baat", the BJP Rajya Sabha MP called for an "open debate" on the definition of India's Gen Z, its politics and the "positive direction" that it needed to take.

Nabin also sought to flag alleged attempts by the Opposition and "foreign powers" to "sway" India's youth, which constitute 65% of its population, to spread "anarchy" in the country by citing examples from India's neighbourhood which had seen toppling of ruling dispensation on the back of a Gen-Z driven movement recently. "What do we want to see (going forward)? Some people say that today's



BJP chief Nitin Nabin performs a puja at a temple in Dehradun on Saturday. ANI

youth is Gen-Z. I favour an open debate on this. The youth of India is known for positive things, in moving towards the positive direction... should the energy of 65% of the population not get positive direction?"

He said, "Someone asked about the 'Cockroach Janta Party'... has nothing happened in this country in the last 10 years that would propel the youth of this nation to a following of millions?... At Kashmir's Lal Chowk... the Pakistani flag was flying in 2011, did that not concern anyone? Now... the Tricolour is there; is that not worth being followed?" Nabin sought to caution the youth from being "defined as anti-establishment".

Why Punjab civic poll outcome rings alarm bells for Congress before 2027 finals

Man Aman Singh Chhina
Chandigarh, May 30

THE CIVIC body elections in Punjab have delivered a sobering reality check for the Congress, not merely in terms of electoral arithmetic, but also in accelerating the factional fault-lines within the party.

While the ruling Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) rode a virtual urban wave to a dominant performance, the principal Opposition Congress's internal discord - laid bare at a stormy Delhi meeting on Friday attended by Lok Sabha Leader of the Opposition (LoP) Rahul Gandhi and Congress national president Mallikarjun Kharge - suggests that the setback may prove more damaging to the Congress's organisational cohesion.

At the heart of the discord lies the contrasting fortunes of key leaders. Punjab Congress president Amarinder Singh Raja Warring suffered a humiliating personal blow in his stronghold of Gidderbaha, where the AAP won 17 of 19 wards in the municipal council despite his intensive campaigning. This breach in a traditional bastion, occurring under the glare of high command scrutiny, invited sharp questioning from Jalandhar party MP Charanjit Singh Channi, the former chief minister.

Channi, who delivered impressive victories in his spheres of influence, Chamkaur Sahib and Morinda, used the platform of the Delhi meeting to highlight the question of leadership accountability. Going by the re-

ports of verbal duels at this meeting between state party leaders, Channi asked how the party could gear up for the Assembly polls when the state party chief's home turf had been overrun.

Warring, in turn, deflected by accusing the ruling AAP of "misusing" official machinery, a familiar narrative in local body polls. Yet this defence was swiftly challenged from within, notably by Gurdaspur MP Sukhjinder Singh Randhawa, who questioned why such "misuse" had not prevented Congress victories in Kapurthala and Chamkaur Sahib.

The exchange underscores a classic Congress affliction: poor results challenging its internal cohesion. Warring's further criticism of Channi's prolonged absence from Punjab during the polls, met with the latter citing



Punjab Congress president Amarinder Singh Raja Warring (right) and former CM Charanjit Singh Channi. ANI

personal reasons, which only intensified personal and factional feuds.

These tensions spilled into visible gestures of discontent. The state Assembly's LoP Partap Singh Bajwa reportedly walked out midway, an act downplayed by Congress general secretary in-charge of Punjab Bhupesh Baghel as "routine", with assur-



ances of no immediate leadership change. However, such optics, combined with the high command's presence, signal that the party's top leadership is closely monitoring Punjab's volatility.

In his interaction with the media late Friday, Baghel chose not to comment on the in-fighting seen during the meeting. He

downplayed Bajwa's premature exit after a one-on-one meeting with Rahul Gandhi and said the local body poll outcomes typically favour the ruling party.

Bajwa, too, downplayed reports of his sudden exit. "I spoke for about 15 to 20 minutes on the situation in Punjab, how the party should function, and the current political scenario... I sought permission to leave and returned to Jalandhar the same night. Reports that I walked out of the meeting or left in anger are completely baseless," Bajwa said on Saturday.

Beyond the headline losses, the Congress registered credible wins that further complicate the internal narrative. Sitting MLA Rana Gurjit Singh's decisive hold in the Kapurthala Municipal Corporation (where the Con-

gress won 31 of 50 wards), strong showings in Shaheed Bhagat Singh Nagar district's Nawanshahr Municipal Council (boosting ex-MLA Angad Singh), and respectable fights in Pathankot, Mukerian, Patti, and other scattered pockets were some silver linings. These successes amplify Channi and Rana Gurjit's positions as leaders capable of delivering in their areas, even as the party overall trailed the AAP by a considerable margin while edging past the Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD) and the BJP.

For Warring, the Gidderbaha rout, despite round-the-clock efforts, represents more than a local defeat - it questions his organisational grip at a time when he is expected to unify the party. His post-poll statement invoking the AAP's "saam, daam, dand,

bhed" tactics and asserting that the 2027 Assembly polls will be different reflects defiance, but also reveals vulnerability.

However, most Congress leaders were unwilling to speak on the civic poll outcome and the resultant internal acrimony at the Delhi meeting.

The civic polls, billed as a semi-final before the 2027 Assembly elections, have amplified pre-existing chasms rather than bridging them. Factionalism has long gripped the Congress in Punjab, which may get aggravated by the party's poor performance in the civic polls.

With Independents already acting as spoilers and the AAP consolidating its governance pitch, a divided Congress may face the risk of ceding ground in a multi-cornered contest in 2027.

Hunt for militants enters Day 8 in J&K forests; drones, helicopters deployed

Arun Sharma
Jammu, May 30

ARMY, POLICE and paramilitary forces continued combing the forests of Rajouri and nearby Poonch for the eighth day Saturday, as search operations launched last week following reports of militant presence expanded to more areas.

Codenamed Operation Sherwall, the searches were launched in the Ghambir Mughalan forests of Rajouri on May 22 following intelligence reports but have now expanded to the forests of Surankote in Poonch, with security forces using sniffer dogs, drones and helicopters to target areas suspected to be militant hideouts. Officials said although security forces sighted some militants last Saturday, there had been “no contact

with militants” since then. “The last time troops had contact with militants was last Saturday, but they managed to escape deeper inside the forests after a brief exchange of fire,” an official said. “The group appears to be well trained in jungle warfare in view of its strategy of continuously changing location so as to avoid contact with the search parties.”

Officials believe 2-5 militants have been operating in the area between the Rajouri-BG-Surankote road (National Highway 144-A) and the Rajouri-Thanamandi-DKG-Bufliaz road for the last two-three years. “There are two groups — one hiding in forests in Rajouri and the other in Surankote in Poonch district. They appear to have come down to the lower heights of Pir Panjal to escape relentless search op-

erations by the counter-insurgency Romeo Force in the forests of Sukhsar and Lalansar, adjoining the Kashmir Valley, over the last three months.”

Characterised by thick forest cover, the forests connecting Rajouri and Poonch districts previously witnessed militant attacks in which 10 security personnel were killed in two major attacks on April 20 and May 5, 2023. According to officials, the contiguous forests, which span both Jammu and Kashmir, offer ideal cover and relatively easy access to Kashmir, allegedly aiding militants’ escape. “As a result, whenever security forces and police launch operations against militants in one district, they manage to slip into another or even the Valley,” they said.

According to officials, one of the militants appears to

have been wounded in last week’s encounter, with search parties finding blood stains inside the forests. Vast plumes of smoke were seen rising from the forests last Thursday after heavy gunfire and multiple grenade explosions, although a senior Army officer attributed these to search parties trying to prevent ambushes.

On April 20, a militant ambush on an Army truck near Bhimber Gali led to the death of five soldiers. Five more elite Army para-commandos were killed in the massive combing operation that followed in the Kesari Hill area in Rajouri’s Kandi forest. These killings came two years after nine soldiers were killed in the Chamrer and Bhatta Durrian forests in what was then one of Jammu’s longest operations in three decades.



Rahul’s auto ride

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi, wearing the uniform of an autorickshaw driver, takes a ride in an auto during a meeting with a group of drivers at Todarmal park in New Delhi. PTI

Kerala CM asks officials to revoke suspension of school principal who ‘insulted’ him on social media

Shaju Philip
Thiruvananthapuram, May 30

CHIEF MINISTER V D Satheesan on Saturday directed the general education department to withdraw the suspension of a school principal, two days before his retirement, on charges of insulting him on social media.

The suspension of Javad S, the principal of the government higher secondary school in Attingal, evoked widespread protests on Friday. He was slated to retire from service on Sunday.

The Chief Minister’s office, in an official release, said that neither Satheesan, who recently took charge of the Congress-led government, nor his office had complained against the principal. Considering that the principal has only two more days in service before his retirement, the Chief Minister instructed the officials to withdraw the suspension, the release said.

The suspension order had alleged that the principal posted an edited photo of the chief minister on his social media page. It said the content was “objectionable and defamatory” and added, “On May 25, the state intelligence wing recommended action against the principal, saying that his Facebook post would give a wrong message to society and lead to political polarisation among students as well as teachers.

“Defaming individuals using social media should be seen as a serious violation of service rules. Hence, the ADGP had recommended stringent department-level disciplinary action against the principal, who is slated to retire from service on May 31.”

The order said the code of conduct prohibits state government employees from participating in events of a political nature. Besides, his action amounted to a violation of a 2017 government circular regarding government employees using media and social media, it said.



GOVERNMENT OF ODISHA
OFFICE OF THE CHIEF CONSTRUCTION ENGINEER
RURAL WORKS CIRCLE : SUNDARGARH
25001/273/2627
AT/PO-SANKARA, SUNDARGARH-770020, E-mail address-serv_sundargarh@yahoo.com
No. Tender Online -RWCCESNG- 09 of 2026-27, Letter No 3071
Dtd.25/05/2026

e-Procurement NOTICE
1. Type of the Work: : Roads (MMSY)
2. Class of Contractor: : As specified in the column-6 of the Annexure
3. Time of Completion: : As specified in the column-5 of the Annexure
4. Detail Projects: : As per Annexure attached
5. Estimated Cost : : As specified in the column-4 of the Annexure
6. Other details: :

Procurement Officer	Bid Identification No.	Availability of Tender on-line for bidding From	To	Last Date & Time of Seeking Tender Clarification	Technical Bid	Date & Time of opening of tender
1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Chief Construction Engineer, Rural Works Circle, Sundargarh	RWCCESNG-09 of 2026-27	03.06.2026 11:00 AM	23.06.2026 5:00 PM	22.06.2026 5:00 PM	24.06.2026 11:00 AM	Will be intimated separately

Further details can be seen from the website www.tendersodisha.gov.in

Sd/-
Chief Construction Engineer,
Rural Works Circle, Sundargarh

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Tenders are invited online from reputed Manufacturers/formulators/ Direct importers for Tablet & Capsule and Miscellaneous Item on Rate contract basis and details of specification, quantity is available on, <https://gmscl.gujarat.gov.in> All tender documents can be downloaded free on the website: <https://tender.nprocure.com> Interested bidders are requested to submit the tender through e-tender process. Duration of downloading of tender document (online):-30/05/2026 to 15/06/2026 up to 18.00 Hrs
Last date for Submission (online): 15/06/2026 up to 18-00 HRS
Last date for submission of EMD/Tender Fee (Physical): 16/06/2026 upto 18:00 HRS
Opening of Technical Bid Date (online): 19/06/2026 At 15-00 HRS.
Pre-Consultation meeting (Pre-Bid)
Interested Manufacturers/formulators/Direct Importers are requested to remain present for pre- Consultation meeting to be held on 09/06/2026 at 11.30 am at Committee room at above mentioned address. Only one representative from each Manufacturer carrying authority letter wouldbe allowed to participate in the pre-bid.
INF-442/2026-27
MANAGING DIRECTOR

Four held for Chhattisgarh Cong leader’s son murder

Jayprakash S Naidu
Raipur, May 30

A MONTH after the 18-year-old son of a Congress leader was shot dead in Chhattisgarh’s Sakti district over an alleged illegal sand-mining rivalry, police have arrested four men—including the alleged key conspirator. Police said the accused trailed Ayush Kashyap of Karhi village as he returned home on April 24, changed clothes to mask their identity, forced their way into his house and locked his parents in a room before shooting him dead. His 16-year-old brother was also shot but survived.

Ayush’s father, Sammelan Kashyap, a Congress leader, had alleged at the time that his son

was killed over a business rivalry linked to illegal sand mining in the area. Police now say the probe has confirmed that angle. Janjgir-Champa SP Vijay Kumar Pandey said: “I realised the murder had a sand-mining angle, as there have been murders linked to sand mining in the past. I was also aware of a gang active on social media that assaulted people for money, and began tracking them. Another clue was the 20-minute lag between the breaking of cameras and the murder.” Police said another clue was that one of the accused, 23-year-old Bhushan Baghel, owed money to Ayush’s father. Bhushan was traced to Ahmedabad in Gujarat, while Hemant Baghel, 23, and alleged shooter Amit Tondon, 28, were arrested from the village. And Ganpat Baghel was arrested Wednesday.

कार्यालय संयुक्त संचालक एवं अधीक्षक
गांधी स्मारक चिकित्सालय रीवा (म.प्र.)
Website-<http://ssmcrewa.com>, Email-jdsupdtgmhrewa@rediffmail.com, Tel/Fax-07662-350106
क्रमांक 6673/क्रय/जी.एच.एच./2026
रीवा, दिनांक 29.5.26

ई-निविदा विज्ञप्ति
श्यामशाह चिकित्सा महाविद्यालय रीवा से संबद्ध गांधी स्मारक/संजय गांधी स्मृति / सुपरस्पेशलिटी चिकित्सालय रीवा में निम्नलिखित सेवाओं हेतु ई-निविदा वेबसाईट <https://mptenders.gov.in/> पर आमंत्रित की जाती है। निविदा प्रपत्र वेबसाईट पर आनलाईन क्रय एवं आनलाईन जमा किए जा सकते हैं। निविदा में संशोधन की स्थिति में संशोधन एवं विस्तृत निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना व अन्य जानकारी चिकित्सा महाविद्यालय रीवा की वेबसाईट <https://www.ssmcrewa.com> पर भी देखा जा सकता है।
संपर्क :- 07662-350106, 9617348113, 9644695933, 9575285501
Email-jdsupdtgmhrewa @rediffmail.com,

क्र.	सेवा का नाम	आनलाईन फार्म कय/जमा करने की प्रारंभ तिथि	आनलाईन फार्म जमा करने की अंतिम तिथि	आनलाईन निविदा खोलने की तिथि
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हस्ता./-
संयुक्त संचालक एवं अधीक्षक
गांधी स्मारक चिकित्सालय, रीवा (म.प्र.)

G-13690-26



DELHI SKILL AND ENTREPRENEURSHIP UNIVERSITY
(A State University Established under Govt. of NCT of Delhi Act 04 of 2020)
HQ - DSEU Dwarka Campus, Sector 9, Dwarka, New Delhi-110077.
Website: <https://dseu.ac.in>

Extension of Registration Date for Diploma Programs
In continuation of Admission Advertisement published on 19 May 2026 regarding 3-Year Technical Diploma Programmes of NCrF Level 4.5 Admissions for Academic Session 2026-27, it is hereby informed that the last date for submission of online applications for admission to various Diploma Programmes offered by Delhi Skill and Entrepreneurship University (DSEU) has been extended upto:
10 June 2026
How to apply: Prospective students are required to complete the online application form available at: <https://admission-diploma.dseu.ac.in>. For detailed information regarding programmes, eligibility criteria (including relaxations for reserved categories), fees, and the admission process, applicants are advised to refer to the Information Bulletin provided on the website. In case of any difficulty while submitting the online application, candidates may contact the helpdesk at helpdesk-admission@dseu.ac.in, call 9218172972, or visit the DSEU Dwarka Campus between 10:00 am and 3:00 pm.
DIP/Shabdarth/Classified/0081/26-27
Registrar, DSEU

Government of National Capital Territory of Delhi
DIRECTORATE OF TRAINING & TECHNICAL EDUCATION
Muni Maya Ram Marg, Pitam Pura, Delhi-110034
Website: <https://tte.delhi.gov.in>

FULL TIME DIPLOMA COURSES ADMISSION 2026-27

ONLINE Applications are invited from the aspirants for the Admissions to AICTE/PCI Approved Diploma Programs running in Privately Managed Self-Financed Institutes affiliated with Board of Technical Education, Delhi for the Academic Session 2026-2027.

The details of the Institute along with the courses offered and other information may be seen in the Information Bulletin available at the website at <https://tte.delhi.gov.in> and at the Online Admission Portal <https://dtte.ucanapply.com>

IMPORTANT DATES*

Date of Start of Registration : 25.05.2026**
Last Date of Registration & Fee Submission : 10.06.2026
Tentative online Common Entrance Test : 13.06.2026/14.06.2025
*** May please refer to the admission portal for any update in the schedule**
****Registration Fee of Rs. 500/- (Non refundable) is payable at time of online registration**

For any queries, please contact:

ADMISSION CELL, Room No. 5, Board of Technical Education,
Muni Maya Ram Marg, Pitampura, Delhi-110034
E-mail: dtteonline@gmail.com Phone: 011-27323161

CONTROLLER
Board of Technical Education
Directorate of Training and Technical Education, Delhi
DIP/Shabdarth/Classified/0072/26-27



DIRECTORATE OF MINES & GEOLOGY
STEEL AND MINES DEPARTMENT,
GOVT. OF ODISHA, BHUBANESWAR
Heads of Department Building, Unit-V, Pin-751001
Tel No.: 0674-2391537, Fax No.: 0674-2391684
Email ID: directormines1@orissaminerals.gov.in

corrigendum
In reference to the “Notice Inviting Tender” advertisement published in *The Indian Express* on 29th May’ 2026. Kindly read Rs. 2,00,000 for Price of Tender Document for Behera Banjipali Limestone Block mentioned in Sr. No-8 instead of Rs. 5,00,000

GOVERNMENT OF INDIA MINISTRY OF DEFENCE
EX-SERVICEMEN CONTRIBUTORY HEALTH SCHEME STATION HQ, (ECHS CELL), HALDWANI

1. GOVERNMENT OF INDIA MINISTRY OF DEFENCEEX-SERVICEMEN CONTRIBUTORY HEALTH SCHEME STATION HQ, (ECHS CELL), HALDWANI. ECHS Invites applications to engage following Medical Staff on contractual basis in ECHS Polyclinic Haldwani for a period of one year renewable for additional period of one year/till attaining the maximum age subject to performance of candidates/other conditions according to the criteria

S.No	Appointment	Minimum Qualification	ECHS PC	No of Vac	Fixed Remuneration
1)	Medical Officer	MBBS, Min 03 Years experience after Internship. Preferable addl qualifications in Medical/Surgery	Haldwani	01	₹ 95000/-
2)	Pharmacist	B Pharma/Approved Diploma in Pharmacy from an Institute recognized by the Pharmacy council of India. Min 03 Years experience		01	₹ 36500/-

2. For Terms & Conditions, Application Form & Remuneration. Kindly see our website www.echs.gov.in. For additional details/application please contact Station HQ (ECHS Cell), Haldwani at Tele No 05946-282374 & email echscell.hldwn@gmail.com. Also approach concerned ECHS Polyclinic for details. Preference will be given to the Ex-servicemen.

3. Last Date of Receipt of Application as per Format Given at Our Website. Application as per requisite format alongwith self attested photocopies of testimonials in support of Educational Qualifications and Work Experiences will be submitted to OIC, Stn HQs (ECHS Cell), Haldwani by 30 Jun 26 in duplicate. Any application received after 30 Jun 26 will not be accepted.

4. Interview Date, Timing & Venue. Candidates must reach Stn HQs (ECHS Cell), Haldwani at 1000 hrs on 10 Jul 26 for the interview to be held between 1030 hrs to 1400 hrs. Candidates must bring all the original certificates/mark sheets of 10th/Matric, 10+2 & Graduation/Post Graduation/Diploma/ Course, work experience and discharge book, PPO, Service Records and two passport size photographs at the time of interview. No TA/DA is admissible for the interview. Only candidates meeting the Qualitative Requirements may apply.

5. Selected individuals will carry out 10 days On the Job Training (OJT) and obtain a certificate from Officer-in-Charge Polyclinic before signing the contract. In case of Officer-in-Charge Polyclinic, the cert would be rendered by the Officer-in-Charge, ECHS Cell at Station Headquarters. This duration of On the Job Training (OJT) will remain unpaid and as a mandatory requirement before assuming charge as a contract employee.

6. With regard to remuneration of ESM, ESM can exercise option as per G.OI, MoD letter No 22D(19)/2017-D(WE/Res-1) (i) dt 24 Jul 2025 and 18 Sep 25.



Karnataka Food & Civil Supplies Corporation Ltd.
(Government of Karnataka Undertaking)
No.16/1, MILLERS TANK BED AREA, BANGALORE-560 052
Ph: 080-2226 0932/2209 6555/2209 6512
E-mail: admknfscs123@yahoo.com, mdkfscs@yahoo.com
No.KFCSCL/ADMN/I.F.K.A./94/2026-27
Date: 30.05.2026

e-Tender Notice
The Karnataka Food and Civil Supplies Corporation Limited has published a tender for “Appointment of Third Party Assaying Agency to carry out Sampling, Testing and Quality Certification of Toordhal, Refined Sunflower Oil, Iodized Salt and Sugar to be Distributed under Public Distribution Scheme to the Beneficiaries through INDIRA Food Kit.” under Tender Number: KFCSCL/2026-27/SE0171. The RFP and other information can be obtained from <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in> e-procurement portal.
Sd/-
General Manager

Strictly monitor & report demographic changes in border districts: Shah to DMs

Home Minister asks officials to deport 'infiltrators'

Express News Service
Ahmedabad, May 30

UNION HOME Minister Amit Shah has directed the district magistrates (DMs) of border districts to strictly monitor and regularly report demographic changes happening in their areas.

Shah gave the directions after chairing a review meeting focusing on security-related issues pertaining to border and coastal districts of Gujarat

along the India-Pakistan Border, an official statement issued on Saturday said.

The review meeting was held in Bhuj on Friday, during Shah's visit to the Kutch district. The meeting was attended by Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel, Deputy CM Harsh Sanghavi, Chief Secretary M K Das, DGP K L N Rao along with other senior officials of the state apart from DMs and Superintendents of Police (SPs) of Kutch, Patan and Vav-Tharad districts, among others.

According to the statement, the meeting focused on the challenges faced by the border areas in which emphasis was put on the active and effective role of the state government, especially the DMs and SPs.

Quoting Shah, the state-



Union Home Minister Amit Shah at the inauguration of Border Out Posts G-7 and G-13 at Bhuj, in Kutch on Friday. PTI

ment said, "DMs in border districts must strictly monitor and regularly report demographic

changes. The reverse migration taking place due to the setting up of industrial units in border

areas is a welcome development. For deporting already settled infiltrators, everyone – from police stations to Patwaris – must come forward collectively... Local administrations should prepare Standard Operating Procedures (SOPs) which ensures identification of already-settled infiltrators, drones, and narcotics."

As per the statement, Shah said a security coordination group should be formed in every district which includes BSF, Coast Guard, Income Tax, ED and the Lead Bank Manager. He also said that the responsibility for implementing laws related to income tax, money laundering and customs should be of the DMs, SPs and IG of the border range.

The Union minister also

emphasised the need of keeping strict vigil over hawala transactions, financial dealings, mule accounts, shell companies, suspicious vehicles and GST collection in border districts. He also added that agencies fighting against economic offences should be strictly apprised about the border areas and the Income Tax department should launch a major survey in collaboration with the RBI.

Shah said that considering Gujarat's proximity to the International Maritime Boundary Line, there is a need to focus on coastal security and effective coordination with the Indian Coast Guard. He added that government schemes "should be implemented 100 per cent in border villages."



Defence Minister Rajnath Singh, UP CM Yogi Adityanath and Chief of the Naval Staff Admiral Dinesh K Tripathi at the inauguration of 'Nausena Shaurya Vatika' in Lucknow on Saturday. EXPRESS

Our naval might confined Pak to its ports: Rajnath

Express News Service
Lucknow, May 30

AT THE inauguration of naval museum 'Nausena Shaurya Vatika' in Lucknow, Defence Minister Rajnath Singh said on Saturday that the facility was a symbol of inspiration that would remind future generations of the true cost of the country's freedom and security. He added the Indian Navy forced "the entire Pakistan Navy to remain confined to its ports during Operation Sindoor".

The open-air display museum, which was inaugurated by Singh along with Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath, showcases the artefacts and weapon systems of INS Gomati, which was decommissioned on May 29, 2022 after 34 years of service. It has been built on 2 acres in Lucknow's Gomti Nagar Extension area at a cost of Rs 19 crore.

Chief of the Naval Staff Admiral Dinesh K Tripathi was also present on the occasion.

The Defence Minister said, "It is not just an architectural design or a product of structural craftsmanship, it rekindles a sense of gratitude we hold for our soldiers. The idea is to awaken the zeal for nation building among our youth."

Singh hailed the Indian Navy

for its "robust presence and operational readiness" at sea, underlining that amid the present geopolitical turmoil, the key to global peace and prosperity lies in securing maritime routes. Commending the Navy's "exceptional contribution" alongside the Army and the Indian Air Force during Operation Sindoor, he said: "Our Navy's formidable posture in the Arabian Sea instilled a constant sense of fear in the mind of the adversary. As a result, the Pakistan Navy remained confined to its ports."

He added, "India can truly be considered powerful when our defence forces do not have to depend on other nations for their weaponry. Through initiatives such as Make-in-India, Defence Industrial Corridors, Innovations for Defence Excellence (iDEX) and Acing Development of Innovative Technologies with iDEX (ADITI), we are indigenously manufacturing state-of-the-art weapons, and exporting them to friendly nations."

He claimed the domestic defence production in 2014 was Rs 46,000 crore which now increased to over Rs 1.51 lakh crore and aims to soon touch the Rs 1.75 lakh crore figure. Defence exports have reached to about Rs 40,000 crore, he said. Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath was also present.

BRIEFLY



CDS Gen Anil Chauhan receives ceremonial Guard of Honour at South Block Lawn in New Delhi on Saturday. AMIT MEHRA

NEW DELHI

CDS Gen Chauhan wraps up tenure, Lt Gen Subramani takes charge today

OUTGOING CHIEF of Defence Staff Gen Anil Chauhan on Saturday described his tenure as "very satisfying" as he wrapped up a three-year-and-eight-month stint at the top military post. Lt Gen NS Raja Subramani (ret'd) will take charge as India's next CDS on Sunday. "I had a very satisfying and excellent tenure," the outgoing CDS said after he was accorded a ceremonial tri-services guard of honour. Gen Chauhan, a former Eastern Army Commander, took charge as the country's senior-most military commander in September 2022, over nine months after the first CDS General Bipin Rawat died in a helicopter crash in Tamil Nadu. Gen Chauhan played a key role in planning and implementation of Operation Sindoor. PTI

HIV+ Syrian man gets bail

THE GUJARAT High Court has granted conditional bail to a Syrian man, who was arrested during a combing operation last November, on the grounds that his ill health was "not in dispute". The petitioner, who is living with HIV+ and belongs to the LGBTQ+ community, had moved the Court, citing "fear of death" if deported. He will now be released from the joint interrogation centre in Gujarat, even as his petition seeking quashing of the FIR filed against him under the Foreigners Act, and protection from deportation, remains pending for hearing. He has been held in a detention centre since January this year. ENS

Ex-BRS MP held over remarks

Telangana Police arrested former BRS MP Balla Suman for allegedly calling for "militant" activities that include "burning of government offices and breaking down rail tracks". Suman was held from near BRS party headquarters Saturday. He was booked under relevant sections of the BNS and Prevention of Damage to Public Property Act by the Nampally police. In a purported video that went viral five days ago May 25, Suman was seen telling the BRS cadre to burn offices. "Even if you go to jail for a month, it doesn't matter," he was heard telling the party cadre in the Chennai constituency. ENS

'CAN'T PLEAD HELPLESSNESS', SAYS TOP COURT

Why Supreme Court is cracking the whip against states over Chambal

Jay Mazoomdaar
New Delhi, May 30

THE SUPREME Court's latest indictment of Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh and Uttar Pradesh over illegal sand mining in and around the inter-state National Chambal Gharial Sanctuary reflects years of judicial frustration with persistent administrative apathy, leading to an environmental and governance crisis.

The apex court, which took suo motu cognizance of the matter in March, was particularly harsh on Rajasthan in its May 26 order, slamming its "wholly casual, indifferent and indolent" conduct, and rebuking the state administration for demonstrating "persistent inaction" and a "disturbing lack of seriousness".

Sand mining was prohibited in the Chambal sanctuary in 2006 but illegal extraction has continued and flourished over the years under organised syndicates. The indiscriminate sand extraction has severely disrupted the Chambal's riverine ecosystem, damaging aquatic habitats and threatening environmental flows, putting at risk the survival of endangered gharials, freshwater dolphins and turtles.

In 2012, an IPS officer was crushed to death by a tractor carrying illegally mined sand in Morena, Madhya Pradesh. The Court's May 26 order referred to the killing of two forest guards this year alone – one again in Morena last month, and another in Dholpur, Rajasthan, this January – to emphasize what it called a "serious erosion of the rule of law" in the region.

At a hearing on May 14, the Supreme Court expressed con-

Despite many dams and threat of sand mining, Chambal has highest conservation value among Gangetic rivers



Chambal's aquatic ecosystem and forest landscape support more than 550 species. It also hosts the largest contiguous and most viable breeding populations of the critically endangered gharial. GETTY IMAGES

cern that authorities appeared to prosecute only vehicle drivers, while failing to investigate the financiers, contractors, operators and masterminds controlling illegal mining syndicates.

"Such a lackadaisical pattern of investigation... raises serious concerns regarding... possible connivance at various levels of the administrative and enforcement machinery." The Court stressed that environmental governance could not remain dependent on repeated judicial intervention and authorities must ensure "sustained and proactive enforcement" to curb illegal mining in the Chambal sanctuary landscape.

On forest personnel allegedly lacking adequate weapons to counter heavily armed mining mafias, the Court said: "The State cannot be permitted to plead helplessness."

However, helplessness is what Madhya Pradesh effectively cited as long back as December 2021, when it proposed

opening 292 hectares for mining across five stretches of the Chambal and its tributary Parvati rivers.

The state argued that allowing regulated mining would free the Forest Department from devoting too much time, resources and efforts to fighting illegal extraction inside the sanctuary.

In 2022, the National Green Tribunal (NGT) accepted the findings of a committee constituted to prepare an action plan for the Chambal sanctuary that "mafias are using interior routes for conducting illegal mining in the national park, which are supported by political persons and are well equipped with weapons".

In January 2023, Madhya Pradesh went ahead and denotified 207 hectares of the Chambal sanctuary. But, it failed to justify the decision before the NGT and had to withdraw it in February 2025.

Similarly, Rajasthan denotified 732 hectares of the Cham-

bal sanctuary in December 2025 to facilitate mining and urbanisation projects. The Supreme Court stayed the notification last month.

Chambal's importance

Because of dark, foreboding myths around the Chambal – from a story linking its origins to a mountain of dripping leather, to the belief that Draupadi cursed its waters – the river, by all means mightier than the Yamuna, has remained one of India's most pristine. No great cities or shrines came up on its banks, with the isolation later fostering the badland reputation of the Chambal ravines as a place where all manner of black sheep – rebel tribesmen and later bandits – found refuge.

The Chambal's splendid isolation started to wane after people living in the arid districts of Rajasthan and Madhya Pradesh started moving into the region. By 1960, the first dam on the Chambal – Gandhi Sagar –

• BUDDHA'S SACRED RELICS WERE DISPLAYED IN LADAKH IN 1950 TO BOOST THE MORALE AFTER THE INDO-PAK WAR OF 1947-48

In travels of Buddha's sacred relics, India's soft power outreach

Upasika Singhal
New Delhi, May 29

THE DAY the Piprahwa relics landed on the small airstrip in Leh, hundreds of people gathered to catch a glimpse. Once the relics were on their way to Jivetsal, to be displayed for two weeks, Leh saw an unprecedented traffic jam that extended as far as the eye could see.

Tsering Dorjay Lakrook, the president of the Ladakh Buddhist Association, would later say that the arrival of the relics was marked by auspicious signs such as the clearing of clouds over the mountains and the appearance of a rainbow over Spituk Monastery.

This wasn't the first time the Buddha's relics had come to the valley, though – they had been brought to Leh for a public exhibition earlier in 1950.

"The war with Pakistan in 1947 had left the Ladakhi community shaken," Ladakhi scholar and diplomat Sonam Wangchuk Shaksपो said. "The

Pakistanis had almost reached Taroo village, around 15-20 km from Leh," he said.

As the Pakistani forces advanced through Nubra valley, the religious head of Ladakh, the 19th Kushok Bakula Rinpoche, gathered local forces to buttress the Indian Army's efforts to secure the valley.

According to the Ministry of Defence's biography of Colonel Chewang Rinchen – the 17-year-old boy who led the Nubra Guards to victory in the war – the local forces played a key role in India's victory in the 1947-48 war.

According to Shaksपो, the Kushok Bakula convinced Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru to send the relics to Ladakh to lift the "spiritual morale" of the local population. The relics were displayed to the public for 79 days in May 1950.

The exhibition is mentioned in Nawang Tsering Shaksपो's book, A Cultural History of Ladakh: "On May 26th, 1950 the relics of two of the main dis-



Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru with the Buddhist leader and India's future ambassador to Mongolia, the 19th Kushok Bakula Rinpoche, in Leh in 1949. THE NEHRU ARCHIVE

ciples of Lord Buddha were brought to Ladakh. On this occasion Yeshes-don-grup had to give a speech about the significance of the relics to the public. In honour of the celebration of Buddha's birthday on the 15th of Vaishakhi month he composed poems related to the occasion."

Scholars and diplomats today view the 1950 Leh exhibition as part of a broader ef-

fort by newly independent India to deploy Buddhist heritage as a form of cultural diplomacy, both in the frontier regions such as Ladakh, and among Buddhist-majority countries across Asia. Over the following decades, relic exhibitions and Buddhist conferences would become an important component of India's soft power outreach.

According to the Piprahwa

Project, the Buddha relics were first displayed in Sri Lanka in 1978. This was followed by exhibitions in Mongolia in 1993, Singapore in 1994, South Korea in 1995, and Thailand in 1996.

In 2012, at the request of the Sri Lankan President Mahinda Rajapaksa, the relics once again travelled from India to Sri Lanka to commemorate the 2600th anniversary of the Enlightenment of the Buddha. The relics were taken to Sri Lanka by a delegation led by then Minister of Culture Kumar Selja.

The 19th Kushok Bakula felt deeply for the Buddhist communities in Russia and Mongolia. He became the first Buddhist monk to visit these countries, where he advocated for peace and nuclear disarmament.

The Asian Buddhist Conference for Peace (ABCP) was co-established in 1969 by the Bakula Rinpoche along with S Gombojav, the abbot of Gandantegchinlen Monastery in

Ulaanbaatar. The Kushok Bakula shaped the policies and programs of the ABCP as the vice president, and later president, of the organisation.

After the collapse of the Soviet Union, Rinpoche, who was then the Indian ambassador to Mongolia, worked to organise an exhibition of the Buddha's relics in Ulaanbaatar.

"When the relics arrived in the Mongolian capital, they were treated like state guests," Shaksपो, who worked closely with the Rinpoche during his ambassadorship years in Mongolia, said.

"People lined up outside the exhibition hall from morning to evening. It was a massive success. Thereafter, all Buddhist countries began requesting similar exhibitions – Vietnam, Thailand, Bhutan, and Sri Lanka," he said.

The author was in Leh during the public exposition of the Sacred Piprahwa Relics of Lord Buddha earlier this month at the invitation of the Ladakh L-G.

Adopt mandatory family planning to bring population under control: BJP Bengal chief to CM

Ravik Bhattacharya
Kolkata, May 30

STATING THAT it was imperative to control population growth of West Bengal, state BJP president Samik Bhattacharya on Saturday asked Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari to adopt effective policies, including mandatory family planning.

Sharing the stage with the chief minister during the launch of the HPV vaccine drive in Kolkata, Bhattacharya said family planning was crucial.

During his speech, Samik Bhattacharya said, “The issue of the growing population in West Bengal needs to be considered with utmost importance. In the interest of building a healthy, orderly society, it is imperative to increase awareness about family planning and adopt effective policies.”

“In a healthy society, whether family planning can be made mandatory or making it a flagship programme of the government, and through vigorous awareness campaign, population growth can be controlled,” Bhattacharya, a Rajya Sabha member, said.

“We have to see whether we can ease the pressure on land (from the rising population). We have to see whether, through birth control, we can do all-around development for women. We can bring in education and socio-economic development of women. The chief minister will take a decision on this,” he added.

Praising the chief minister for having “touched the emotions of the people”, Bhattacharya said, “Certain exemplary decisions have been taken by the new government. The state government welfare schemes have been aligned with the Central schemes. I would request the chief minister to shoulder the responsibility of population control (in West Bengal).”

Bhattacharya’s statement comes amid the Centre forming a five-member High-Level Committee on Demographic Change to investigate “artificial” and “unnatural” population change across the country.

Abhishek attack: Mamata says hospitals not admitting him under BJP govt threat

Tanusree Bose
Kolkata, May 30

HOURS AFTER TMC general secretary Abhishek Banerjee was heckled and eggs were thrown at him at Sonarpur in South 24 Parganas, the Diamond Harbour MP returned to his Kolkata residence late Saturday night after he was allegedly refused admission by two private hospitals.

TMC supremo and former chief minister Mamata Banerjee, who first rushed to Apollo Hospital and then to Belle Vue, where Abhishek was taken after he was roughed up by a group of men and women at Sonarpur, said, “I want to say with great sadness that I am shocked and saddened to see the behaviour of the BJP government. They are using the police administration to threaten hospitals not to admit and give treatment to Abhishek.”

“Both hospitals mentioned the seriousness of his health. He



Former CM Mamata Banerjee outside a hospital in Kolkata where Abhishek Banerjee was taken after the attack. PARTHA PAUL

was admitted to the ITU (Intensive Therapy Unit). When I was sitting, the doctors were getting threat calls from the police and BJP leaders not to admit Abhishek. Doctors apologised and expressed sadness. We have sent him home. There, the family doctor will make arrangements,” Mamata, who is Abhishek’s aunt, told mediapersons outside Belle Vue hospital where Abhishek was kept for two hours.

On Saturday afternoon, Abhishek had gone to meet with the family of TMC worker Sanju Karmakar, who was killed in alleged post-poll violence.

This was the first time Abhishek was seen in public after the TMC lost in the Assembly elections. Ahead of his arrival, groups of women, allegedly backed by the BJP, were seen standing with eggs in their hands at several places along the

road. BJP workers were seen holding black flags and chanting “Go Back” slogans.

The Diamond Harbour MP, who reached Sonarpur in a four-wheeler, had to ride a motorbike to reach Karmakar’s residence because of the narrow lanes. This was when a group of people gheraoed him and started throwing bricks, eggs, and shoes at him. Abhishek, who was seated in the middle on the bike, wore a cricket helmet to protect himself. As he and others accompanying him, including his security personnel, tried to move ahead, a group of people, chanting “chor chor (thief, thief)”, punched him and tore his shirt.

Undeterred, Abhishek continued to walk towards Karmakar’s home. Sources said that no police personnel were seen at the spot.

A group of women was seen standing outside Karmakar’s house with brooms in their hands. They were heard shout-

ing against the TMC leader, accusing him of shielding the culprits of RG Kar rape-murder case.

“It is a BJP-sponsored protest. Just look at the condition. We want to meet victims of the post-poll violence, but the police are nowhere to be seen, even after being told repeatedly,” Abhishek told mediapersons after meeting Karmakar’s family.

“If they want to kill me, let them. I want my body to be taken out of here... In the last 15 years, such an incident has never happened... Overnight, bulldozers are brought in by this government. I do not expect security from them. I will stand by the family (of Karmakar).”

Accusing the BJP of unleashing violence against TMC workers, Abhishek said, “I will not leave the parents (of Karmakar) alone. I will move HC and petition the Governor.”

As the stalemate continued for over an hour, police and Central forces arrived and escorted Abhishek out of Sonarpur.

Monsoon at Kerala’s doorstep but likely to miss June 1 onset

Express News Service
Bengaluru, May 30

THE SOUTHWEST monsoon is most likely to miss its date with Kerala on June 1 this year.

The normal monsoon onset date over Kerala, which marks the commencement of the season over the country, is June 1 with a likely deviation of 7 days.

The Indian Meteorological Department (IMD) said Saturday the conditions were favourable for further advance of southwest monsoon over to southern peninsular India, including Kerala and Tamil Nadu in the coming week.

The Met office said, “The monsoon advance was likely into some more parts of southwest and southeast Arabian Sea, Lakshadweep islands, some parts of Kerala and Tamil Nadu, some more parts of southwest, west-central, east-central and northeast Bay of Bengal and remaining parts of

southeast Bay of Bengal during the next 4 to 5 days.”

In 2023, the monsoon onset over Kerala was realised on June 8, whereas it had an early onset both in 2024 (May 30) and 2025 (May 24), as per the IMD data.

On Saturday, the monsoon progressed further into some more parts of southwest and southeast Arabian Sea, Lakshadweep islands, Comorin area, southwest, southeast, west-central and east-central Bay of Bengal, and some parts of northeast Bay of Bengal.

This year, the all-India rainfall during the southwest monsoon is forecast to be below normal and quantitatively remain 90 per cent of the Long Period Average of 870mm (1971-2020).

The monsoon onset over the Andaman Sea and neighbouring areas was realised on May 16 this year, which was nearly a week ahead of normal.

Over 400 alleged Bangladeshi migrants detained in holding centres across Bengal

Atri Mitra
& Ravik Bhattacharya
Kolkata, May 30

IN THE first seven days after opening holding centres across the state, the West Bengal administration has so far apprehended around 400 alleged Bangladeshi citizens for deportation.

According to the state administration, the highest number of detentions are from the Basirhat police district, where 335 alleged undocumented immigrants have been detained. The detainees here have been kept in Tentulghati, Pathorshati, Charghat and Subhashnagar flood centres.

Apart from Basirhat, alleged Bangladeshi immigrants have also been detained in Malda, Murshidabad and South Dinajpur districts. It has also been learnt that the detainees are being kept in police districts such as Baruiipur, Barasat, Cooch Behar, Jangipur, Krishnanagar and Bongaon. The state admin-



A deportation centre set up in Murshidabad district, West Bengal.

istration has further tightened security and surveillance at all the holding centres here. According to sources, the district administrations concerned have also been given special instructions to ensure that the detention and deportation process is completed swiftly and smoothly.

Sources said that the holding centres are being continuously monitored and additional police have been deployed to maintain

law and order there.

Meanwhile, four labourers from Kerala are among the Bangladeshi immigrants who came to the Hakimpur border outpost on May 26. They came here in a bid to return home, but were sent to a detention centre in North 24 Parganas district.

Speaking over the phone, Motleb Hossain, one of the four youths, said, “Our biometrics were done yesterday. They took

our fingerprints and other information. The BSF officials also interrogated us and took all details of how we entered India and where we worked and stayed. We told them everything.”

Another youth, Fahim Malida said they were being provided with proper food at the centre. “But we want to return home. We have been told that soon we will be sent back to Bangladesh.” The group had crossed into India about eight months ago with help of a tout.

“The tout who helped us cross took Rs 7,000 per head,” said Malida. From there, they took a bus to Kerala where they worked as a mason on a daily wage of Rs 1,000. “The trouble started after polls. They (landlords) wanted Aadhar cards to allow us to stay. We didn’t have that, so we decided to return. An Indian tout promised a safe return... Later, he brought us to checkpoint and suddenly left. We had given him Rs 10,000 per head,” Malida added.

Hamirpur bridge collapse: FIR against contractor firm, owner and supervisor

Express News Service
Lucknow, May 30

A DAY after six labourers were killed in Uttar Pradesh’s Hamirpur district when a concrete slab from an under-construction bridge over the Betwa river collapsed on them, police on Saturday registered an FIR against the private construction firm engaged in the project, its owner, and a supervisor.

The FIR has been filed against the Kanpur-based construction agency, M/S The Sheter, its owner Vijay Pratap Singh and supervisor Nitish Sachan, on a complaint filed by Dileep Kumar, deputy project manager of the UP State Bridge Corporation Limited which had contracted the project to the firm. Charges of causing death by negligence and acts endangering life or personal safety of others have been invoked against them.

The complainant alleged that on the intervening night of Thursday and Friday, a severe



Officials at the site of the bridge collapse, which left six labourers dead and three injured, in Hamirpur district, Uttar Pradesh. PTI

high-velocity windstorm, coupled with the contractor’s negligence, led to the collapse and damage of a segmental span of the under-construction bridge. The six labourers sitting beneath the span were buried under the debris, he added.

Hamirpur Circle Officer Rajesh Kamal said no arrests have been made so far in the case and further action will be taken based on the evidence gathered during the investigation.

The 800-metre-long bridge

has been under construction since 2024 and is being built to connect Mora Kandaur and Kandaur villages in Kurara block of the district.

Following the incident, the State Bridge Corporation suspended assistant engineer Gajendra Chaudhary while a departmental inquiry was initiated against Dileep Kumar, the deputy project manager.

The department has set up a three-member committee to probe the exact cause of collapse.

{ FROM PAGE 1 }

How NEET 2026 breached safeguards put after 2024 leak

CONOPs, was not consistently enforced in 2026. And the person who had built and overseen that framework was gone at the wrong moment, leaving a leadership vacuum in the system during the most sensitive phase of exam preparation.

“We are missing the larger issue,” said one official, who did not wish to be identified. “If the confidential operations protocols were functioning the way they were supposed to, it would have been extremely difficult for anybody to access, retain and circulate complete sections of the paper.”

The Education Ministry and the NTA did not respond to emails seeking comment.

Two leaks, two different failures

To understand what may have gone wrong in 2026, it helps to find out how this controversy differs from 2024.

The NEET-UG 2024 scandal stemmed from vulnerabilities that emerged after the paper had left the NTA system: during printing, transportation, bank storage and movement to examination centres. The leak that year occurred in Jharkhand. Those gaps were substantially plugged ahead of NEET-UG 2025 through a series of stringent protocols — the CONOPs at the heart of these — introduced on the recommendations of a high-level committee headed by former ISRO chief K Radhakrishnan, constituted in the wake of the 2024 controversy. Four members of this very committee were tasked with overseeing the implementation of CONOPs for 2025.

CONOPs have two distinct phases. The first covers paper-setting, which happens months in advance, between December and February. The second covers paper transportation, closer to the exam, in April.

In 2024, it was the second phase that was compromised. In 2026, officials now believe it was the first — the phase that was supposed to be the most tightly sealed of all.

THE CHAIN A NEET PAPER TRAVELS, WHERE IT CAN BREAK

1 Paper-setting (Dec-Feb):

Chief paper setters, subject experts draft questions in special CONOPs room.

2 Translation (Jan-Feb):

The English master paper is translated into 12 regional languages by translators required to work inside the CONOPs room under the same strict protocols. **This is where the 2026 breach is believed to have occurred.**

3 Finalisation & encryption:

Master paper & translations are locked, encrypted and stored within NTA system before being



sent for printing.

4 Printing: Question papers are printed at designated, security-cleared facilities.

5 Packaging & dispatch:

Papers sealed in tamper-evident packaging, taken to designated strong rooms at exam cities.

6 Storage in strongrooms (April onward):

Papers kept under guard in bank vaults or designated secure locations until exam day. (The 2024 breach is believed to have happened during storage and transport)

7 Last-mile transport (Exam day):

Papers moved from strong rooms to exam centres under escort, arriving close to the start of the exam.

8 Distribution:

Centre superintendents receive sealed packets, open them in front of candidates and invigilators.

alone retained the key. Team members were also barred from participating in any external activities while paper-setting operations were underway.

“No phones, laptops, pen drives or external devices were supposed to enter the confidential operations room,” said a person familiar with the 2025 protocols. “Even movement and access inside the system was meant to be tightly controlled.”

It was inside this system, or at least one nominally bound by its rules, that the translators now accused of the leak were working. NEET-UG is conducted in 13 languages, which means the English paper must be translated into regional languages before the exam. That translation work, considered as sensitive as paper-setting itself, was required to happen inside the CONOPs room under the same strict protocols.

All three individuals arrested as translators were involved in translating the paper into Marathi. Retired Chemistry teacher PV Kulkarni, allegedly associated with the Marathi translation process, is accused of leaking the Chemistry section. Pune-based teacher Manisha Havaladar allegedly leaked the Physics section, while Manisha Mandhare is suspected of leaking Botany and Zoology questions, according to the investigators. Notably, Kulkarni was also involved in translating the

Chemistry section for the 2025 exam, the very exam the CONOPs were designed to protect.

“The entire logic of CONOPs during the paper-setting and translation phases is that no individual should be able to freely access, retain or move complete sections of the paper outside the system,” said an official associated with the examination process. “If investigators are now alleging that happened with individuals linked to different sections of the paper, then naturally questions arise about whether the safeguards developed and implemented in 2025 were enforced with the same rigour in 2026.”

A system without a steady hand

The protocols, officials insist, did not fail on their own. Some attribute it to a change in guard with gaps in transition.

After the 2024 controversy, the government removed NTA chief Subodh Kumar Singh and gave additional charge to PS Kharola, then serving as Chairman and Managing Director of the India Trade Promotion Organisation. Kharola oversaw the design and implementation of the entire CONOPs framework for 2025. But his extended tenure at the NTA expired on October 19, 2025 — just as the paper-setting cycle for NEET-UG 2026 would have been getting underway.

Between October and January, a period considered crucial for paper-setting preparation, NTA’s additional charge was handled by Navodaya Vidyalaya Samiti chairperson Rajesh Lakhani — who was simultaneously serving in his primary role elsewhere. A permanent head, Abhishek Singh, was appointed only a month before the May 3 exam.

The result was a leadership vacuum at the most sensitive moment. The protocols that Kharola had built and personally championed had no consistent owner as they were being applied for the first time without him.

“The CONOPs of 2025 did not smoothly translate into 2026. That is the core of the problem,” said one official. “These protocols are not self-executing. They require institutional ownership, consistent enforcement and leadership that understands what is at stake.”

Kharola and Lakhani did not respond to requests for a comment.

The irony of May 3

On May 3, the Education Ministry issued a press release highlighting the elaborate monitoring systems in place for NEET-UG 2026. Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan visited the NTA headquarters to supervise preparations, while ministry officials monitored examination centres round the clock for 48 hours from a control room at Ambedkar Bhawan.

Within days, however, NTA received information suggesting a possible leak in Chemistry. It began with an email. On May 7, a tip-off arrived without any attachment, just an allegation that Chemistry questions had been leaked before the exam. The agency tracked down the whistleblower the following day and obtained a PDF of a guess paper circulating online. The Chemistry questions matched.

On May 9, the highest levels of government were informed of the suspected leak, around the same time preparations

were underway for the swearing-in of West Bengal’s new chief minister. NTA and the Education Ministry were told to first confirm the suspicion, and if verified, cancel the exam.

Over May 9 and 10, Sikar police in Rajasthan, where the whistleblower was based, verified whether the guess paper PDF had been circulated before the examination. On May 11, they confirmed it had — establishing that the leak had occurred before May 3. NTA formally wrote to the ministry. The ministry formally approached the CBI. On May 12, the government announced the exam had been scrapped and the investigation handed over to the CBI.

Officials defended the decision, saying allowing the result to stand despite evidence of a leak would have strengthened what one officer called the “paper leak economy.” “Yes, something wrong happened. But there was a view that if the examination was allowed to continue, the message would go out that there are no real consequences for the exam mafia,” said a senior official. “If someone has spent lakhs procuring a question paper, then the system must ensure there are consequences for that too.”

What Comes Next

CONOPs are back in focus ahead of the NEET-UG re-test scheduled for June 21. A fresh batch of subject experts has been brought in to set the paper, though officials declined to detail the specific measures being taken.

On May 27, a meeting was held with former ISRO chief K Radhakrishnan, whose committee’s recommendations had originally shaped the 2025 CONOPs framework.

That addresses the first leg of the process, paper-setting. For the second leg, discussions are underway on whether assistance from the defence forces should be sought to strengthen the secure transportation and storage of question papers after printing.

Chaos after tech glitch hits CUET-UG exam: Re-test for 3,765

A total of 73,106 candidates were present at their allotted examination centers, and their biometric registration was completed. Out of these, 69,341 candidates (almost 95%) completed their examination at their respective centers, said the NTA.

It said the Tata Consultancy Services (TCS), involved in conducting the test, reported a technical glitch, prompting NTA to initially revise the afternoon session timing and allow full compensatory time. It asked the technical service provider to conduct a root-cause analysis and submit its report immediately.

“We understand that 3,765 candidates who were present and had completed biometric registration chose to leave before the exam could restart. For these candidates, NTA will hold a re-scheduled examination as a one-time measure,” the testing agency said in a post on X. Details of the fresh examination, it said, would be announced separately.

Earlier in the day, the NTA had announced that candidates affected by the disruption would be given another opportunity to appear for the examination.

The afternoon session was also pushed back by an hour. According to the revised timing, reporting and entry for the afternoon session began from 2.30 pm, while the examination began at 4 pm instead of 3 pm.

The NTA said candidates in the morning session were being given the full duration of the paper. The agency also said it “sincerely regrets the inconvenience caused to students and parents”.

Meanwhile, TCS CEO and MD K Krithivasan said a brief technical issue caused a delay of around two hours in the morning shift of the CUET-UG examination. “The issue was promptly identified and resolved by our technical teams and the examination has since

resumed without any impact to the sanctity of the exam,” he said. Krithivasan said teams were actively monitoring all systems and would ensure seamless conduct of computer-based tests.

At some centres, candidates said there was confusion on the ground before the revised arrangement was communicated. At Adarsh Pariksha Kendra in Noida Sector 64, some candidates said they were asked to leave the facility around 11 am after waiting for several hours. They said entry had begun around 7 am, but the examination could not begin because of server-related issues and technical errors.

A CUET candidate from Delhi, whose examination centre was in Noida, said candidates had come from several places, including Delhi, Haryana and Jaipur to take the examination.

“We were allowed entry from 7 am and kept waiting. There were server-related issues and technical errors. The invigilators told us they were unable to download the question papers. Later, we were told that further communication would be initiated by the NTA,” the candidate said, adding that many candidates had left the examination centre after being told to leave the premises.

The disruption caused inconvenience to candidates and parents, particularly those who had travelled from other states to the designated examination centres. A woman, whose daughter appeared for the exam at the Ion Digital Centre in Sector 62, Noida, said students were made to wait for nearly two-and-a-half hours amid uncertainty over whether the examination would be conducted. “Initially, they were informed that the exam had been cancelled. Despite this, they were not allowed to leave and told to remain seated inside the classrooms,” she said.

Cockroaches of the world have united



ACROSS THE AISLE
BY P CHIDAMBARAM

COCKROACH IS not a *bad* word or an abuse. A search in Wikipedia will reveal that cockroaches have retained their basic body structure for roughly 200 million years — that is 199,700,000 years earlier than *Homo sapiens* first emerged in Africa about 300,000 years ago. Cockroaches have a prior claim over humans to the right to exist in this world.

Science Encyclopedia tells us that cockroaches do not bite or attack people, unlike people who attack cockroaches. Of course, cockroaches carry bacteria, transmit diseases and trigger allergies. Humans also carry bacteria, transmit diseases and trigger allergies (especially among members of rival groups). Some humans consider cockroaches as ‘creepy’, not unlike some humans who consider other humans as ‘creepy’.

Stirred and shaken

Some days ago, a high dignitary stirred the cockroaches from their slumber. Bless him, he clarified promptly that he was refer-

ring to fake lawyers with fake degrees roaming around the courts. Such fake lawyers deserve to be called bad names but, I submit respectfully, *not* a cockroach. Once stirred, the cockroaches remain stirred (like ‘once a mortgage, always a mortgage’). A few stirred cockroaches have founded a political party, started an X handle, created a website and opened an Instagram handle. By last count, the handle had over 22 million followers.

The stirred cockroaches retaliated. The consequence was the humans were *stirred* and *shaken*. I suspect the humans are shaking in their *Kolhapuri* chappals. If not, why would the highest executive authority of India with Armed Forces that have 1.45 million active personnel in uniform, 4,200 main battle tanks, 580 fighter aircraft, 270 naval vessels, 2 aircraft carriers and hundreds of nuclear weapons, and a Rs 2,86,588 crore bonanza from RBI in its kitty, fear a *mere* X handle opened by a 30-year-old Abhijeet Dipke who is the flag-bearer of the digital-only Cockroach Janta Party (CJP), and ask X to close the handle?

Mr Dipke is in a far away land pursuing a Masters degree in, *phew*, ‘public relations’ (not the dangerous AI) under the care of our frenemy, Mr Donald Trump. The website set out CJP’s goals: “we own the identity of the cockroach — if that is what it takes for young people to be heard.” With its tagline as ‘Voice of the lazy and unemployed’, the CJP claims to represent the people “the system forgot to count”. He wants the unemployed, lazy, chronically online and who can rant professionally to join his party. He is inspired by

Mobility is the life-spring of cockroaches. The high fuel prices limit the mobility of cockroaches. The price of petrol in Delhi is Rs 102.12 and the price of diesel is Rs 95.20



INSIDE TRACK | BY COOMI KAPOOR

RULERS RULE CLUB CLASS

The Capital’s drawing rooms are heatedly discussing the government’s eviction threat to the hallowed Delhi Gymkhana Club. Some members, who apprehend that they could be robbed of their lifelong watering hole, now trace the origins of the dispute to the arrogant and rigid attitude of the earlier managing committees to admitting the all-powerful members of the ruling political class. For instance, Natwar Singh as club president in the mid 1970s recommended that R K Dhawan, then Indira Gandhi’s personal assistant, jump the long membership waiting list, but was overruled. L K Advani was rather grudgingly admitted. And the managing committee quibbled about granting a five-year extension to former Haryana CM Bhupinder Hooda, an accomplished tennis player who has even played against Boris Becker. The club’s admission policy in its eminent person’s category is unabashedly transactional, limited to a person’s tenure in office! In contrast, the Delhi Golf Club liberally enrolled members recommended by the Urban Development Ministry, which periodically extends the lease terms for its 180 acres. Kamal Nath, who was minister in charge when the lease last came up for renewal, in fact, demanded unofficial, out-of-turn membership quota for his nominees for the next 20 years. During Modi’s regime, several of these memberships were cancelled and BJP nominees, including a former RSS pracharak, were enrolled in their place! Mumbai’s Western India Turf Club, the Willingdon Club and the Bombay Gymkhana have all opened their doors to officialdom, through a compromise of give and take.

REPORT CARD GLOOM

Prime Minister Modi’s mood and body language at the 4.5-hour-long Cabinet meeting at Seva Teerth this month was stern and somber, reflecting the gloomy economic outlook and looming global instability. It was not the ministers alone who were tense but also secretaries to the GoI, since the performance ratings of a dozen ministries was publicly appraised. Besides, ranking of ministries in terms of the top five and bottom five were announced for several criteria, including speed of clearance of files, redressal of public grievances and extent of execution of government policy. Many apprehend that the meeting was a prelude to a Cabinet reorganisation. The buzz is that the PM is waiting for the inauspicious month of *Purushottam Maas* (which extends from May 17 to June 15 in the Hindu calendar) to pass. But the delay has heightened public restiveness over issues, from examination fiascos and fuel shortages to a falling rupee and breakdown of essential services in cities in this summer’s record-breaking heat.

STATEWIDE ANXIETY

The party leadership is reportedly unhappy with some BJP CMs from heartland states. The blame, however, cannot be attributed to the CMs alone — they were catapulted to top positions without having the necessary political heft or administrative experience. The fact that a senior Cabinet minister has recently delegated some of his important duties to his minister of state has added grist to the rumour mill.

Yogi Adityanath, a seasoned CM who faces an election next year, is, however, almost certain to continue. Adityanath has successfully guarded his turf from outside interference. An example of his ability to neutralise attempts to rein him in is the posting in Lucknow in 2022 of a well-regarded IAS officer who previously worked in the Capital in many key positions, including the PMO for two decades. The surmise was that the bureaucrat, who sought voluntary retirement before entering politics and joining Yogi’s cabinet, would take over a prestigious portfolio, such as Home. But the CM assigned him instead to Energy and Urban Development. With the heat wave, power shortages have spiked with complaints even from BJP MLAs.

POLITICS THROUGH MATRIMONIAL ALLIANCE

Veteran Maharashtra politician and the man for all seasons, Sharad Pawar, recently surprised his INDIA allies by chiding Opposition leaders for criticising PM Modi’s frequent foreign trips. Pawar felt that whatever their political differences, these views should not be aired while Modi was out of the country as it detracted from the Prime Minister’s efforts to project India’s image abroad. Around the same time, weathercock pollster Prashant Kishor called on Pawar. Some spot a link between Pawar’s remarks defending Modi and the fact that earlier this year, his granddaughter Revati, daughter of NCP MP Supriya Sule, was engaged to Sarang Lakhani, son of businessman Arun Lakhani, Managing Director of the Vishvaraj Group, a company specialising in infrastructure and environmental solutions. The Nagpur-based businessman is close to the RSS and it is said that the BJP’s Nagpur politicians, Nitin Gadkari and Devendra Fadnavis, played a role as matchmakers.

A farewell night to remember at Delhi’s Gymkhana Club



HISTORY HEADLINE
BY VIVEK SHUKLA

IT WAS the evening of August 6, 1947. Though it was hot in Delhi, the air carried a certain chill. The mood was sombre, somewhat sedate.

At the beautiful Delhi Gymkhana Club, the green lawns and grand ballroom were softly lit. Women turned up in colourful saris, officers in khaki uniforms. Brigadier Kodandera Madappa Cariappa (who later became India’s first Field Marshal) was the host that evening. But this was no ordinary party. Partition had been announced. The Army was also being divided. Cariappa had organised it as a farewell party for fellow officers of the British Indian Army who were now going to join the new Pakistan Army.

Cards by the “Officers of the Armed Forces of the Dominion of India” invited guests to the party to bid farewell to “Old Comrades Reception in Honour of the Officers of the Armed Forces of the Dominion of Pakistan”.

The book *Freedom at Midnight*, by Larry Collins and Dominique Lapierre, referred to this party as “the most emotional farewell”.

The club building, designed by Robert Tor Russell, was specially decorated that evening. Tents were put up on the lawns with tables full of whisky, gin, and Indian food. A band played in the ballroom. Officers hugged each other and recalled old memories.

Collins and Lapierre write about the conversations and the camaraderie at the party in great detail.

“Do you remember how we fought together on the Burma front in 1942?” a Muslim officer asked his Hindu friend.

“Yes, and that night when we faced the Japanese attack? You saved my life,” the other replied, with tears in his eyes.

The host of the evening, Brigadier Cariappa, was the first Indian commander of the Rajput Regiment. He was tall, had a strong face, but a soft heart. As the evening

Gandhi, Ambedkar and Nehru. CJP’s manifesto makes one laugh and think; the usual political party’s manifesto makes one sleep.

“It is the cause...”

I think CJP is counting on the widespread disappointment, distress and frustration among people, especially among the youth including young women. The causes are: **UNEMPLOYMENT:** The unemployment rate is 5.2%; youth unemployment rate is 16-17%. The Work Force is 64.3 crore and the Labour Force Participation Rate is, at best, 60%. The remaining 40% or about 25 crore are, pardon me, cockroaches. If the CJP gets all the cockroach votes, it will form the government. (In the 2024 LS elections, BJP got 23.6 crore votes and the Congress 13.7 crore votes).

PETROL & DIESEL: Mobility is the life-spring of cockroaches. The high fuel prices limit the mobility of cockroaches. The price of petrol in Delhi is Rs 102.12 and the price of diesel is Rs 95.20. For voting for the BJP, residents of Kolkata have been rewarded with prices of Rs 113.51 and Rs 99.82, respectively. **JOBS IN FACTORIES:** Cockroaches are, by definition, lazy. Since they do not get up early every morning to attend the neighbourhood *shakha*, they will never be employed by the government. The next best is a factory job. According to MoSPI, there are 260,061 registered factories in India. The estimate of the number of jobs in factories is 1.95 crore. Many jobs will be redundant because of AI, and the 25 crore cockroaches will never get a factory job. Hence, the frustration.

FAMILY SUPPORT: Cockroaches are supported by families, especially mothers, in return for the 5 kg of free grain that they bring to the family every month. Since the household debt is 42% of GDP and household savings are only 5-6% of GDP, cockroaches receive little cash support from families, and are desperately cashless. **VIKSIT BHARAT BILLIONAIRE:** Cockroaches hoped to become billionaires in *Viksit Bharat*. However, despite 12 years of BJP rule, the number of billionaires is rising at a painfully slow pace. The latest count is 205, and there are 25 crore cockroaches in the line waiting to become billionaires. They are also waiting for the Rs 15 lakh of *achhe din aayenge* promised in 2014.

C-EA dashes hopes

The cockroaches turned to the Cockroaches Economic Adviser. The C-EA’s advice was sombre: “The trade deficit will widen significantly in FY27, as will the current account deficit. Inflation risks are tilted to the upside. A below-normal monsoon adds an agricultural dimension to a complex supply shock. The task of attracting stable long-term capital — through credible tax policy, regulatory predictability, and reduced friction for investors — intensifies in these conditions” (*The Indian Express*, May 23, 2026).

Catastrophe is foretold. The cockroaches may decide that the only way to prevent the catastrophe is to seek a peaceful transfer of power, with the aid of CEC, from humans to cockroaches.



The Gymkhana Club, founded in 1913, now faces eviction. GAJENDRA YADAV

grew darker, he climbed onto the raised platform in the ballroom and asked everyone to be quiet.

All eyes turned to him. “My dear comrades,” he said in a deep voice, “we have shared a common destiny for so long that our story cannot be separated. We were brothers. We will always remain brothers. And we will never forget the great years we spent together.”

The hall fell completely silent. Then, the clapping started. Many officers had tears in their eyes. A Major who was going to Pakistan stepped forward and hugged Cariappa tightly. “Sir, this is very painful,” he said. Cariappa smiled and replied, “It is painful because our bond was deep. But even in this new beginning, we must keep this friendship alive.”

The party continued late into the night. Officers kept sharing old stories from the Second World War and their cantonment days. Women sat in a corner, talking. Some wondered what tomorrow would bring. The journey from Delhi to Lahore and Rawalpindi would now mean crossing the border of enmity.

A young Captain who was going to Pakistan told his Indian friend, “My belongings are still in Delhi. I thought I would come back and take them once things become normal.”

His friend patted his shoulder and said, “Yes, definitely come. We will wait for you.”

But history had something else in store. Just a few months later, war broke out in

Kashmir. The same officers who had left their belongings behind were now fighting on the enemy side.

The writers of *Freedom at Midnight* describe the atmosphere at the club that evening as one of “great sadness”. The Gymkhana Club, which was once only for the British elite, had become a witness to the emotions of Indian and Pakistani officers.

That evening, a Muslim officer going to Pakistan, Brigadier Aga Raza, was given a special gift by his junior officers. According to the book, “Raza plucked the protective cloth from the trophy and held it up to the crowd. Fashioned by a silversmith in old Delhi, it represented two sepoy, one Hindu, one Moslem, standing side by side, rifles at their shoulders trained upon some common foe.”

But it didn’t take long for that evening of friendship to turn into nights of hostility.

Cariappa went on to become the first Commander-in-Chief of the Indian Army. But he remained a professional soldier all his life. He always spoke of friendship with Pakistan. Even when his own son was a prisoner of war in Pakistan, he put the nation first.

The memory of that evening lives on at the Gymkhana Club. The club faces new challenges today, but that farewell party of 1947 remains a proud part of its history.

The writer is Ex-Advisor (History), Indira Gandhi Centre for Arts and Culture

Parliament has become a private club



FIFTH COLUMN
BY TAVLEEN SINGH

WHAT INTRIGUED me about the government’s decision to sound the death knell of the Delhi Gymkhana Club was the timing. Why now?

Could it be to distract attention from the economic problems caused by the war on Iran? In these times of social media, it is stories that everyone has an opinion about that take precedence over grim news like the price of fuel rising and foreign investors fleeing our shores. Whatever the reason, I am delighted that the club was given marching orders.

Not because I think it is a good idea to demolish this charming relic of our colonial past but because the decision could start a movement to end the privileges of our politicians and high officials. It is a movement that is much needed. Among the heated debates that happened last week on television and social media the one thing everyone agreed on was that this private club was a symbol of the entitlement and privilege that makes the word ‘lootys’ an insult. Somehow nobody has noticed yet that the most entitled and privileged private club in Lutyens’ Delhi is not the Gymkhana but the Lok Sabha. Just over 30% of its members come from political families which means one in three of our elected representatives is a nepo baby. Nepotism is less evident in the Rajya Sabha but 20% of its members also come from political families.

So, if we object to people inheriting their membership at the Gymkhana Club, then we must first acknowledge that this is not half as disquieting as politicians inheriting parliamentary constituencies. A desire for public service is not something that comes down in the genes so every time some nepo baby inherits a constituency, it is denied to a person with a genuine desire for public service. Yet we never protest when our political parties hand out tickets at election time to candidates from political families. The sad truth is that other than the communists, all our opposition parties are today family businesses. Nepo babies can be spotted in the BJP as well, but the party itself has not yet become some political heirloom.

In the debates we heard last week about the cancellation of the lease of the Gymkhana Club’s 27 acres, those who said this was a good thing argued that public land needs to be better used. True. And this is why this columnist has argued for many years that it is time to throw politicians and bureaucrats out of their colonial bungalows in Lutyens’ Delhi. This is public land that can be much better used for creating affordable rental housing for the millions of people in Delhi who live in shamefully squalid shanties. An estimated 30-50 lakh Delhi citizens live in horrible conditions in shanty towns that sometimes exist on the edge of garbage dumps in which children compete with stray animals in their search for food. Is it acceptable that the men responsible for building low-cost housing themselves live like princes?

Most democratic countries do not ask taxpayers to pay for housing public servants. But since we have spoiled ours so badly for so many decades, I would like to offer a humble suggestion. Since ‘national security’ was given as a reason to get rid of the Gymkhana Club, would it not be a good idea to move the Prime Minister into a permanent residence like Teen Murti House? Or instead of wasting money on a new residence for the Prime Minister, why not move him into Hyderabad House or one of those other fine palaces that exist around India Gate?

Another question we need to start asking is why Rashtrapati Bhawan needs to sit in an estate that is slightly more than 300 acres? Surely a 20-acre garden would suffice for the President of India, and the rest of that public land could be used to house ministers and high officials? This would reduce what we spend on security, and we might save some money on their travel since they would then be close enough to their offices to walk. There are countries in the ‘viksit’ western world where prime ministers, presidents and princes all use public transport. Our politicians and officials believe that there is a constant threat to their lives so that cannot happen, but a healthy walk accompanied by two security men would do wonders for their health.

If the Gymkhana Club refuses to pay market rent, then it must go. But this should be the first step in a bigger readjustment of Lutyens’ Delhi. Or it will be clear that the real reason why this club has been targeted is because it is considered the last bastion of that ‘English-speaking ruling class’ that the new rulers of India so despise. At this point I must clarify that although I am a proud member of that old ruling class (AKA Khan Market gang), I am in fact not a member of the Gymkhana Club.

Like a lot of other people, I have been trying to change my dependent member card to a full membership for more than thirty years. I also need to clarify that in the past thirty years I have been to the Gymkhana Club no more than five or six times. Usually for someone else’s party or for someone’s wedding. It is here that the indigent ‘elite’ come because they cannot afford five-star hotels.

The End of Nine-to-Five



ON THE LOOSE
BY LEHER KALA

There’s the thought deeply rooted in history that a person who doesn’t work full time may be morally suspect. (An idle mind is the devil’s workshop.) Even the Bible warned, “He who does not work, neither shall he eat.” Throughout the ages but especially in the last hundred years, our self worth is inextricably tied up with productivity and success. The first question anyone asks at a party is, what do you do? The right answer raises one’s stature. But we’re entering an era of the very real possibility that people will wake up in the morning and have nowhere to go and nothing to do. Will how we view work change? Perhaps, at social gatherings, the initial question will be asking about peoples’ hobbies instead.

For too long, we have all fallen for the righteous view that one must have some kind of vocation to justify a right to existence. People who have enough don’t necessarily have to “earn a living”. They shouldn’t be sneered at for going back to learning or en-

gaging in community service. It should strike anyone as odd that volunteering in India is seen as a euphemism for being incapable of finding something real. Governments have their own sobering motivations to keep inventing employment schemes — like India’s MNREGA — a large population with too much free time poses a danger to the social order. The Pope is right when he says that people feel a need to contribute meaningfully to the world but it’s easy to forget that of the three billion working people on this planet, most wake up and head to unskilled, labour-intensive employment. They’re sanguine about the drudgery involved because they need the money. Work is rarely worship. For most, it’s a means of survival.

For the well qualified, if AI hogs all the boring job options humanity relies on for a paycheck, dare we hope that after the initial shake up, people will pivot back and pursue whatever genuinely brings them joy? It’s a widespread reality that most people hate

their jobs. Often, circumstances dictate careers and ambition requires making cold blooded choices. If there’s no security in anything, one is free to choose whatever one enjoys.

Work will, in fact, become a perpetual hustle. Till quite recently, people went about careers knowing it’s a slow and patient climb up a corporate ladder but there are regular increments and better designations along the way. It’s not that this kind of quiet toiling didn’t have its frustrations but there’s comfort in knowing that one could join an organisation and not worry about getting sacked. Sure, there’s freedom in carving out one’s own (tentative) path but it comes with a lot of stressful uncertainty. One must have some sympathy for the 20-somethings entering the workplace who have no idea how a new technological age will reshape their lives.

The writer is director, Hutkay Films

PENTAGON CHIEF SAYS TRUMP IS ‘PATIENT’ AND WANTS DEAL WHICH ENSURES IRAN DOES NOT GET NUCLEAR WEAPONS

US ready to resume strikes on Iran if no deal: Hegseth

Trump to make decision on extending truce

Reuters
Singapore, May 30

THE US is ready to restart attacks on Iran if a deal cannot be reached, Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth said on Saturday, as negotiators from Washington and Tehran worked to bridge major differences blocking an agreement. “Our ability to recommence if necessary...we are more than capable,” Hegseth said in Singapore.

“Our stockpiles are more than suited for that, both there and around the globe, so we’re in a very good place,” he added.

Hegseth, speaking at the Shangri-La Dialogue, Asia’s premier forum for defence leaders, militaries and diplomats, said the US has not turned its back on the Asia-Pacific region despite being engaged in conflict with Iran.

“We can do two things at one time. We’re super-charging our defence industrial base so that we’re building 2X, 3X, 4X the munitions very soon to ensure that all of our (operations) plans are properly funded throughout the world,” he said.



A drone view shows vessels anchored at the Strait of Hormuz, as seen from Musandam, Oman, on Saturday. REUTERS

The Pentagon chief said President Donald Trump was “patient” and wants to make a “great deal” that ensures Iran does not get a nuclear weapon.

Meanwhile on Saturday, the US military stopped another merchant vessel trying to break through the American blockade of Iranian ports, a US official with knowledge of the situation told *The Associated Press*.

The Gambia-flagged bulk carrier *Lian Star* ignored multiple warnings from US forces overnight as it tried to enter an Iranian port, the official, who spoke on condition of anonymity to discuss military operations, said.

The ship was disabled by US aircraft in the Gulf of Oman and remains adrift there, the official said, adding that US forces have not boarded it.

With the latest action, US military has stopped six ships trying to breach the blockade. One was allowed to proceed.

On Friday, Trump said he would meet in a secure White House room to make a “final determination” on a proposal to end the Iran war, which would extend an early-April truce for another 60 days, giving negotiators time to forge a permanent end to the conflict.

A White House official said the meeting in the Situation

Room lasted about two hours, but did not address whether Trump had made a decision.

“President Trump will only make a deal that is good for America and satisfies his red-lines. Iran can never possess a nuclear weapon,” the official said. A senior Iranian source told *Reuters* an agreement was close but had not yet been approved.

However, Trump also said Iran would have to end its chokehold on the Strait of Hormuz and dismantle its capacity to make a nuclear weapon - two conditions that Tehran has not agreed to. “Iran must agree that they will never have a Nuclear Weapon or Bomb. The Hormuz Strait must be immediately open, no tolls, for unrestricted shipping traffic, in both directions,” Trump said, adding that nuclear material would be “unearthed” by the US.

Iran’s semi-official *Fars* news agency, citing sources, said Trump’s comments were an “attempt to portray a fabricated victory.” The senior Iranian source, speaking on condition of anonymity, said the potential deal does not include any nuclear-related issues, while Iran’s Foreign Ministry spokesperson Esmail Baghaei said on state TV that the management of the strait must be decided by Iran and Oman.

Hardliners in Tehran try to derail potential deal with Washington

Farnaz Fassihi
May 29

AS IRAN and the United States appeared to be nearing an agreement to end hostilities this week, not everyone in Iran was on board.

The hard-line faction, a fringe but loud group with members in Parliament and a seat on the Supreme National Security Council, has openly opposed any concessions to Washington, using rallies, state media and private and public statements as tools to try to derail a deal.

It remains unclear when an actual agreement will be announced, if at all. President Trump met for two hours with cabinet members in the Situation Room at the White House on Friday, but he put off making a final decision, according to a senior administration official.

Iran’s lead negotiator, Gen. Mohammad Bagher Ghalibaf, said in a social media post earlier in the day that Tehran did not trust Washington and that no step would “be taken before the other side acts first.”

But in Iran the political fight continues. State television, which is controlled by a hard-line director, has amplified the divisions in the country and portrayed negotiations as a fail-

ure. On Monday, President Masoud Pezeshkian scolded state television in a meeting with its senior leaders, calling on them to avoid sowing discord.

Pezeshkian said even Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, the former supreme leader killed on the first day of the war, “agreed that we must go to the negotiation table.” “But now,” he continued, “we are advertising that we should not negotiate.”

At a packed rally of hard-line supporters in Tehran on Friday, large crowds waved flags and chanted for defiance. A state television reporter asked some attendees if Iran should retreat or continue fighting the United States and Israel.

“We want them to punish them good,” one woman attendee said. “Stand firm, we are with you until our last drop of blood,” said one man.

“Trump must know that Iran, as the victor and conqueror of the field, sets the terms,” said Ebrahim Azizi, a conservative lawmaker and the head of Parliament’s national security and foreign policy committees, in a social media post on Friday. Analysts close to the government in Iran say that the hard-line faction represents a minority view, both in the general public and among officials. NYT

• BRIEFLY



Rescuers after they safely evacuated the villagers, who had been trapped in a cave in Xaisomboun province, Laos, on Saturday. AP

LAOS

Rescuers pull four from flooded cave in Laos, two still missing

RESCUERS PULLED four people from a flooded cave in Laos on Saturday, Thai volunteer rescuers said, hours after another man was brought out late on Friday. The five are among seven Lao nationals who had entered the cave in Xaisomboun province to prospect for gold, but were trapped for more than a week when rising water blocked their exit. Two others remain missing, Kengkard Bongkawong, a Thai cave diver involved in the mission, said in a Facebook post on Saturday that all four of the trapped people had emerged from the cave. REUTERS

GERMANY

Drone sighting disrupts flights at Munich airport

FLIGHTS WERE halted for about an hour at Munich Airport in Germany on Saturday morning after two pilots reported seeing a drone, airport authorities and police said, confirming initial reports by German media. During the shutdown more than 20 flights that had been due to land at Munich were diverted to other airports, an airport spokesperson said. REUTERS

GHANA

Bill criminalizing LGBT promotion gets House nod

GHANA’S PARLIAMENT on Friday approved a new bill that criminalizes the so-called promotion of LGBTQ activity, part of a broader crackdown on sexual minorities in West Africa. The Human Sexual Rights and Family Values Bill, passed by a voice vote after Constitutional and Legal Affairs Committee recommended adoption, said deputy speaker Bernard Ahiafor. REUTERS

• NEIGHBOURHOOD WATCH

SRILANKA

Buddhist monk suspended over abuse charges

THE POWERFUL Buddhist clergy in Sri Lanka on Saturday stripped a senior monk facing charges of child abuse after weeks of relentless pressure. Pallegama Hemarathana was on May 14 ordered to be remanded after being arrested on May 9 following a probe into a case of child sexual abuse. PTI

PAKISTAN

Security forces kill 5 terrorists in KPK province

PAKISTANI SECURITY forces have killed five terrorists during an operation in the Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province, police said on Saturday. The operation was conducted in Darra Adam Khel town of Kohat district, some 30 km southwest of Peshawar on Friday. Two soldiers also died in a fierce exchange of fire. PTI

Inside Ebola epicentre, the virus rages with little to stop it

Declan Walsh
Mongbwalu, May 30

IN THE cramped, dilapidated Ebola ward, a 5-year-old boy languished on a bare mattress, a tissue stuffed into his nose to stanch the incessant bleeding. His father stood over him, eyes clouded with worry.

A few beds away lay the body of Christiane Bahati, 21, who had died seven hours earlier but had not yet been taken away. Her shoes were still tucked under the bed, her wailing relatives gathered outside the ward doors.

The body, covered by a thin sheet, was highly contagious. Yet hardly anyone in the ward was protected. Relatives came and went, carrying food and

water to ailing patients because the hospital had none to give them. A few wore rubber gloves or pulled a scarf across their mouths. Most had nothing at all.

In the next ward lay the hospital’s laboratory technician, also sick. Seven other hospital workers had already died from suspected Ebola.

Few of the staff members had ever been trained to fight the disease, and the most rudimentary equipment was in dangerously short supply: tests, protective suits, goggles, masks, even drinking water.

Outside, the sound of hammering broke the hushed silence. Aid workers from Doctors Without Borders were racing to erect isolation tents and disinfection stations.



Dr Alex Bogole, a Congolese doctor in the hospital’s intensive care ward, was furious. The virus had been spread-

ing for months, virtually unimpeded, “and this is the best we can do?” he said, the frustration pouring through his protective

gear. This is the epicenter of the Ebola outbreak in the Democratic Republic of Congo, and the front line is completely overwhelmed.

The Congolese Health Ministry declared the outbreak on May 15, and it has already ballooned into the third largest on record. Two weeks later, the international response is being outpaced by the virus, and there is almost nothing to slow it down. Aid groups warn that without urgent intervention, this could be the world’s deadliest Ebola outbreak ever.

Dr Bogole was never trained for this and was angry at everyone — at the Congolese government for failing to detect the outbreak until perhaps six weeks after it began, and at the

world, which has barely mobilized help here in Mongbwalu, a remote gold mining town of about 150,000 where the outbreak is believed to have started.

“They hold meetings and meetings,” he said, struggling to contain his disdain. “What is the purpose of these meetings? People are dying, people are getting infected, people are in danger. It’s very slow.”

Giant trucks, curling through lush hills, leave blinding clouds of dust. Edgy-looking Congolese soldiers guard checkpoints that are often little more than string.

Gold miners and people fleeing rebel conflict stream in and out of Mongbwalu, providing an excellent vector for the spread of the virus. NYT

Ukraine keeps up strikes on Russian oil sites as Kyiv expects more attacks

Associated Press
Moscow, May 30

UKRAINIAN DRONE strikes caused fires at more Russian oil facilities overnight into Saturday, Russian officials said, in what appeared to be latest attack on Moscow’s vital oil industry.

Authorities in Russia’s Rostov region said falling drone debris sparked a fire that damaged an oil depot and tanker in the port of Taganrog, while officials in the neighbouring Krasnodar region reported a fire breaking out at an oil depot in Armavir.

“Another facility of Russia’s oil industry has been reached - Armavir,” Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy wrote on X, referring to the Krasnodar attack, and noting that Armavir is



Smoke rises after a Ukrainian drone attack on an oil refinery and terminal in Tuapse region of Russia on Saturday. AP

“500 kilometers from our state border.” “We are rightfully bringing the war back to where it came from,” he wrote.

Kyiv is bracing for further heavy bombardments after what the Russian Foreign Ministry said earlier this week would

be upcoming “systemic strikes” on Ukraine. The attacks on Russian oil infrastructure came a day after a Russian drone that was part of an attack on Ukraine struck an apartment building in eastern Romania, injuring two in the NATO member country.

Top US commander meets Cuban military officials amid Trump pressure

Associated Press
Havana, May 30

THE TOP US commander in Latin America met with Cuban military leaders on Friday in a “brief exchange on operational security matters” near the US Navy base in Guantanamo Bay, the latest official to visit the island nation as President Donald Trump ramps up pressure on its leaders.

Trump has warned that Cuba “is next” after US military forces captured Venezuela’s autocratic leader, Nicolas Maduro, in a January raid.

In the months since, the Trump administration has im-

posed an oil blockade on Cuba, maintained warships in the Caribbean Sea and indicted former Cuban President Raul Castro on federal charges.

General Francis Donovan, head of US Southern Command, met with Lieutenant General Roberto Legra Sotolongo and other Cuban military officials.

Cuba’s Revolutionary Armed Forces said in a statement that both sides viewed “the meeting positively because it addressed security issues along the perimeter separating the military enclave, and they agreed to maintain communication between the two military commands”.

22 killed after truck carrying Afghan refugees overturns

Associated Press
Kabul, May 30

A TRUCK carrying Afghan refugees returning from neighboring Pakistan overturned on a highway in eastern Afghanistan on Saturday, killing at least 22 people and injuring about 36 others, most of them women and children, officials said.

The accident occurred in Laghman province on the main highway linking Kabul, the Afghan capital, with Nangarhar province, said Abdul Malik Niaza, the spokesperson for the provincial governor.

He said among the dead were 10 children and five women, and the injured were taken to hospitals in Nangarhar.



An man receives treatment at a hospital in Jalalabad after the accident in Laghman province on Saturday. AP

The provincial director of public health, Aminullah Sharif, said 22 people were killed and about 36 injured. He said the accident occurred when the truck

fell into a ditch after the driver fell asleep.

The passengers were among thousands of Afghans who recently returned from Pakistan, which launched a crackdown on migrants in 2023, and has since deported or pressured many to leave. Iran also intensified expulsions of Afghan migrants around the same time. Since then, millions of Afghans have returned home from the two countries, including many who were born in Pakistan and had spent decades working there.

In a separate accident in the eastern province of Nuristan, a car fell off the road into a river on Friday night, injuring the driver and leaving four passengers missing, governor’s office said.

• BELGIUM’S POTATO HARVEST SETS A RECORD, JUST AS TARIFFS HIT U.S. DEMAND FOR FROZEN FRIES AND AS COMPETITION FROM SUPPLIERS IN ASIA INTENSIFIES

The world capital of French fries has a problem: Too many potatoes and no buyers

Jenny Gross
Walhain (Belgium), May 30

A THOUSAND tons of potatoes were stacked 15 feet high in a warehouse on Kris D’haeyere’s farm for months. Even though he offered to sell them for just a couple of euros per ton, no one wanted to buy them.

So D’haeyere did the unthinkable: This month, he dumped the crop back into his fields in eastern Belgium, the cheapest way to dispose of enough potatoes to make 200 million French fries.

Other farmers are doing the same, as Europe faces a surplus of five million metric tons of the type of potato used for fries.

For months, the price of a metric ton of potatoes on the spot market in Belgium, the world’s biggest exporter of frozen fries, has languished at precisely zero. It was nearly 600 euros (\$690) three years ago.

The great potato glut of 2026 is the result of several factors, some meteorological and others geopolitical.

Good weather produced the biggest European potato harvest in eight years, just as farmers were struggling to sell their crops because the Trump administration’s tariffs hit their exports and new competitors from Asia took market share. More recently, the war in Iran has pushed up prices for energy

and fertilizer and made consumers cut back, shrinking profit margins that were already as thin as a shoestring fry.

“Of course it’s bad,” D’haeyere, 58, said, “but that’s life.” His unsold potatoes had started to sprout, making them impossible to offload. It hit him with a loss of €160,000 on soil, seedlings, fertilizer, labor and other costs and forced him to dip into his savings, he said.

D’haeyere planted 17 acres of potatoes for next season, a fraction of the 170 acres he usually plants on his 370-acre farm in Hermalle-sous-Huy, Belgium.

In Germany, another major potato producer, a farmer with 4,000 tons of unwanted pota-



atoes arranged a series of giveaways in Berlin, which locals refer to as the “Kartoffel-Flut,” or potato flood.

But nowhere has a mismatch in potato supply and demand been more acutely felt than in Belgium, the world’s

biggest exporter of frozen fries. Frites are a national symbol, and friteries — what French-speaking Belgians call the stands that sell cardboard cones stuffed with fries — are ubiquitous in public squares across the country. Belgians smother their frites in a variety of elaborate sauces, including andalouse, a mayonnaise blend with tomato paste and bell peppers, and dallas, which has fried onion, tomato and herbs.

Belgium exported \$3.3 billion of cooked, frozen potatoes in 2025, nearly triple the amount a decade earlier, according to the EU’s statistics agency.

The war in Iran is the latest source of strain on the supply

chain for frozen fries, said Christophe Vermeulen, the chief executive of Belgapom, Belgium’s potato processing association.

Higher energy costs make refrigeration and transport more expensive. Skyrocketing fertilizer costs also make farming more expensive, with ships carrying fertilizer ingredients unable to exit the Persian Gulf because of a blockade on the Strait of Hormuz.

The blockade has also made it harder to export fries to countries including Qatar, the UAE and Saudi Arabia, all major French fry consumers. Gulf countries are likely to need fewer fries anyway, with fewer tourists

staying at resorts and eating at restaurants, Vermeulen said.

Closer to home, rising inflation has forced many Europeans to think twice about going out to restaurants, where most fries are consumed, said Niels van der Boom, an analyst at DCA Market Intelligence, which specializes in commodity markets.

These challenges come as US tariffs on imports have made European fries more expensive in the United States, their second-largest market after Britain. Exports of frozen fries from the EU to the US were down 8 percent over the 12 months ending Feb. 28, according to World Potato Markets, a magazine. NYT

RECENT HIKE IN FUEL PRICES MAY ACTIVATE BOTH DIRECT AND INDIRECT TRANSMISSION CHANNELS

Must be vigilant on inflation, may face demand headwinds: Fin Min

The comments come days before the RBI's rate setting panel announces its interest rate decision on June 5

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, May 30

CONSUMPTION DEMAND in India may face headwinds in the coming months with economic conditions beginning to show the impact of the conflict in West Asia, the Ministry of Finance said on Saturday.

It cautioned that while the near-term outlook is one of "cautious resilience", policy will need to "remain agile across monetary, fiscal, and structural dimensions" to tackle the ongoing uncertainty and that inflation developments warrant "vigilance".

"For India, these external pressures are beginning to transmit, selectively but perceptibly, into domestic economic conditions," the finance ministry said in its Monthly Economic Review report for May, adding that the moderation in core sector growth and fuel consumption "signals that global headwinds are gradually finding their way into select segments of domestic activity."

"With forecasts pointing to a below-normal monsoon and a likely moderation in economic activity, overall consumption demand may face headwinds in the coming months," it further said.

It separately said a signifi-

cant rainfall deficit along with the current geopolitical conditions could translate into food inflation, weakening rural demand and aggregate growth.

According to data released on May 20, growth of India's eight core industries — namely coal, crude oil, natural gas, refinery products, fertilisers, steel, cement, and electricity — fell to 1.2% in March and 1.7% in April.

Meanwhile, the India Meteorological Department on Friday cut its monsoon forecast to 90% of the Long Period Average from 92% projected in April. The latest forecast is the lowest by IMD in the last 20 years. The comments by the finance ministry that policy will need to be "agile" and the inflation outlook warrants vigilance come days before the Reserve Bank of India's Monetary Policy Committee announces its interest rate decision on June 5.

After having cut the policy repo rate by 125 basis points (bps) to 5.25% in 2025, the MPC has left it unchanged so far in 2026 amid sharply higher global energy prices due to the war in West Asia, which has led to foreign investors pulling money out from Indian financial markets to the tune of \$24.2 billion since the conflict began in late February.



The finance ministry released its Monthly Economic Review report for May on Saturday. REUTERS

This has exerted tremendous pressure on the Indian rupee's exchange rate, pushing it down to multiple all-time lows. Earlier this month, it nearly breached the 97-per-dollar mark, before it was propped up by sustained RBI intervention in the foreign exchange market.

On Friday, the rupee ended at 95. It has fallen 4.2% since the war started.

While the rupee has recovered some ground in recent days, economists warn that the MPC may have to increase interest rates as early as next week. According to Standard Chartered Bank economists, the RBI may raise the repo rate by 50 bps over its June and August meetings. And they see a risk of additional 25-50 bps of hikes in 2026-27 if inflation turns out to be higher than ex-

pected due to continued pressure from commodity prices and a weak rupee.

In its report on Saturday, the finance ministry took note of the divergence between India's retail and wholesale inflation in April: 3.48% and 8.3%, respectively. This wedge, it said, is a sign that upstream cost pressures are building and the pass-through to consumers may not be far behind. "The recent hike in petrol and diesel prices may activate both direct and indirect transmission channels, and any further escalation in energy prices could narrow the existing cushion more quickly than anticipated. A deficient monsoon could add food price pressures on top of energy-driven ones. However, second-round effects and their persistence must be evident in the

• CHALLENGES AHEAD

THE FINANCE ministry took note of the divergence between India's retail and wholesale inflation in April — which stood at 3.48% and 8.3%, respectively

THIS WEDGE, it said, is a sign that upstream cost pressures are building and the pass-through to consumers may not be far behind

IT SEPARATELY said a significant rainfall deficit along with the current geopolitical conditions could translate into food inflation, weakening rural demand and aggregate growth

data for policy responses to be triggered," the finance ministry said. After holding retail fuel prices at for over two-and-a-half months amid the surge in global rates due to the West Asia crisis, public sector oil marketing companies have raised pump prices of petrol and diesel by over Rs 7 per litre in less than two weeks.

The RBI, in early April, forecast that headline retail inflation as measured by the Consumer Price Index (CPI) may average 4.6% in 2026-27, up from less than 2% in 2025-26. However, economists from outside the central bank see CPI inflation averaging more than 5%. Central banks in Asia have already begun raising interest rates, including Indonesia by 50 bps and Sri Lanka by 100 bps — both in one go — in the last 10 days.

Govt waives import duty on cotton till October 30

Ravi Dutta Mishra
New Delhi, May 30

THE GOVERNMENT on Saturday announced removal of the 11% duty on cotton starting June 1 till October 30 to boost cotton availability for India's textile industry amid the ongoing West Asia crisis.

This is the second time in the last 12 months that the duty has been removed.

A similar relief measure was extended to the industry last year after the US imposed steep tariffs on Indian exports.

The Ministry of Textiles said that the temporary duty exemption is expected to reduce input costs across the textile and apparel sector, thereby providing a targeted relief to manufacturers and consumers, while also keeping the interests of domestic farmers in mind.

"Overall, the measure is anticipated to have a positive impact on the performance of the domestic textile industry, especially the small and medium enterprises, ensuring better availability of cotton in the market," the ministry said.

The government move comes after industry executives highlighted that the price of cotton has surged nearly 10-15% during the last month alone due to hoarding, as cotton demand picked up in line with other input materials, particularly polyester.

Apparel Export Promotion Council (AEP) Chairman A Sakthivel had earlier this

month asked the government to eliminate the duty due to high cotton prices and rising input costs.

In a presentation made to the Finance, Commerce and Industry and Textile Ministry, AEP said that India has recently entered into several Free Trade Agreements (FTAs), but competing countries have lower input costs.

Mithleshwar Thakur, Secretary General AEP said, "The temporary exemption of Customs duty and Agriculture Infrastructure and Development Cess on Cotton imports from June 1, 2026 to October 30, 2026 will lead to reduction of input costs across the textile and apparel sector besides improving the availability of cotton, thereby providing much-needed relief to the downstream industry, which have been facing challenges due to the sharp increase in cotton and yarn prices."

Confederation of Indian Textile Industry (CITI) said import duty was resulting in costs going up across the value chain and having a detrimental impact on scaling India's textile and apparel exports. India's textile exports are dominated by cotton. India is the second-largest cotton producer after China, but relies on imports for about 15% of its raw cotton and about 20% of its yarn to meet demand.

India's cotton production has been declining, with experts blaming it on a range of

policy failures. They said that cotton production has stagnated for years largely due to a lack of new seeds, modern irrigation facilities, and frequent pest attacks and diseases.

Unlike several other competitors, such as Bangladesh and Vietnam, India is one of the largest producers of cotton and farmers' interests weigh on the duty-related decision.

Apparel manufacturers have said that some investments that had begun going out of the country due to tariffs have started to come back.

An industry executive, who did not wish to be named, said the sector is also seeing European investments coming into India as they are trying to diversify away from Bangladesh.

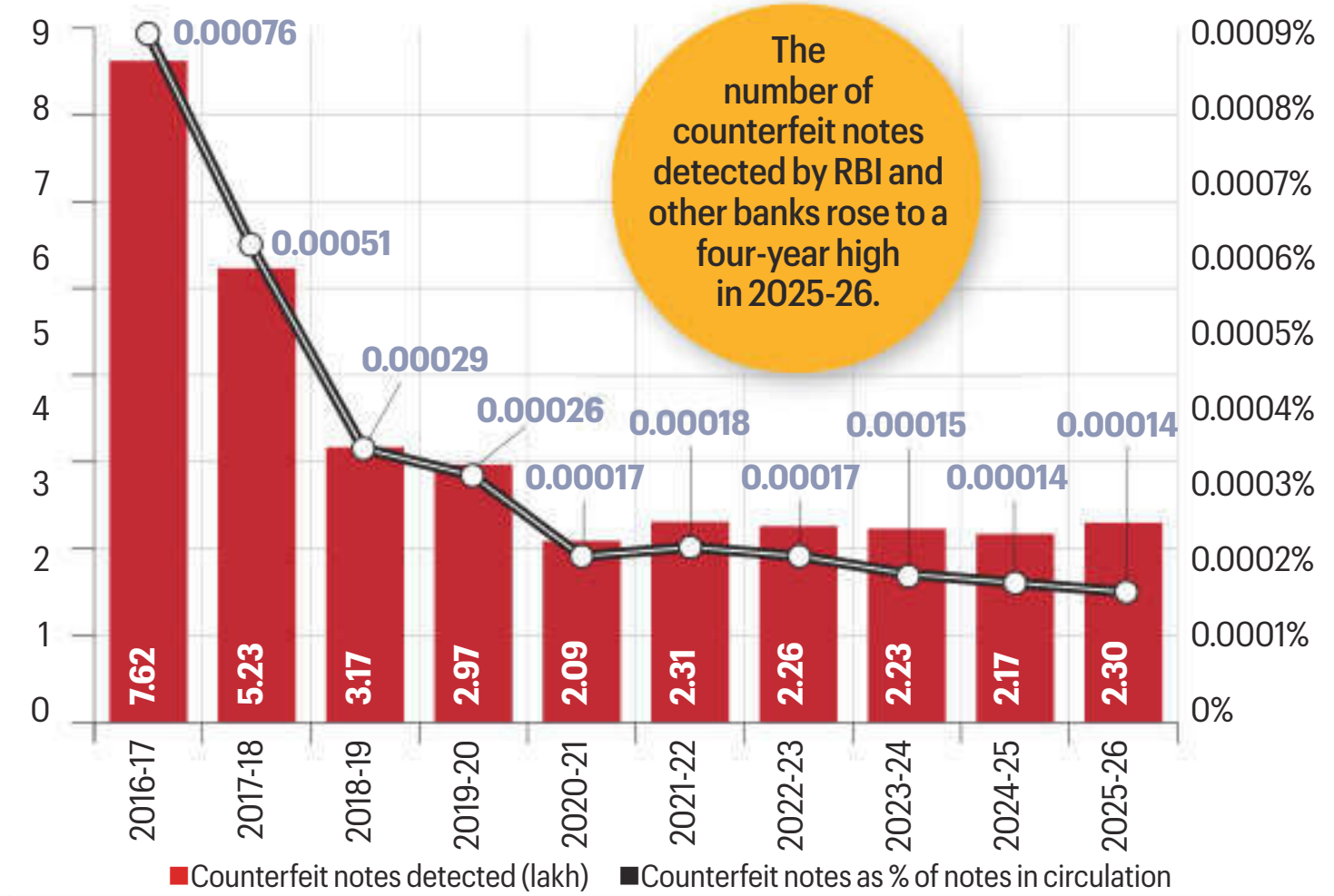
"Bangladesh has signed an FTA with the US and is also seeking a deal with the EU, as India's duty disadvantage will be eliminated soon when the deal comes into effect," the executive said.

AEP said that the textile industry's cotton requirement for the current year is projected at around 337 lakh bales, while cotton arrivals for the 2025-26 season are estimated at only 292.15 lakh bales, resulting in a supply-demand gap of nearly 45 lakh bales.

The shortfall is expected to increase pressure on spinning mills and downstream textile industries due to rising input costs and limited availability of quality raw material, the Export Promotion Council said.

• RBI, banks detected 2.3 lakh counterfeit notes in FY26

According to the Reserve Bank of India's annual report, published on Friday, the number of fake notes in the last financial year rose to 2.30 lakh from 2.17 lakh in 2024-25. However, as a percentage of all banknotes in circulation, the number of fake notes detected remains minuscule: 0.00013%. In fact, this percentage figure has now fallen for four years in a row, having stood more than five times higher at 0.00076% in 2016-17.



SOURCE: RBI

'Carbon rules, sustainability norms make ESG a compliance priority for industry'

New Delhi: Frameworks such as the EU's carbon tax and the proposed Carbon Credit Trading Scheme by India are rapidly transforming environmental, social and governance (ESG) practices from a voluntary disclosure exercise into a key business and compliance priority for industries, say experts.

Without credible carbon data systems and traceable reporting mechanisms, companies could face increasing compliance risks and competitive disadvantages

in global markets, they said.

"The next phase of ESG will be driven by implementation readiness and data credibility," World of Circular Economy (WOCE) Founder and Director Anup Garg said.

He added that frameworks such as the European Union's Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism (CBAM), India's Business Responsibility and Sustainability Reporting (BRSR) norms and the evolving Carbon Credit Trading Scheme (CCTS)

are rapidly shifting ESG from a voluntary disclosure exercise to a business and compliance priority. While sustainability intent is clearly rising, execution remains uneven, many organisations continue to struggle with structured emissions tracking, especially across supply chains and vendor ecosystems, he added.

Citing an analysis, he said that 72% of Indian companies remain at an early stage of carbon readiness despite increasing climate regulations. PTI

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

• THERE IS A SHARP MISMATCH BETWEEN THE COUNTRY'S RELATIVELY LIMITED DOMESTIC CELL MANUFACTURING CAPACITY AND ITS MUCH LARGER SOLAR MODULE MANUFACTURING BASE

Domestic solar cell mandate: How new rules may squeeze smaller manufacturers

Pratyush Deep
New Delhi, May 30

A NEW domestic sourcing requirement for solar cells, set to come into force from June 1, is likely to disproportionately impact smaller solar module manufacturers compared to larger companies with integrated cell and module manufacturing facilities.

While the move is expected to help reduce India's dependence on imports and strengthen the domestic solar manufacturing ecosystem, industry insiders have raised concerns over potential market consolidation risks in this sector. The apprehension stems from the sharp mismatch between the country's relatively limited do-

mestic cell manufacturing capacity and its much larger solar module manufacturing base, a gap that could tighten supplies and favour vertically integrated players.

While the country's solar module manufacturing capacity has surged to nearly 200 gigawatts (GW) per annum, domestic solar cell manufacturing remains far lower at around 30 GW, creating a significant gap.

Under the new mandate, all 'net-metering' and 'Open Access' solar projects commissioned after June 1 will have to use domestically manufactured solar cells. Net-metering projects largely include rooftop solar installations — such as those under the PM Surya Ghar: Muft Bijli Yojana — where consumers



India's solar module manufacturing capacity has surged to nearly 200GW per annum, but domestic solar cell manufacturing remains far lower at around 30 GW. REUTERS

can offset electricity bills by supplying surplus power back to the grid, while Open Access projects mainly cater to commercial and industrial consumers pro-

curing renewable energy directly from developers.

The new mandate has sparked concerns among module manufacturers, particularly

non-integrated players — those without internal cell manufacturing facilities. Industry executives cautioned such companies could face significant supply risks, as they would now be forced to procure domestically manufactured cells from larger competitors that also operate in the module market, potentially creating an uneven playing field.

According to industry insiders, the timing of the transition has added to the stress. India's solar module manufacturers are currently grappling with overcapacity and weakening export opportunities amid steep US tariff barriers. Against solar capacity installations of around 45 GW in 2025–

26, India's annual solar module production is estimated at nearly 60-65 GW, highlighting the growing oversupply concerns in the sector.

Industry sources said capacity utilisation levels at several module assembly plants are currently hovering around 30-40%.

"The prices of domestically manufactured cells are expected to rise after the mandate comes into force. As a result, companies with integrated manufacturing facilities may prioritise cell production, given the stronger margins and assured demand," an industry insider said, adding that some degree of market consolidation now appears inevitable during the transition

E.

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दक्षिणांचल विद्युत वितरण निगम
अधीक्षक अभियंता (सांअप्र०-प्रथम), ऊर्जा भवन
सिकन्दरा, आगरा

क्रंक: 1123/अधी०अभि०(सांअप्र०-1)/आगरा/विज्ञापन/ दिनांक: 30.05/26
जेम-निविदा सूचना दिनांक :- 30.05.2026

GEM/2026/B/576334, सामग्री 11 KV Incoming VCB, 11 KV Out
 CB & 11 KV Bus Coupler, मात्रा: **2842 नग** क्रय किये जाने हेत, प्रपत्र
 - शुल्क घरोहर राशि रु० 1,14,00,000/- विड अपलोड करने की अंतिम तिथि
 28.05.2026 10:00 बजे तक।

GEM/2026/B/5779047, सामग्री 33 KV O/C & Earth Fault Relay & 1
 C & Earth Fault Relay, मात्रा: **1150 नग** क्रय किये जाने हेत, प्रपत्र शुल्क नि-
 रोहर राशि रु० 2,87,50,000/- विड अपलोड करने की अंतिम तिथि 18.06.2026
 तक बजे तक।

रुस्त जानकारी एवं प्रपत्र वेबसाइट <http://gem.gov-in> पर उपलब्ध है। अग्रेर
 रुनाएं वेबसाइट पर ही प्रदर्शित की जाएगी।

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSONS

See Section 82 CrPC

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Do Jagpal R/o R-Block, Gali No. 6, Opp. Pami K Mangolpuri, Delhi & Man Singh S/o Madan Lal Khan 4/116, Sultanpuri, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case registered vide **FIR No. U/S 379/356/411/34 IPC, PS Paschim Vihar East, New Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest issued that the said accused **Jyoti & Man Singh** not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Jyoti & Man Singh** has absconded (or is concealing Themselves to avoid the service of the warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Jyoti Singh of FIR No. 47/2021 U/S 379/356/411/34 IPC, PS Paschim Vihar East, New Delhi** is required to appear before this Court (before me) to answer the complaint on or before the date **06.07.2026**.

Sh. Moksh Raj
Judicial Magistrate First Class
Room No. 10
Tis Hazari Court

DP/7129/00/2026(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 CrPC/84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that **Gopal Sharma S/o Suresh Sharma R/o House 10, Kewal Park, Azadpur, Delhi 110033** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case recorded vide **FIR No. 201/2022 U/S 103/104/63/65/ CR Sarai Rohilla, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant arrest their upon issued that the said accused **Sharma** can not be found and whereas it has been to my satisfaction that the said **Gopal Sharma** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Sharma of FIR No. 201/2022 U/S 103/104/63/65/ CR Sarai Rohilla, Delhi** is required to appear before the Court (or before me) to answer the complaint on or before the date **30.06.2026**

Ms. Harsh
Chief Judicial Magistrate
Central District, Rohtak
Tis Hazari Court, Delhi

DP/7113/N/2026(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused **Nishar Ahmad, S/o: Riyazuddin, R/o: H. No. 1439, Pocket-A6, Narela, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 36216/2024, U/s 305(B)/317(2) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023, P.S.: Hazrat Nizamuddin, Delhi** and has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Nishar Ahmad** cannot be found and whereas it has been brought to my satisfaction that the said accused **Nishar Ahmad** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant),

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Nishar Ahmad** shall appear before me in person or by his pleader in the said case **FIR No. 36216/2024, U/s 305(B)/317(2) Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023, P.S.: Hazrat Nizamuddin, Delhi** is required to appear before the Court to answer the said complaint on or before **02.07.2026**.

Sh. Manoj Kumar

DP/7105/SE/2026 Judicial Magistrate First Class - 3 (Sole Charge)
(Court Matter) **Room No. 512, Saket Court, New Delhi**

	BANGALURU NORTH CITY CORPORATION Office of the Executive Engineer, Byatarayanapura Division Zone-1 No. 2152/20, Defence Colony, 9th Main, D Block, Sahakarnagara, BNCC Office, Bangalore
No: BNC-Z1/EE/BTP/KPPP/PR/03/2026-27	Date: 30/05/2026
SHORT TERM TENDER NOTIFICATION TWO COVER TENDER	
(Through GOK KPP Portal https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in) Offers on item rate basis are invited by the undersigned from the registered contractors mentioned below from the registered contractors of Bangalore North City Corporation, or equivalent registered CPWD/ KPWD/ Railways/ MES or any State Government Organizations.	
Sl. No.	Name of the Work
1.	Annual Maintenance of SWD in Byatarayanapura Division for the year 2026-27/Call-2. Approximate value of Rs.175.00 Lakhs. EMD : Rs.2,62,500.00 Category
Calendar of Events : (1) Pre-Bid Meeting will be held on 06.06.2026 at 15:00 Hrs noon in the office of the Executive Engineer Byatarayanapura Division, No. 2152/20, Defence Colony, BWSSB Tank Road, Sahakarnagara office, Bangalore. (2) Last Date for uploading the Filled proposal is 10.06.2026 up to 16:00 hours. (3) Date of Opening of Bid is 11.06.2026 after 16:00 hours. (4) Date of Opening of Financial Bid after Approval of Technical BID.	
Sd/- Executive Engineer, Byatarayanapura Division	

SALUTE THE SOLDIER

**LT COL RANJIT SINGH PAWAR, SM
(13 FEB 1978 – 31 MAY 2016)**

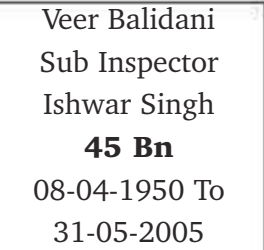
IC-59142P Lt Col Ranjit Singh Pawar, Sena Medal (Posthumous) displayed exceptional courage, outstanding leadership and unwavering devotion to duty while leading firefighting operations at CAD Pulgaon in May 2016. Leading from the front under extremely hazardous conditions, he ensured effective containment measures and motivated his men with remarkable composure and determination despite grave danger. The officer displayed exemplary bravery, exceptional courage and leadership of the highest order spearheading the critical operations of preventing the further spread of fire which otherwise could have led to unimaginable loss of life & property, making the supreme sacrifice in the line of duty. For his gallant act and selfless devotion to duty, he was awarded the “Sena Medal” (Gallantry) posthumously. Lt Col Ranjit Singh Pawar will always be remembered with pride and deep respect by all ranks of the Army Ordnance Corps for his supreme sacrifice and extraordinary act of bravery.

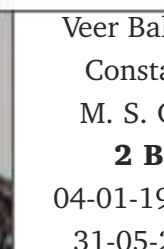
**Director General of Ordnance Service & Colonel Commandant
and all ranks of the Army Ordnance Corps**

**MAJ KRISHNAN MANOJ KUMAR, SM
(19 AUG 1974 - 31 MAY 2016)**

IC-64501F Maj Krishnan Manoj Kumar, Sena Medal (Posthumous) was posted as Fire Master and Installation Security Officer at Central Ammunition Depot (CAD). On the fateful day, the officer led from the front, displaying exceptional courage, composure and determination while motivating his men in the face of grave danger. He led the critical firefighting operations to contain and prevent the further spread of fire, thereby averting a potentially catastrophic loss of life and property. His swift decision-making, resolute leadership, and effective execution of containment measures ensured successful management of the crisis under highly challenging circumstances. In the true traditions of the Indian Army, Maj Krishnan Manoj Kumar displayed exemplary bravery, courage and leadership of highest order and made the supreme sacrifice and was awarded “Sena Medal” (Gallantry). Maj Krishnan Manoj Kumar will always be remembered with pride and deep respect by all ranks of the Army Ordnance Corps for his supreme sacrifice and extraordinary act of bravery.

**Director General of Ordnance Service & Colonel Commandant
and all ranks of the Army Ordnance Corps**

BORDER SECURITY FORCE			
Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawans on their Balidan Diwas.			
			
LANCE NAIK PURAN SINGH 17 BN BSF 28.05.1956 – 31.05.1989	CONSTABLE LAL SINGH 60 BN BSF 02.02.1980 – 31.05.2002	CONSTABLE/TRADESMAN SUNNY AVTAR 43 BN BSF 05.10.1975 – 31.05.2004	CT BIDYUT KUMAR DAS 123 BN BSF 16.08.1965 – 31.05.2001
CENTRAL RESERVE POLICE FORCE			
			
	Veer Balidani Sub Inspector Ishwar Singh 45 Bn 08-04-1950 To 31-05-2005		Veer Balidani Constable Nitin Musale 45 Bn 01-06-1982 To 31-05-2005

DG and all Ranks of CRPF pay solemn tribute to Sub Inspector Ishwar Singh and Constable Nitin Musale of 45 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice while bravely combating Maoists during a cordon and search operation in village Belahi, district West Champaran, Bihar on 31 May 2005. CRPF salutes the bravehearts and pledges never to let their sacrifice go in vain.			
	Veer Balidani Constable Ramphal 38 Bn 02-11-1954 To 31-05-1984		DG and all Ranks of CRPF pay solemn tribute to Constable Ramphal of 38 Battalion, who made the supreme sacrifice while managing a violent mob in West Bengal on 31 May 1984. CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.
			Veer Balidani Constable M. S. Gani 2 Bn 04-01-1951 To 31-05-2001
			Veer Balidani Constable V. K. Reddy 90 Bn 10-07-1977 To 31-05-2001
DG and all Ranks of CRPF pay solemn tribute to Constable M. S. Gani and Constable V. K. Reddy of 2 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice while bravely combating insurgents during an attack on their CRPF in South Tripura on 31 May 2001. CRPF salutes the bravehearts and pledges never to let their sacrifice go in vain.			

			
Veer Balidani Lance Naik Roshan Lal 9 Bn 26-08-1926 To 31-05-1963	Veer Balidani Constable Tara Singh 9 Bn 05-08-1942 To 31-05-1963	Veer Balidani Constable Shri Krishna 9 Bn 10-05-1942 To 31-05-1963	Veer Balidani Constable Baldev Raj 9 Bn 15-04-1943 To 31-05-1963
			
Veer Balidani Constable Joginder Singh 9 Bn 28-07-1924 To 31-05-1963	Veer Balidani Constable Daan Singh 9 Bn 24-03-1931 To 31-05-1963	Veer Balidani Constable Jograaj 9 Bn	Veer Balidani Constable Kalu Ram 9 Bn 20-03-1939 To 31-05-1963

DG and all Ranks of CRPF pay solemn tribute to eight bravehearts of 5 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice in a fierce encounter with hostile underground elements in the Tajo/Heta area of Chiyang, Arunachal Pradesh on 31 May 1963. CRPF salutes the bravehearts and pledges never to let their sacrifice go in vain.

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE
OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr. P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Person(s) **Sanjay Sharma S/o: Satish Sharma, R/o: C-308, Inder Enclave, PH-2, Kirari Suleman Nagar, Near Badi Masjid, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 512/2025, Dt. 30.10.2025, U/s: 377/506/34 IPC & 6 Pocco Act, PS: Khyala, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) **Sanjay Sharma**, cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) **Sanjay Sharma**, has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person(s) **Sanjay Sharma, of FIR No. 512/2025, Dt. 30.10.2025, U/s: 377/506/34 IPC & 6 Pocco Act, PS: Khyala, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **02.07.2026**.

By Order
Saloni Singh

Add. Sessions Judge-01 (West) POC SO (FTSC)
Room No. 21, Ground Floor
Tis Hazari Court, Delhi

DP/6928/WD/2026
(Court Matter)

Office of Executive Engineer,

Provincial Division, P.W.D. Amroha

E-Procurement Notice Inviting Tenders

No. 1160/E-Tender/26-27

Dated : 22-05-2026

1. The Executive Engineer, Provincial Division, PWD, Amroha on behalf of Governor of Uttar Pradesh invites the percentage rate bids online from the eligible and approved Contractors registered with UP PWD, Class A, B, C & D (Building work) The Bidder may submit bids for any or all of the works. Bidders are advised to note the minimum qualification criteria specified in Clause 4 of the Instructions to Bidders to qualify for the award of the contract.

2.

Sl. No	DISTRICT	Name of Work	Estimated cost (Rs.in Lacs)	Bid Security (Rs.in Lacs)	Cost of tender documents including GST (RS.)	Time of completion of the work (Including rainy season)	Category of road contractor eligible
1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
In the Anticipation of Sanction							
1	Amroha	Internal Repair and improvement work of District Magistrate residence in District Amroha	33.50	3.35	854.00	2 Months	"A, B, C. & D" (building category)

➤ The Rate adopted in the BOQ all Other taxes but excluding GST.

➤ Tender cost and EMD should be deposited online by Net Banking as per Column 6 in the table.

➤ Bids must be download online from 10:00 AM on date **16.06.2026** to 12:00 PM on dated **24.06.2026** and the technical bids will be opened online date **24.06.2026** at 12:30 PM and Financial bids of the qualified bidders will be opened on date & time as notified. According to the provisions of Government Order no. 1/2018/3070/78-2-2018/42 IT/2017 (22) Date 03-01-2018 after opening of the technical and financial bids, the qualified bidder has to submit original documents personally in department/ office. In the event of non submission of original documents by the bidder, the appropriate action will be taken in accordance with the provisions of G.O. All terms & conditions can be seen on website <http://tender.up.nic.in>

Executive Engineer
Provincial Division, PWD
Amroha
For and on behalf of Governor of UP
05922-246261

UPID-251932 Dt. 29.05.2026
www.upidadv.gov.in

 CSB Bank Trusted Heritage Smart Future		The locker customers of the Bank with details as under have not paid the locker rent issued to them. This publication is to intimate the customers to immediately contact the locker rent arrears within 30 days of this publication failing which the Bank will open the locker and deal with the contents of the locker, without any further intimation in terms of the locker agreement and the customer's will be liable for all costs and damages.	
S. No.	Branch	Locker No	Customer Name
1	GREATER KAILASH II	22	ABDUL SHAHID ANSARI

S. No.		N.T. No.	Name of work
1	55		Special Repair For Govt. Residential and Non Residential Building Under Public Works Department Division No. 02 Pathalgaon, Dist- Jashpur (C.G.) (First Call)
2	56		Ordinary Repair For Govt. Residential and non Residential Building Under Public Works Department Division No.01 Pathalgaon, Dist. Jashpur (C.G.) (First Call)
3	57		White Washing, Color Washing For Govt. Residential and Non residential Building Under Public Works Department Sub Division No. 01 Pathalgaon (C.G.) (First Call)
4	58		Special Repair For Govt. Residential and Non Residential Building Under Public Works Department Division No.01 Pathalgaon, Dist. Jashpur (C.G.) (First Call)
5	59		Ordinary Repair For Govt. Residential and Non Residential Building Under Public Works Department Division No.02 Pathalgaon, Dist. Jashpur (C.G.) (First Call)
6	60		White Washing, Color Washing For Govt. Residential and Non residential Building Under Public Works Department Sub Division No. 02 Pathalgaon (C.G.) (First Call)
7	61		White Washing, Color Washing and Distempereing work for Govt. Residential and Non Residential Building Under PWD Sub Division No. 2 Jashpur (C.G.) (First Call)
8	62		White Washing, Color Washing and Distempereing work for Govt. Residential and Non Residential Building Under PWD Sub Division Kunkuri (C.G.) (First Call)
9	63		White Washing, Color Washing and Distempereing work for Govt. Residential and Non Residential Building Under PWD Sub Division No. 1 Jashpur (C.G.) (First Call)
10	64		Special Repair and MOW work for Govt. Residential and Non Residential Building under Sub Division Kunkuri (C.G.) (First Call)



UTTARAKHAND POWER CORP.
 (A Govt. of Uttarakhand Undertaking), Victoria Cross Vijaya Gabar Singh
 Telephone- 91-135-2763872-76, Fax- 91-135-2760289, Corporate Identity No. (CIN)
No:- 388/1/EE(cm)/UPCL/A-2

E-TENDER NOTICE (NIT)

Uttarakhand Power Corporation Ltd., Dehradun invites e-tender for following

Sl. No.	Name of Item	Tender Specification No.	Tender Qty.	Estimated cost (in ₹)	Average yearly Turn Over of Preceding Financial Year Three i.e. 2022-2023, 2023-2024 & 2024-2025 (in ₹)	Earnest Money (in ₹)
01	11KV GO Switch 400Amp	CCP-I /7/2026-2027	700 Nos	70,98,000.00	1,50,00,000.00	1,42,000.00
02	GI wire 5mm (6SWG)	CCP-I /8/2026-2027	100 MT	95,92,220.00	1,91,84,440.00	1,92,000.00

For further details, please visit the website www.uktenders.gov.in

 U. P. POWER CORPORATION LIMITED Shakti Bhawan, 14-Ashok CIN: U32201UP1999SGC024928,				
Extracts of Financial Results for the quarter and year ended 31st Mar (Regulation 52 (8), read with Regulation 52 (4), of the SEBI Act, 1956)				
S. No.	Particulars	Standalone		
		Quarter ended		
		31st Mar, 2026 Un-audited	31st Dec, 2025 Un-audited	31st Mar, 2025 Un-audited
1	Total Income from Operations	22,871.29	16,010.34	16,823.35
2	Net Profit/(loss) for the period (before Tax, Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	(2,839.72)	429.41	(1,489.24)
3	Net Profit/ (loss) for the period before tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	(2,852.15)	429.41	(1,500.84)
4	Net Profit/ (loss) for the period after tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	(2,852.15)	429.41	(1,500.84)
5	Total comprehensive Income for the period [Comprising Profit/(Loss) for the period (after tax) and Other Comprehensive Income (after tax)]	(2,846.63)	428.74	(1,502.38)
6	Paid up Equity Share capital (Face value of ₹1000/- per share)	157,334.80	153,628.90	146,233.80
7	Other Equity	(117,023.83)	(114,242.32)	(109,996.28)
8	Securities Premium Account	NA	NA	NA
9	Net worth	37,160.93	35,565.40	34,052.17
10	Outstanding Debt	48,091.86	50,542.96	53,919.17
11	Outstanding redeemable preference shares	NA	NA	NA
12	Debt Equity Ratio	1.29	1.42	1.58
13	Earning per share (of 1000/- each) (for continuing and discontinued operations)			
	Basic	(18.31)	2.83	(10.42)
	Diluted	(18.31)	2.77	(10.42)
14	Capital Redemption Reserves	NA	NA	NA
15	Debtenture Redemption Reserves	NA	NA	NA
16	Debt Service Coverage Ratio	(0.0007)	0.0002	(0.0137)
17	Interest Service Coverage Ratio	(2.37)	0.33	(1.08)

Note 1 The above results have been reviewed by the audit committee of the Board of Directors of the Board of Directors in their meeting held on the same day.

Note 2 The above is an extract of the detailed format of Quarterly Financial Results filed with of SEBI (LODR) Regulations, 2015. The detailed format is available on the website of BSE Limited.

Note 3 Additional information/other line items pursuant to Regulation 52(4) of the SEBI (LODR) Regulations, 2015. The detailed format is available on the website of BSE Limited. Financial Results filed with the stock exchange (BSE Limited) and can be accessed on www.uppcl.org

Note 4 The figures/ratios for the previous periods have been restated, regrouped/reclassified to conform with the current classification.

EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY

E-TENDER NOTICE

e-Tender Notice No. 18 of 2026-27 (Open)-Engg/DDU

On line (through e-tendering) for the following work is invited by DRM/Engg/DDU for and on behalf of the President of India from experienced and financially as well as technically sound contractors including those enlisted with the Railway, CPWD, BSNL, MES, PWD and other public sector undertakings.

Tender No. : 14-DDU-SR DEN-II-26-27
 Name of work with its location : Renovation of Railway Inter College in PD. Colony at DDU under ADEN/HQ/DDU. Advertised Value : ₹4,40,86,459.02, Earnest Money : ₹8,81,700/-

Tender No. : 15-DDU-SR DEN-II-26-27
 Name of work with its location : Manpur - Pt. Deen Dayal Upadhyaya - Cess Repair Work -17.66 Tkm (6m 16.26 Tkm & 3m - 1.4 Tkm). Advertised Value : ₹8,15,13,086.82, Earnest Money : ₹16,30,300/-

Tender No. : 16-DDU-SR DEN-II-26-27
 Name of work with its location : Construction of boundary wall/compound wall at vulnerable locations around the colonies at Gaya. Advertised Value : ₹1,12,32,959.70, Earnest Money : ₹2,24,700/-

Closing Date & time for submission of e-tender: 18.06.2026, Up-to: 12:00 hrs. Website particulars of e-tendering: www.irops.gov.in

Divisional Railway Manager/
 ECR/Pt. Deen Dayal Upadhyaya
 PR/0325/DDU/Engg/T/26-27/14

The notices and pay to break as per the therefor. RECEIPTS 7500 SB Bank	EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY E-TENDER NOTICE Batch No: 08/26 dated: 29.05.2025 For and on behalf of the President of India, the Principal Chief Materials Manager, East Central Railway invites e-tenders for supply of the following items: 1. Tender No.: 04264871, Brief Description: Air Spring Assembly (Capacity 180 KN), Quantity : 1126 Nos, Due Date : 15.06.26, Due Time : 14.00, 2. Tender No.: 12253460, Brief Description : Superior quality Pillow for AC Coaches. Quantity : 97299 Nos, Due Date : 17.06.26, Due Time : 14.00, 3. Tender No.: 04260679, Brief Description : Primary Inner Spring (Code F-06), Quantity : 1425 Nos, Due Date : 22.06.26, Due Time : 14.00, 4. Tender No.: 03254892A, Brief Description : Finger Contact with Flexible Shunt Assembly, Quantity : 763 Nos, Due Date : 22.06.26, Due Time : 14.00, 5. Tender No.: 14265003, Brief Description : Cable single core 150 sq. mm, 1500 Volts, Quantity : 14375 Mtr., Due Date : 29.06.26, Due Time : 14.00, 6. Tender No.: 03254927A, Brief Description : Set of Electronic Brake Valve (EBV) Complete Assembly, Quantity : 7 Set, Due Date : 29.06.26, Due Time : 14.00, Note: All the above-mentioned tenders are e-tenders and all tenderers are requested to submit their bids on-line through the IREPS website at www.ireps.gov.in. All correspondence to above- mentioned tenders shall also be published online in IREPS website only. For more details regarding the above-mentioned tenders and other supply tenders please visit IREPS website. AMM-cum Secy. to PCMM/ ECR/Hajipur PR/0331/HQ/Store/T/26-27/48
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ATION LIMITED ian, Kanwali Road, Dehradun -248001 SGC025867/2358, Website: www.uktenders.gov.in			
Date: 30.05.2026 detailed below:-			
Date & time of Prebid conferen ce in online mode	Last Date & time of online request for tender and Submission of tender in online & Offline mode	Date of opening of bid Part-I in online and offline mode	
		Date of opening of bid Part-II in online and offline mode	
11.06.2026 at 12:00 hrs	20.06.2026 upto 17:00Hrs	21.06.2026 at 15:30Hrs.	
	20.06.2026 upto 17:00Hrs	21.06.2026 at 15:45Hrs	

ION LIMITED			
, Lucknow			
te: www.upplc.org			
26			
(R) Regulations, 2015)			
Year ended		Consolidated	
Year ended		Year ended	
31st Mar, 2026	31st Mar, 2025	31st Mar, 2026	31st Mar, 2025
Audited	Audited	Audited	Audited
8.18	79,990.80	108,219.50	102,971.92
(8.86)	(10,903.64)	(7,423.97)	(12,715.09)
(.29)	(10,915.24)	(7,563.94)	(12,845.78)
(.29)	(10,915.24)	(7,563.94)	(12,845.78)
(.79)	(10,917.93)	(7,456.14)	(12,870.70)
4.80	146,238.51	157,334.80	146,238.51
(3.83)	(109,996.26)	(101,809.83)	(97,024.47)
	NA	NA	NA
0.93	34,052.17	30,234.48	25,858.07
8.86	53,919.11	54,671.37	61,494.00
	NA	NA	NA
9	1.58	1.81	2.38
(.1)	(78.87)	(49.41)	(92.97)
(.1)	(78.87)	(49.41)	(92.97)
	NA	NA	NA
	NA	NA	NA
(.4)	(0.005)	0.38	0.36
(8)	(1.90)	(0.16)	(0.83)
Meeting held on 30th May, 2026 and approved by			
Exchange (BSE Limited) under Regulation 52			
and the company's website at www.upplc.org			
have been disclosed in the detailed Quarterly			
te of BSE Limited and the company's website			
ver necessary to conform to current period			
For & on behalf of the Board of Directors			
Sd/-			
(Nitin Nijhawan)			
Compliance Officer			
दिनांक 30/05/2024			

epaper.india

express.com

BRIDGE

DEALER: North		VULNERABLE: Both	
NORTH		SOUTH	
♣ KQJ10		♣ 987654	
♥ J6543		♥ K2	
♦ AKJ		♦ 653	
♠ A		♠ Q4	
SOUTH		WEST	
—		—	
1♣		pass	
3♣		pass	
pass		pass	

West leads the spade ace. East following. West shifts to the diamond eight. Plan the play. South should win the diamond shift in dummy, draw the last trump, and lead the jack of hearts. If East follows with a low heart, South should go up with the king, taking his normal chance for the contract (either the heart ace or diamond queen onside). However, if East covers the heart jack with the queen, South should duck. West cannot profitably overtake, and South has time to see if hearts are 4-2 or better (in which case he has the entries to set up a long heart for a diamond discard), before resorting to the diamond finesse.

THE WEST HAND

♠ A ♥ A87 ♦ 874 ♣ J97653

THE EAST HAND

♣ 32 ♥ Q109 ♦ Q1092 ♠ K1082

This plan gives up one technical chance for the contract - East might hold a singleton queen of hearts. But it gets back much more. Think how hard it will be for East to avoid covering the jack of hearts from Q-10 Q-10-9 and various other combinations. Plan the play in this grand slam.

DEALER: North		VULNERABLE: Both	
NORTH		SOUTH	
♠ A K 9743		♠ J62	
♥ A8		♥ K102	
♦ A K6		♦ 10	
♣ Q8		♣ A K J1094	
WEST		NORTH	
pass		1♣	
pass		2NT	
pass		4♣	
pass		5♦	
pass		5♠	
pass		pass	
pass		pass	

West plays the queen of diamonds.

• SUNDAY CROSSWORD

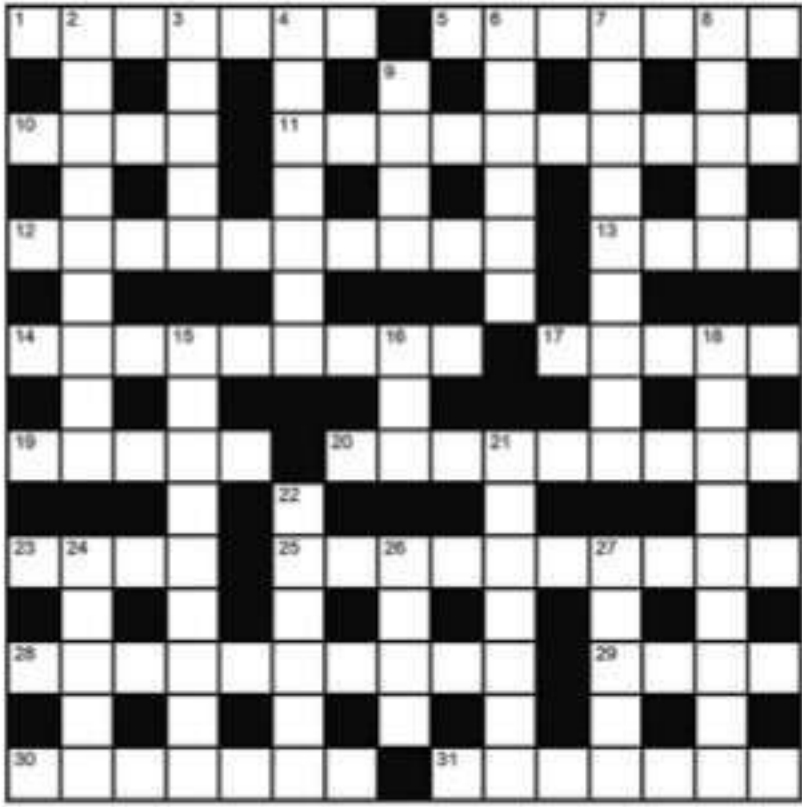
QUICK CLUES

ACROSS

- 1. Full of excitement and enthusiasm (7)
- 5. Bartender (7)
- 10. Capital of South Sudan (4)
- 11. Treacherous (10)
- 12. Dumb (10)
- 13. Sleeps briefly (4)
- 14. Our land ! (9)
- 17. Speck (5)
- 19. Pile (5)
- 20. Great Russian empress (9)
- 23. Run away (4)
- 25. Sweetheart (10)
- 28. Irresolute (10)
- 29. India's desert region (4)
- 30. An element form (7)
- 31. A person who is very good at different sports (7)

DOWN

- 2. A reproduction of drawings or plans (9)
- 3. Strident noise (5)
- 4. ___ on to : attaches oneself to; understands ? (7)
- 6. Manet or Monet (6)
- 7. Notorious Boston murderer (9)
- 8. Fit out (5)
- 9. Dwindle (4)
- 15. Reduction (9)
- 16. Rap sheet letters (3)
- 18. In accord (9)
- 21. Most blistering, warmest (7)
- 22. Small crustacean (6)



- 24. Respiratory organs (5)
- 26. Auction condition (2,2)
- 27. House for travellers (5)
- 17. A fine car is not stationary (5)
- 19. That's how we like the gardens — disordered (5)
- 20. Wheelwright's representative (9)
- 23. Run from fellow taking shelter (4)
- 25. NEC needs a knight to approve foreign-born appraisal of our Grannies coyer swimsuits (4-2-4)
- 28. Worker in Biblical community went to America (5,5)
- 29. Starting fires with not much effect on a service man's holding (4)

CRYPTIC CLUES

ACROSS

- 1. Reckon on a swimmer getting muddled (7)
- 5. Proposed to give feed for development (7)
- 10. Turn up your nose at what you get up from the bakery (4)
- 11. An armed timing device (5-5)
- 12. Up and down they go endlessly (10)
- 13. Wasted allowance of yore ? (4)
- 14. Blunder could be

SOLUTIONS TO 2583 QUICK CLUES ACROSS: 1 Remained, 5 Assert, 10 Conic, 11 Hardliner, 12 Anaerobic, 13 Evian, 14 Depict, 15 Deposed, 18 Obeying, 20 Biased, 22 Suomi, 24 Red-handed, 25 Attaining, 26 Ovale, 27 Alloys, 28 Stays put DOWN: 1 Racial, 2 Bedight, 21 Oddest, 23 Octal CRYPTIC CLUES ACROSS: 1 Regarded, 5 Afraid, 10 Oribi, 11 Governing, 12 Bandwagon, 13 Sonia, 14 Frayed, 15 Eugenic, 18 Inhaled, 20 Petite, 22 Gorse, 24 Stand down, 25 Pepperoni, 26 Ebbed, 27 Non est, 28 Feast-day DOWN: 1 Rhombi, 2 Grid north, 3 Railway sleepers, 4 Engaged, 6 Foresightedness, 7 Alien, 8 Dogwatch, 9 Evince, 16 Not too bad, 17 Wingspan, 19 Despot, 20 Praline, 21 One day, 23 Ripon

2584

IF IT'S YOUR BIRTHDAY

SUNDAY MAY 31: This is a year of new beginnings, adventures and major changes in your life. Keep your eyes open for new opportunities. Define your goals. Prepare for leadership.

MONDAY JUNE 1: This year you will reap the benefits of all your hard work. Expect power and leadership. It's a year for major decisions and accomplishments. The spotlight will be on you.

TUESDAY JUNE 2: This year is the end of a nine-year cycle. Take inventory of your life. It's time to let go of people, places and things. Do some internal and external housecleaning.

WEDNESDAY JUNE 3: This is a year of new beginnings, adventures and major changes. Be ready to take action. Prepare for leadership. What you do now will bring great benefits in the future.

THURSDAY JUNE 4: This is a slower paced year. Take time to rejuvenate your energy and outlook. Choose to be with people who are kind, helpful and have your back.

FRIDAY JUNE 5: This is a lovely year! Enjoy socialising. Express your creativity and desire for life. Nurture the happiness and beauty that you have within. Loosen up a bit! Old friends might reappear.

SATURDAY JUNE 6: This is a year to build solid foundations, both externally and internally. Simplicity is key. Take charge of your health. Stay grounded and levelheaded.

JUMBLED WORDS

Given below are four jumbled words. Solve the jumbles to make proper words and move them to the respective circles below. Select the letters in the shaded circles and jumble them to get the answer for the given quip.

God is in the _____. - Ludwig Mies van der Rohe (7)

KNOAE

SSYIS

AACULT

EENTXD

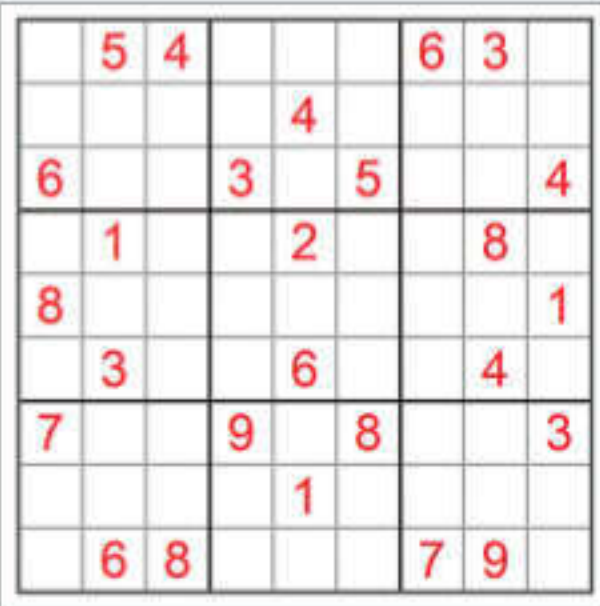
AMSWER: God is in the details.

NOTIONS: Oaken, Sissy, Actual, Extend

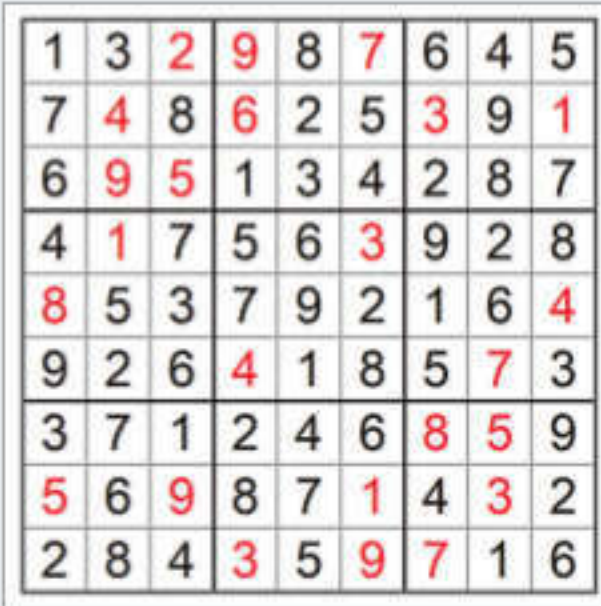
SUDOKU 6335

DIFFICULTY LEVEL 5s
INSTRUCTIONS
To solve a Sudoku puzzle, every digit from 1 to 9 must appear in each of the nine vertical columns, in each of the nine horizontal rows and in each of the nine boxes.

DIFFICULTY LEVEL
1s = Very easy; 2s = Easy; 3s = Medium; 4s = Hard; 5s = Very Hard; 6s = Genius



SOLUTION SUDOKU 6334



Classifieds

PERSONAL

I,hitherto known as Anita w/o Shashi Bhushan, residing at, E-18/202, Sector-3, Rohini, P.O, Rohini, sector-7, Dist: North-West Delhi, Delhi- 110085, have changed my name shall hereafter be known as ANITA UDINIYA. 0040857960-9

I, Vinod Kumar, S/o Yashpal R/o- Flat. No.909, PKT-7, Sec.- A-10, Punarvas Colony, Narela, Delhi- 110040, that the name of my minor son, has been wrongly- recorded, as Piyush Chauhan in, his school- record. The correct, name of my son, is Kunal 0040857913-4

I, Vimmy W/o Ashish Khatter, R/o- 2013-A, DG- II, Vikaspuri, Delhi- 110018, have changed my name to Vimmy Grover. 0040857894-1

I, Valibhav Jhanji, S/o Rajiv Jhanji, R/o Flat No. 704, Tower-1, Valley View Estate, Gwal Pahari, Gurugram (Haryana)- 122003, have changed my minor Son's Name, from Vihaan to Vihaan Jhanji. 0040857913-1

I, VIKAS MITTAL, S/O NAND KISHORE MITTAL, R/O-B-32, GROUND FLOOR, GAGAN ENCLAVE, GHAZIABAD, UTTAR PRADESH-201001, have changed my minor son name MANIT MITTAL to YUV MITTAL, permanently. 0040857972-4

I, TUSHAR JAIN, S/O MANOJ KUMAR FULFAGAR, R/O-B-69, B-BLOCK, NEAR SURYA-NAGAR, RAMPURI, CHANDER-NAGAR, GHAZIABAD, UP-201011, have changed my name to TUSHAR JAIN FULFAGAR, permanently. 0040858007-1

I, Subhadra Kumari W/O Suresh Kumar, R/o NO. 177-T/6, Old. No.97, W.No.2, Flat-No.G-2 LGE Mehrauli, South-Delhi, Delhi-110030, have changed my name to Subhadra Devi. 0040857972-9

I, Shyam Sunder, S/o Amar Singh Goswami, R/o496/E, Gali. No.1, R ama Block, BholaNath Nagar, North-East-Delhi, Delhi-110032, have changed my name to Shyam Sunder Goswami for all purposes. 0040857972-2

I, MOHAMMAD KHURSID AHMAD, S/O Late Mohammad Kuddus, R/O- LZ-2056A, Second Floor, Front Side-Right Side, Gali No.26, Tughlakabad Extension, Kalkaji, South-Delhi, Delhi-110019, declare that in my- Passport bearing. No.S246390, the name of my-mother has been wrongly mentioned as Jarina Khatoon instead of Zarina Khatoon. The actual- name of my-mother is Zarina Khatoon, which may be amended accordingly. 0040857960-12

I, PREETAM CHAND GARG, S/O HARI KISHAN DASS GARG, R/O-801-2 SUKHDVE-NAGAR KOTLA MUBARAKPUR, NEW DELHI-110003, HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO PRITAM CHAND GARG. 0040857960-4

I, NIKHIL S/O Sh.Om Parkash, R/O M-22.1st Floor, 25 yards, Raghuraj Nagar, Tagore Garden, West Delhi-110027, have changed my name to NIKHIL VISHWAKARMA. 0040857972-5

I, Munsoor Naqi, s/o Shaikh Mohammed Naqi R/o-A-14, flat no-401, street no-3, johri farm, jamia nagar okhla Delhi-110025, have changed my name to Munsoor Naqi 0040857913-3

I, Mohit Suresh Sadaani, S/o Suresh Bhagwandas Sadani, R/o- CM729A, The Camellias, Golf-Course Road, DLF Phase-S, Gurgaon, Haryana-122009, have changed my name to Mohit Sadaani, Permanently 0040857894-2

I, SANTHOSH VIJAYAN S/o S Vijayan, 9/203, Sri Niwas Puri, Delhi-65 have changed my name to V SANTHOSH. 0071039111-1

I, RAMESH CHAND, S/O BALDEV RAJ ARORA, R/O- 250-1-A GALLI, NO-5BHOLA-NATH NAGAR SHAHDARA, DELHI-110032 HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO RAMESH ARORA 0040857972-6

I, Pratibha W/o Shyam Sunder Goswami, R/o-496/E, Gali. No.1, Rama Block, BholaNath Nagar, Shahdara, North-East Delhi, Delhi-110032, have changed my name to Pratibha Goswami, for all purposes. 0040857972-3

I, Pankaj S/O Suresh Kumar R/o NO.177-T/6, Old-No.97, W.No.2, Flat-No.G-2 LGE Mehrauli, South-Delhi, Delhi-110030, have changed my-name to Pankaj Kumar. 0040857972-8

I, RADHA W/O PRITAM CHAND GARG, R/O-801/2 SUKHDVE NAGAR KOTLA MUBARAKPUR, NEW DELHI 110003, HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO RADHA GARG 0040857960-5

I, SURUTI AGGARWAL alias SURUTI AGGARWAL VERMA, D/o-N-R.AGGARWAL, W/O SUMIT VERMA, R/O- CC-65 D, Near-Police Station, Shalimar-Bagh, Delhi-110088, have changed my name to SURUTI AGGARWAL VERMA. 0040857972-7

I, Samridhi Mittal W/O Soumil Singhal R/O C-2/50, Ashok Vihar, Phase-2, Delhi-110052, have changed my name to Samridhi Singhal. 0040857960-1

I, Anita, W/o Kramti Kumar Singh, R/o-H.No.904, A-Block, Near MCD-Office, Shahbad Dairy, Delhi-110042, Aadhaar No.962884105557, do hereby declare, that I, have changed, my name, from KM Anita, to Anita, for all, future purposes. Henceforth, I shall be, known as, Anita in all, records and, dealings. 0040857913-5

I, JASKIRAT SINGH, S/o HARJEET SINGH BHATIA, R/O-07.37/17/2, GALLI. NO.07, A-2 BLOCK, SANT NAGAR, BURARI, DELHI-110084, have changed my name to JASKIRAT SINGH BHATIA, for all future, purposes. 0040857960-7

I, HEMANT KUMAR alias HEMANT KUMAR BAJAJ, S/o Sh. Fakir Chand, R/o-House No.115, 2nd Floor, Pocket-26, Sector-24, Rohini, Rohini Sector-7, Po, Rohini Sector-7, Delhi-110085, have changed my name to HEMANT BAJAJ. 0040857960-2

I, GOURAV MANCHANDA, S/O RAMESH MANCHANDA, R/O- HN.3161 MAHINDRA PARK RANI BAGH SARASWATI VIHAR, DELHI-110034, HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO GAURAV MANCHANDA. 0040857960-8

I, Ellamal M/o Murugan, C, Kujal Pettai, Vellur, Polur, Triuvannamali, Tamil-Nadu-606905, That my name mentioned in my-son Army Services-Record as Ellamal Instead of Ellammal. (Correct-name). 0040857972-11

I, DEEPTI GOPAL MOHANTY, W/O MIHIR RANJAN MOHANTY, R/O- OL2/1301, ELDECO UTOPIA, SECTOR-93A, NOIDA, G.B.NAGAR, U.P.-201304, have changed my name to DEEPTI MOHANTY. 0040857913-6

I, Channapaiyan F/o Murugan, C, Kujal Pettai, Vellur, Polur, Triuvannamali, Tamil-Nadu-606905, That my name mentioned in my son Army Services-Record as Channapaiyan. P(Correct-name) 0040857972-10

I, Vishal Chauhan, S/o Virendra Singh, Address: Village Kulesara, District Gautam Buddha Nagar-201306. My father's name is wrongly mentioned as Virendra Chauhan in myeducational documents, whereas my father's correct name is Virendra Singh. 0040857868-1

I, Vikrant Sahu S/o Ashok Kumar Sahu R/o Plot No.- 120, Street No.- 3, Hind Nagar, Civic Centre Bhilai, Durg, Chhattisgarh -490006, have changed my minor daughter's name from Dhairya aged 03 years to Isha Gupta forever 0071039186-1

I, JITENDER S/O SUBHASH CHANDER, R/O-O-H.NO-1A/206, BLOCK A, NEAR HANUMAN MANDIR, NIT FARIDABAD, FARIDABAD (HARYANA)-121001, HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO JITENDER KUMAR. 0040857913-2

I, Suman Lata Devi W/o Satish Chandra Gauniyal R/o 156, Aliganj, Kotla Mubarakpur Pur, Lodhi Road, Delhi-110003, have changed my name to Suman Lata Gauniyal for all purposes. 0040857788-1

I, Mahalu, S/O Nanhak, R/O-H.No.16/43, D-Block, Shahbad Dairy, Delhi-110042, declare that me and my-father name has been wrongly-written in documents Budhi Ram and Ram Dev instead of Mahalu and Nanhak. 0040857913-7

I, MONIKA JAIN W/O MANOJ KUMAR FULFAGAR, R/O B-69, B-BLOCK, NEAR SURYA NAGAR, RAMPURI, CHANDER-NAGAR, GHAZIABAD, UP-201011, have changed my name to MONIKA FULFAGAR, permanently. 0040858007-3

I, MOHNISH KANSAL S/O SANJEEV KANSAL R/OA-203, DERAWAL NAGAR, MODEL TOWN, DELHI-110009 have changed/ my name shall henceforth be known as MOHNIESH KANSAL. 0071039202-1

I, MOHAMMAD KHURSID AHMAD, S/O Late Mohammad Kuddus, R/O LZ-2056A, Second-Floor, Front Side-Right Side, Gali. No.26, Tughlakabad Extension, Kalkaji, South-Delhi, Delhi-110019, declare that in my- Passport bearing No.S246390, the name of my-wife has been wrongly- mentioned as Samsa Begum instead of Shamsha Begum. The actual- name of my-wife is Shamsha Begum, which may be amended accordingly. 0040857960-13

I, MANOJ KUMAR JAIN/ MANOJ FULFAGAR, S/O LATE SH. HEMRAJ FULFAGAR, R/O B-69, B-BLOCK, NEAR SURYA-NAGAR, RAMPURI, CHANDER-NAGAR, GHAZIABAD, UP-201011, have changed my name to MANOJ KUMAR FULFAGAR, permanently. 0040858007-2

I, Kusum W/o Lt Shri Rakesh Kumar, Addrsc-96, antriksh apartment, sec-14, Rohini-110085, have changed my minor child name Saanvi to Saanvi Singhal. 0040857960-11

I, Kusum Singla, W/o Lt Shri Rakesh Kumar, Addrsc- C-96, antriksh apartment, sec-14, Rohini-110085, have changed my name to Kusum. 0040857960-10

I, ARKAM S/O TAFSIR R/o Khanpur Banger, Ikla Rasoolpur, Meerut, U.P.-250406, have changed my name to ARKAM KHAN. 0040857960-6

I, FARHAT N. D/O MD ISHAQUE, AGE 60, R/O 503, TOP FLOOR SADAT APARTMENT 1, TTI ROAD JAMIA NAGAR, DELHI PIN110025 HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO BABY FARHAT NAZ AS DECLARED BEFORE NOTARY NO: IN-DL17268225850211Y 0071039177-1

I, HARISH KAUSHIK, S/O VIJAY SHARMA R/O 1011 SHAM NAGAR KARNAL HARYANA 132001 HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO HARISH. 0040857960-3

I, Smt. Harsh Wadhawan W/o Shri Surender Wadhawan R/o 130, A - Block, Preet Vihar, Delhi -110092 have inform that previously I was known as Harsh Bala Wadhawan. Harsh Wadhawan and Harsh Bala Wadhawan both are one and same person. In future I will be known as Harsh Wadhawan. 0040857874-1

I, Shubham Kumar S/o Sunil Kumar Gupta, 405/ Tower17, Paras Tierrea, Sec-137, Noida have changed my name to Shubham Kumar Gupta. 0071039115-1

I, SAIYAM CHABRA S/O BHARAT BHUSAN CHHABRA R/O C-6/44B, SECOND FLOOR, LAWRENCE ROAD, KESHAV PURAM, DELHI-110035 HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO SAIYAM CHHABRA FOR ALL FUTURE PURPOSES. 0071039192-1

I, Pawan Kumar Jha S/o Kailash Prasad Jha R/o Chhoti Simra, Naugachia, Dist: Bhagalpur, Bihar-853204, have changed my minor son's name from Reshaw Aged 13 Years to Aditya Kumar Jha forever 0071039156-1

I, Nabanita Chakravarty, W/o Sh. Shantanu Chakravarty, R/o C-409, 2nd Floor, Chittaranjan Park, New Delhi-110019, hereby declare that in my minor son's Passport name has been mentioned "Nabanita", correct name "Nabanita Chakravarty." Both one and the same person. official as well as all purposes 0040857901-1

I, Luv S/O Hitender born on 30/08/1995 residing at Plot No-91A Block-E3 Chanakya Place Part-1, Delhi 110059, have changed my name to Luv Kumar Sohni vide affidavit dated 28-05-2026 at Delhi. 0050290343-1

I, Dilip Sharma S/o Late Bhanwarlal Sharma, R/o 34, Govind Khand, Vishwakarma Nagar, Delhi-110095, have changed my name to Dileep Kumar. 0071039228-1

I, DEEP W/o Ashok Kumar Sakarwal, 5526, Reghar Pura, Gali. No-74, Karol Bagh, Delhi-05 have changed my name to DEEP SAKARWAL. 0071039154-1

I, BHARAT S/O SASHI KUMAR YADAV, R/O Village Kanganheri Delhi 110071 Changed my name as BHARAT YADAV 0130065190-1

I, Anjana Devi W/o Pradeep Kumar R/o R8, Pallavapuram, Phase-2, Modipuram, Meerut have changed my name to Anjana. 0071039112-1

I, (NEHA SINGH) D/O (LALIT SINGH) born on (27/04/2010) residing at H.NO 74 MAIN MARKET SAMAYPUR DELHI-110042 have changed my name to (MAAHI SINGH) vide affidavit dated (26/05/2026) at (DELHI) 0050290367-1

• YOUR WEEK AHEAD



ARIES (MAR 21 - APR 20): This is an accident-prone day. Be careful and don't overreact. If someone says something that doesn't thrill you. Stay chill. If people are touchy, This Week: Home projects and lively discussions keep you busy.



TAURUS (APR 21 - MAY 21): You have lots of energy, which is why get outside and do something to release any pent-up steam. Financial issues might come to a head today. You'll be charming. This Week: Stay patient when unexpected changes test your diplomacy.



GEMINI (MAY 22 - JUNE 21): Today the full Moon is opposite your sign. Be patient with partners and close friends. Find someone who wants to listen to you. This Week: Explore fresh ideas but double-check important details.



CANCER (JUNE 22 - JULY 23): Today is the second full Moon of the month, so, even if people around you are tense today, with fair Venus in your sign, you'll find it easy to be charming and diplomatic with everyone. This Week: Patience helps you avoid confusion and financial mistakes.



LEO (JULY 24 - AUG 23): This is a bit of a tense day for romance. Issues with your kids might come up because everyone can feel the increased emotional tension from today's full moon. This Week: Friends and teamwork open exciting new opportunities.



VIRGO (AUG 24 - SEP 23): Today you might feel a tug-of-war between the demands of home and family versus the demands of your career and your external world. Discussions with parents and bosses could be significant. This Week: Stay grounded as new opportunities emerge.



LIBRA (SEP 24 - OCT 23): Pay attention to everything you say and do, because today's full Moon can create an accident-prone situation for you, both verbally and physically. This Week: Exciting encounters inspire bold new future plans.



SCORPIO (OCT 24 - NOV 23): Keep an eye on your money, your possessions and even banking issues, because today's full Moon will affect your finances. Fortunately, money will easily come your way now. This Week: Patience helps you handle emotional people gracefully.



SAGITTARIUS (NOV 24 - DEC 22): Today's full Moon is in your sign. Be patient with partners and close friends. Romance will be intense. You can get a lot done today. This Week: Focus on finances, work and meaningful conversations.



CAPRICORN (DEC 23 - JAN 20): This is a playful day! Relations with partners, spouses and close friends are warm and supportive. However, the full Moon energy might create some tension with co-workers. This Week: Clear communication improves relationships and financial decisions.



AQUARIUS (JAN 21 - FEB 19): You value your friends, but today's full Moon will cause issues with a particular friend or a member of a group. Use your diplomacy. This Week: Enjoy friendships while keeping emotions under control.



PISCES (FEB 20 - MAR 20): Today you have to focus on home and family. This might not be easy, because today's full Moon will force you to juggle priorities. It's a lovely day to have fun! This Week: Trust your intuition and make time for loved ones.

LOST & FOUND

It is hereby informed that the original Sale Deed of Flat No. 206, Sector-18, Vasundhara, Ghaziabad, executed between U.P. Awasthi Vikas Parshad and the purchaser Mr. Surendra Singh, son of Mr. Suresh Chandra Jain, in favour of Mr. Sanjay Sharma, resident of 76, Kedamath Marg, Daryaganj, New Delhi, bearing Document No. 12614-15 dated 09.10.2000, registered in the office of the Sub-Registrar, Ghaziabad, along with physical possession documents, has genuinely been lost/misplaced. If anyone finds the said document, kindly inform Mrs. Shobha Nigam, wife of S.K. Nigam. Any misuse of the said document by any person shall be treated as illegal and invalid. Mobile No.: 9818979748

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given to all concerned for and on behalf of our client MR. BRIJU DEVIENDU S/O Sh. R.G. Srastrhi is the lawful co-owner and in possession by virtue of sale deeds in respect of schedule property. The Sanctioned Plan stands challenged before MCD. Any person or persons/company/banks/non-banking financial institutions or corporation are hereby cautioned not to enter into any transaction not limited to sale/lease/rent/ mortgage or otherwise in any manner in respect of scheduled property or any part thereof without the authority of our client. Any person shall be dealing so at his/her/its own risk our client shall not be liable for the same. (SCHEDULE PROPERTY:- Plot No. 11231-32-D (Old No. 11131-32), Block No. 4, Ward No. 12, Roop Nagar, Sabzi Mandi, Delhi-110007)

TUSHAR DATTA, ADVOCATE FOR:- M A X I M O Advocates & Law Consultants C-7/70A, Lawrence Road, Keshav Puram, Delhi-35 01143510270. 9515841784

PUBLIC NOTICE

Public at large is informed that my client Mr. Gangra Ram S/o Late Shri Sakhi Ram R/o US-240, Uttar School Block, Mandawali, Farid Pur, East Delhi-110092 has disowned/debarred his son Mr. Deepesh Kumar and his wife Mrs. Jyoti has been disowned and debarred from all my movable and immovable properties, assets, bank balances, investments, ancestral/ self-acquired properties, and all other rights whatsoever, due to his/her irresponsible conduct and activities against the interests and wishes of the family. My client and his family will not be responsible for act done by him. Any individual, institution, organization, or person dealing with him in respect of my properties or on my behalf shall do so at entirely at their own risk, cost, and consequences.

“
Mindset to win title, not defend 2025 IPL win, says Patidar



Rajat Patidar. PRAVEEN KHANNA
Express News Service
Ahmedabad, May 30

BEFORE ROYAL Challengers Bengaluru (RCB)'s IPL 2026 final against Gujarat Titans, Rajat Patidar was presented with a topic that has followed him through much of the season - a potential return to India's T20I setup.

Patidar, however, had little interest in discussing it. "I'm not looking forward to any selection regarding India. So, I'm not looking forward for it," the RCB captain said on the eve of the final.

It is easy to understand why his name has entered the selection debate. Patidar has scored 486 runs in 14 matches this season while simultaneously leading RCB into a second successive IPL final. His performances have come in a batting line-up built around clearly defined roles, with Patidar often providing the acceleration in the middle overs.

India captain?

That same outlook was evident when Patidar was asked whether he could envision himself one day leading India in T20 cricket. "I don't visualise to be the T20 captain of India. But at the same time, every captain wants to win the trophies. So last year we did it, but again it's a new season. You cannot keep talking about 2025, what we have done. You have to be more in the present and do whatever best you can do to win the title. What has changed from last year? To be honest, I don't think we have changed anything."

RCB enter the final carrying the confidence of a side that has established itself as one of the IPL's most consistent teams in recent seasons. While Patidar's individual contributions have been significant, he believes the franchise's evolution has been driven by a broader shift in mindset rather than the influence of a few star performers.

"I think responsibility is the main word that every individual is thinking about."

He added: "So, responsibility and keenness to do for the team. And having the same mindset that we are not here to just play qualifiers and all. We are here to play the finals and win the finals. So I think this mindset has changed."

Responsibility is probably the key word. Every individual is keen to contribute and do something for the team. The other thing is the mindset. We're not here just to qualify for the playoffs. We're here to play finals and win finals. I think that mindset has changed.

RAJAT PATIDAR, ON WHAT'S CHANGED FOR ROYAL CHALLENGERS BENGALURU

INDIAN PREMIER LEAGUE FINAL

From chaos to clarity

For 18 years, RCB underachieved. Sunday's final against Gujarat will tell us if they have fixed it permanently

Shankar Narayan
Ahmedabad, May 30

As the sun set over the Narendra Modi Stadium on Saturday evening, Rajat Patidar and Devdutt Padikkal were still on the ground, working through their drills under Dinesh Karthik's eye. The intensity was evident. So was the composure. That combination - urgency without anxiety - has become the defining characteristic of this RCB side over two seasons.

They arrive at Sunday's final as defending champions. They also arrive at a venue that has already beaten them once this season - bowled out for 155 here in April, a total Gujarat chased with four wickets in hand. The final was originally scheduled at the Chinnaswamy Stadium in Bengaluru, RCB's home, before the BCCI moved it to Ahmedabad citing logistical requirements. So the defending champions will play for the title not on their own ground but on Gujarat's, on a pitch they know can undo them. Ahmedabad is hosting the IPL final for the fourth time in the last five seasons. RCB are the only side arriving without the comfort of familiarity.

It is the kind of detail that would have unsettled previous RCB sides. This one no longer looks like a team built on reputation. It has been built, deliberately, on something more durable.

The clearest illustration came last Tuesday in Dharamsala. Bhuvneshwar Kumar, 36 years old, with 26 wickets in 15 matches this season, bowling



The Narendra Modi Stadium will host the IPL final for the fourth time in the last five seasons. PRAVEEN KHANNA

the same seam-up action he has bowled for sixteen years. Patidar walking in at 97 for 3 and making 93 off 33 balls - the fastest innings of 90 or more in IPL history. Neither moment was accidental. Both were the product of a franchise that has stopped assembling famous names and started building defined roles.

Efficient XI

The thinking behind the squad reflects a clarity shaped by the Chinnaswamy - high-scoring, short boundaries, pace-friendly. Bhuvneshwar gives swing and powerplay wickets that hand RCB early control. Josh Hazlewood mixes his lengths intelligently to maintain pressure. Rasikh Salam Dar has quietly filled the third seamer slot in Yash Dayal's absence. In spin, Suyash Sharma and Krunal Pandya bring different tools toward the same principle: middle-over control and wickets in batting-friendly conditions. The batting reflects the same role precision. Virat Kohli stabil-

The defending champions will play for the title not on their own ground but on Gujarat's, on a pitch they know can undo them.

ises and anchors. Padikkal enforces at the top. Tim David accelerates late. Jitesh Sharma provides finishing depth. The intent is not to assemble the most famous XI but the most efficient one.

A win on Sunday would put Patidar alongside MS Dhoni and Rohit Sharma as captains to win consecutive IPL titles. He was asked about this at the pre-match press conference on Saturday. The answer was characteristic. "No, I've never thought about what another captain has done or whether I want to compete with someone. My journey has been a rollercoaster, but I've never focused on that. I focus on

what I can do best in the present. Right now, my focus is only on the final and giving my best tomorrow."

The broader legacy conversation is one the franchise is more willing to have than their captain. Teams that define eras are rarely built on single-season brilliance. They are built on stability across cycles. Three things stand out in this RCB group as the foundations of something longer. The first is Patidar's captaincy - not yet fully formed but already embedded in a clear system, built for continuity rather than personality. The second is the Indian core of Krunal, Padikkal, Jitesh and Patidar himself - the structural backbone that gives the side identity and allows overseas players to slot into defined roles. The third is the bridge that Kohli and Bhuvneshwar provide between the franchise's past and its evolving present. Between them they carry the identity and the experience. Neither is surplus. Both are essential.

Gujarat Titans are not straightforward opponents. Both sides arrive on Sunday chasing a second IPL title - GT won their first in 2022 under Hardik Pandya. They know this ground. They bat from the top with Gill and Sudharsan, bowl with Rabada and Siraj, and control the middle overs with Rashid Khan. They have lost to RCB twice this season but won Qualifier 2 to be here. Gill's reflection after the Qualifier 1 defeat was pointed: fielding let them down under pressure. They will have addressed that.

The pitch used for the final will be the same surface used for the 2023 ODI World Cup final. On that evidence alone, conditions will test both sides equally. What it will not test equally is temperament - and that, more than tactics, is what Sunday is really about.

RCB have climbed the mountain once. The question is whether they have built something strong enough to stay there.

Teams with similar batting philosophies, different depth

Lalith Kalidas
New Delhi, May 30

EVEN IN an IPL season defined by unprecedented scoring rates, stability remains a premium. Consistency that lasts two months can punch a ticket to the final. Royal Challengers Bengaluru and Gujarat Titans embody contrasting run-making philosophies, yet arrive at the same endpoint: clarity over chaos.

It is the relative calm within their batting units that has driven success, albeit through different personnel structures. While the defending champions utilise their entire top seven, Gujarat's batting is visibly pinned

on Shubman Gill, Sai Sudharsan and Jos Buttler. The efficiency of both units through the first two phases, with minimal drop-offs in intent, has allowed them to outpace the more explosive top orders of Rajasthan Royals, Sunrisers Hyderabad and Punjab Kings.

Interestingly, RCB are the only side among the top-five teams to increase their scoring rate as the innings progress. Their Powerplay strike rate of 9.75 runs per over (rpo) has transitioned smoothly into 9.9 rpo in the middle overs (7-16). While the average dips from 41 to 31, RCB absorb that cost thanks to their depth and finishing



Gujarat's batting is visibly pinned on Shubman Gill, Sai Sudarshan and Jos Buttler. CREIMAS

strength. In contrast, Gujarat continue to adopt a lower-risk approach, with scoring responsibility concentrated in the top

Number Plate
9.9
● RCB's SR in the powerplay is 9.75 runs per over and goes to 9.9 in the middle overs (7-16) — the only team in the Top 5 to have an ascending scoring rate.

three. Their middle-order average of 35.24 is the highest among Playoff teams. Though they start slower in the Powerplay at 9.08 rpo, GT maintain stability at 9.05 rpo through the middle overs. By comparison, the third-

placed Rajasthan Royals leaned heavily on the Vaibhav Sooryavanshi factor, with the Powerplay contributing over 36 per cent of their total runs — the highest among all teams. However, their 11.2 rpo in that phase drops to 9.19 in the middle overs, alongside a steep fall in average.

Avoiding such sharp fluctuations for 80 per cent of the innings has ensured that neither RCB nor GT is forced to reset at the death. Powered by Tim David (252 runs in overs 17-20), RCB surge at 11.19 rpo — the second-best in the league. Gujarat, lacking similar firepower, trail at 9.53 rpo in the final phase.

Titans' five-pronged bowling attack

RCB's biggest test



Kagiso Rabada has 28 wickets in 18 matches this IPL. CREIMAS/BCCI

Shankar Narayan
Ahmedabad, May 30

KAGISO RABADA will run in from one end. Mohammed Siraj from the other. Between them, in the overs that follow, Jason Holder will step in. Then Rashid Khan. Then Prasidh Krishna. Royal Challengers Bengaluru's batting - Kohli's stability, Patidar's explosiveness, Tim David's finishing power - has found answers to most challenges this season. On Sunday, it must find answers for all five.

What makes Gujarat Titans' attack particularly dangerous is not merely the quality of individuals but the variety they bring. It is a unit rooted in traditional Test-match lengths, forcing batsmen to constantly rethink their approach across all twenty overs. There are no easy phases. There is no obvious gap. RCB's batting has been one of the defining stories of IPL 2026 - built around clearly defined roles, it has answered most challenges thrown its way. But this is arguably the most complete bowling attack in the league, and the most complete test it has faced.

Rediscovered form

Rabada has been the standout bowler of IPL 2026. After three consecutive difficult seasons - a combined 20 wickets in 21 matches - he has emerged as the bowling leader of this attack. Twenty-eight wickets in 16 matches at 9.43. Nineteen of those in the powerplay. His ability to hit the deck hard while maintaining high speeds makes him effective even on surfaces that offer little assistance. The relentless pace, the attacking mindset that refuses to retreat into containment - Rabada arrives at the final as the tournament's leading wicket-taker and as a bowler who has rediscovered something he had temporarily lost.

Siraj presents a different challenge from the other end. The 32-year-old relies on seam movement and swing, hunting wickets from the very first over rather than retreating into defensive lengths. Fourteen of his 18 wickets this season have come in the first six overs. His stock delivery appears to come in but shapes away - outside edges re-

main interested. Where Rabada hits hard and fast, Siraj probes and moves. Together they form the most dangerous new-ball pairing in the competition.

The surprise has been Holder. Gujarat had planned him before the auction even opened. "Even before the IPL auction last year, we had planned that Jason Holder would be our main pick," GT assistant coach Parthiv Patel said.

Faith in Holder

"We know that in the last 1.5 years, Holder has been in good form in T20 leagues across the world. If you have a player who can bowl in the powerplay as well as in the middle overs, and he can bat as well - after that decision, a lot of things changed for us." Seventeen wickets in 10 matches at an economy of 7.54. Thirteen of those in the middle overs, where his height extracts bounce from lengths that are otherwise comfortable to hit. The calculation was made fourteen months ago. It has paid off precisely as intended.

Prasidh Krishna's 16 wickets have come at a cost - 10.52 runs per over - but he remains a difficult bowler to line up. The lengths are awkward, the pace persistent, and he repeatedly hits the deck hard. Caught between driving and pulling, batsmen are forced into scoring options they would not normally consider. On a surface like Ahmedabad, where the bounce is true and the pace holds, those lengths become difficult.

Then Rashid Khan. By the time he arrives, RCB will have survived the pace quartet. It will not feel like relief. Seventeen of his 19 wickets have come in the middle overs, where he has broken partnerships and stalled scoring with a consistency that makes him the most reliable wicket-taker in the competition when games are in the balance. His pace through the air, his accuracy, his ability to create doubt where batsmen thought they had settled - each time a RCB batter thinks they have read the innings, Rashid will be waiting.

Batsmen win you games. Bowlers win you championships. Gujarat Titans have built their bowling attack around that conviction.

● SULTAN OF SWING

How Bhuvi hasn't allowed the young fearless batsman to run away with IPL

Sandeep Dwivedi
New Delhi, May 30

WHILE THE 15-year-old Vaibhav Suryavanshi's fearless hitting has made him this season's highest run-getter, Bhuvneshwar Kumar, at 36, has exploited that same trait in several new-age batsmen to emerge as one of the league's top wicket-takers. Though he hasn't yet got Suryavanshi's wicket, Bhuvneshwar's 26 scalps include the who's who of Gen Next daredevils—Priyansh Arya, Prabhsimran Singh, Sahil Parakh, Sameer Rizvi, Ayush Mhatre, and a few more.

The sly old fox has reminded the young Turks that their standard-deliver, relentless attacking approach, though very popular with fans, isn't bulletproof. He isn't allowing the relentlessly attacking kids to run away with his sport. Not that he is getting any credit for keeping bowlers relevant in T20 cricket. But then, that has been Bhuvneshwar's story all along.

As a rookie bowler, he

notched Sachin Tendulkar's first duck in domestic cricket. He had a dream ODI debut against Pakistan, running through their top order. He is on the Lord's honours board. He has two Purple Caps and two IPL titles.

Still, Bhuvi isn't even the most talked-about cricketer from his hometown Meerut. That honour goes to Praveen Kumar. In RCB, there are Virat Kohli and now Rajat Patidar, players with more star power than him. Not that he minds or works towards building an aura around him. A man of few words, he isn't just understated but does his best to underplay himself.

Strong work ethic

Once, an interviewer asked him the secret of his swing bowling and suggested a few options: Is it because of the several ball-manufacturing units in Meerut? Was it because Bittu, his childhood name, was passionate about kite flying, a daily activity that helped him develop dexterous wrists? As if to cut the con-



At 36, Bhuvneshwar Kumar (26 scalps and counting), continues to be a challenging prospect for batsmen to deal with in the IPL. CREIMAS

versation short or probably not keen to intellectualise his art, he agreed to both. If easy access to a gleaming red cherry and kite flying made one the Sultan of Swing, India would be brimming with bowlers of Bhuvneshwar's skill. Bhuvi, the Sultan of Swing, didn't mind the image of a kite-flying Bittu.

Though later in the chat, he did mention the hours he put in as a 10-year-old with a slight build to be a fast bowler. He didn't have any energy left to even eat food. His mother gave his elder sister the daily duty of feeding him as he sprawled on the bed, shut his eyes, and called it a day. He also had drools drip-

In the IPL too, when Bhuvneshwar gets one of the new stars, a Johnny-come-lately hard-hitter, his celebration doesn't have the angst of a veteran who grudges the success and riches of the newbies

ping from the corner of his mouth when he slept — a clear sign of a thoroughly exhausted person. These were nuggets mentioned in passing with no effort to exaggerate his ordeal from his early days. In his part of the world, the industrial town of Meerut, they call Bhuvneshwar a karmath cricketer—a player with a great work-ethic and firm believer of karma and not the hype-industry.

Bhuvneshwar comes across as a laid-back cricketer but that's misleading, like his bowling. Watch his eyes when he runs in

to bowl — fully focused on the target, tiny balls of fire burn at the very center of his pupils when he towers over the stumps, arches his back, and unleashes the ball exactly where he wants. Every time he has the ball in his hand, he seems to be in a zone, his brain ticking constantly to spot a weakness in the batsman in front. His goal is to dismiss the batsman, nothing else. No ugly send-off or a sledge to vent out the anger or even an over-the-top celebration to tell the batsman that he was better on the day.

Thinking bowler

When he got Tendulkar, he hung his head, as if to offer an apology to Paaji. At Lord's, when he knocked back Ben Stokes's stump to take his fifth, all he could manage was a mild fist-pump. In the IPL too, when he gets one of the new stars, a Johnny-come-lately hard-hitter, his celebration doesn't have the angst of a veteran who grudges the success and riches of the newbies. Once he has beaten

their defense, he is on his own, flying on the turf, celebrating his victory and not the batsman's defeat. His face betrays the satisfaction of a thinking bowler who has cracked the code to pin down the modern T20 smasher.

In an RCB video, when asked to compare Suryavanshi & Co. to past batsmen, he shares a secret that gives hope that all is not lost for the bowlers. "They (new-age T20 batsmen) are fearless. They don't think about what the conditions are and what the situation is. They take on the bowlers. That is also the reason batsmen of the past are more mature and read the situation and conditions better than these guys," he says.

While lesser bowlers get intimidated by the massive back lift and the bats moving like a golf swing, Bhuvneshwar sees an opening. A classical swing bowler, with immaculate control over the line and length, the ever-evolving bowler bowls lengths that force batsmen to move their feet—something today's T20

batsmen aren't used to.

By an indiscernible adjustment of the thumb on the ball, he has it on a string. He got Arya out with a ball pitched at a length that was beyond his reach; the extra bounce that he gets from bending the back at the last minute resulted in a mis-hit. Prabhsimran was foxed by a ball pitched on a Test match length, swung wide on the off-side and moved further away after pitching. By habit he swung and edged behind. Rizvi couldn't read the length and got bowled.

Bhuvi the conjurer has been playing the young batsmen this season. As he said, they weren't reading the conditions, situation, or the bowler who had Tendulkar for a duck and is a Lord's hero.

Here's a humble request to those punch-drunk on the success of this IPL's young six-hitting machine—spare a thought for an equally successful crafty old-timer. If your fingers are hurting from applauding Suryavanshi all season, deliver a slow-clap ovation to Bhuvneshwar.

SINGAPORE OPEN

Satwik-Chirag down World No.1s to reach final

Down 8-13 in the first set, Indian pair beat Seo Seung-jae and Kim Won-ho to end their 34-match winning streak

Shivani Naik
Mumbai, May 30

NOT FEARLESS, but forged. Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty were 8-13 down in the first set against the world champions. They won 21-19, 21-18.

Defeating world champions and top seeds Seo Seung-jae and Kim Won-ho of Korea, the Indians reached successive finals in the month of May at the Singapore Open Super 750. This was their first win over the Koreans, who came in on a 34-match winning streak, unbeaten across seven tournaments since last autumn.

For the tall Indians, constantly facing the headwinds of the flat game and service return troubles, it was a massive release of pressure — not only did they out-skill Seo Seung-jae, a contemporary doubles great, but they came back from trail-

ing positions in both sets. “The way we were playing, even when we were down we backed each other up. We knew they crack at some time if we stick to our plans. Points would eventually come. We had that belief,” Chirag told BWF.

The path from 9-13 to 17-17 was the turnaround they had been building toward for a year — a period in which their game has evolved to become more complete than even when they were World No.1. The two Olympic disappointments have better armed them for beating pairings who make them uncomfortable.

Their reputation as slam-bang smash machines helped. It meant the creative southpaw Seo Seung-jae was perpetually in two minds, always bracing for the big smash to the back court. While the fast conditions neutralised Korean skills, the Indians played snappy, flat



Rankireddy and Shetty (R) beat Seo Seung-jae and Kim Won-ho 21-19, 21-8 in the semifinals of the Singapore Open. BADMINTON PHOTO

drives, pushing Seo-Kim back and opening up wide spaces to kill. Levelling at 17-all, the gear change from five points down was almost imperceptible. Seo was so wary of the smash that the Indians gleefully pinned him back and took the first lead with front-court kills at 18-17.

Satwik remains uncertain in confidence, but in a classic 1-2 move the duo operate almost on autopilot. On the most cru-

cial point of the match — getting to 19-18 without wilting — Satwik soared to smash first, then Chirag leapt like a second giant wave to hit the Koreans. Satwik made amends for a service error that followed with an aggressive cross-net, wholly unexpected by the Koreans who had beaten the Indians twice last year.

The opening set was claimed 21-19 after a fast, taut,

tense rally in which the Korean defence parried back an Indian attacking flurry until they couldn't — a Satwik smash finally beating Seo's usually watertight defence.

Decoy smash

Still, Seo-Kim are No 1 and on an undefeated streak for a reason. The Indians trailed again in the second, even as Seo was now convinced the Indian attack was an almighty headache. From 0-3, Satwik-Chirag tried the decoy smash — the ultimate moment in men's doubles — when Chirag jumped as if to hit but Satwik rose like a booming echo right behind him and completed the action.

Chirag followed with cheetah-like front-court interceptions, boldly attacking the Korean serve and sowing more doubts. Satwik rattled Kim with high flats at face height, putting the Koreans in an awkward bind. “Set 2 plan was to just keep pushing at the net. I felt like they were not in a comfortable position to defend. They didn't want to defend. So we got into that game, didn't leave

them, just rushed them,” Satwik told BWF.

The real war bugle was blown at 9-9 with Chirag's iconic cry of 'Maar'.

Even as the Koreans took a slender 11-10 lead, they had been split twice — both Seo and Kim going for the same shuttle, colliding twice. Things went to 11-14, but the Indians were prepared. The attack was earned by keeping Korean playmaker Seo under pressure with hard pushes, depriving him of time to create openings while going on the attack themselves.

“If we have to beat them we have to be steady. By far they have the strongest defence on the circuit. Normal rallies we are OK, but when rallies get longer they are quite strong in defence. So we need to be calm and steady,” Chirag said.

Satwik drew cross lifts with his smashes for Chirag to kill. After splitting the Koreans again, Seo was shaken enough to send a rare smash long. With Satwik's attack near-unretrievable and the Indians assured at the net, Seo erred on a serve. The Koreans blinking was the tactical win.



Arsenal's Gabriel Magalhaes reacts after missing his kick during the penalty shoot out at the Champions League final. AP

PSG outlast Gunners in penalty shootout

Express News Service
Mumbai, May 30

PARIS SAINT-GERMAIN refuses to let go of Europe. In a final of brutal margins and collapsing legs, the defending champions outlasted Arsenal 4-3 on penalties to retain the Champions League and confirmed their place at the summit of the game.

Twice winners in a row, PSG held their nerve as Arsenal's unbeaten European run finally cracked under pressure. Eberechi Eze's miss opened the door, and Gabriel blazed the decisive kick high into the Budapest night, sending it into the stands as silence swallowed the Arsenal end. As PSG players sprinted onto the pitch in celebration, Gabriel dropped to his knees in tears, surrounded by heartbreak, while navy blue shirts swarmed the turf in scenes of pure triumph.

For much of the evening, which ended 1-1 after extra time, Mikel Arteta's side looked destined to complete the greatest achievement in the club's history. Kai Havertz's early strike gave Arsenal a precious advantage and appeared to put them on course for Champions League glory.

Yet after spending much of the match defending their lead, the Gunners were eventually punished as Ousmane Dembélé converted a second-half penalty to drag PSG level and force extra time.

The scoreline reflected a fascinating tactical battle between two elite sides pursuing European football's biggest prize. Arsenal enjoyed the better start and struck with clinical efficiency, while PSG gradually established territorial control before finally finding a route back into the contest.

Arsenal settled quickly despite the magnitude of the occasion and carried a threat whenever they broke forward. Their reward arrived early when Leandro Trossard, pressing the PSG midfield forced an error and ricocheted off the Trossards into space on the left flank.. Havertz reacted first, drove forward and beat the PSG keeper with a thunderous strike.

Having already produced decisive moments on the biggest stages in his career, Havertz once again demonstrated his ability to deliver under immense pressure.

Yet the goal also altered the shape of the contest. Rather than building on their advantage, Arsenal gradually retreated into a deeper defensive block. Whether by design or through PSG's growing dominance in possession, Arteta's team became increasingly focused on protecting their lead rather than extending it.

PSG sensed it immediately. Luis Enrique's side began to monopolise possession, moving the ball patiently across

midfield and forcing Arsenal further towards their own penalty area. Vitorinha and João Neves dictated the rhythm, while Khvicha Kvaratskhelia and Dembélé searched for openings against Arsenal's disciplined back line.

For long stretches, Arsenal defended magnificently. Saliba was outstanding in one-on-one situations, Gabriel won a succession of aerial duels, and Rice repeatedly disrupted PSG attacks before they could develop into clear chances. David Raya also produced a calm and assured display behind them, commanding his area confidently and helping Arsenal withstand wave after wave of pressure.

However, the longer the match continued, the more difficult Arsenal found it to escape their own half. Martin Odegaard spent much of the second half contributing defensively rather than creating chances, while Bukayo Saka and Trossard were often forced into deep positions to support the full-backs. PSG's pressure eventually produced the breakthrough they had been threatening.

Midway through the second half, Kvaratskhelia drove into the penalty area and was brought down as Arsenal scrambled to contain another dangerous attack.

The referee pointed immediately to the spot, handing PSG the opportunity they had worked tirelessly to create.

Dembele stepped forward and showed remarkable composure. With the stadium holding its breath, the French international drove his penalty beyond Raya and into the net to level the score at 1-1.

The goal transformed the atmosphere inside the Puskas Aréna. The PSG supporters erupted, while Arsenal suddenly faced a challenge they had not encountered since taking the lead.

Having spent much of the match protecting an advantage, they now had to rediscover attacking ambition against a side whose confidence had surged.

Arteta reacted quickly. Jurrien Timber was introduced to strengthen Arsenal's defensive options, replacing Cristhian Mosquera after a difficult spell against PSG's movement. Viktor Gyokeres was also sent on in place of Odegaard, a change that reflected Arsenal's desire to regain an attacking outlet and stretch PSG's defence.

The substitutions brought renewed energy. Gyokeres immediately offered a physical presence that Arsenal had lacked during the latter stages of the second half, while Timber added composure and fresh legs as PSG continued to push forward.

But neither side could find the decisive breakthrough, forcing extra time.

Sabalenka sees off Kasatkina

Reuters
Paris, May 30

ARYNA SABALENKA cut through the French Open chaos as the world number one beat Australia's Daria Kasatkina 6-0 7-5 on Saturday to seal her place in the fourth round after seismic upsets in the previous two days at Roland Garros. With top seed Jannik Sinner and 24-times Grand Slam winner Novak Djokovic exiting in the last 48 hours, Sabalenka restored order with a commanding display to book a tantalising meeting with Japan's Naomi Osaka.

“It has definitely been a great week,” Sabalenka said during her on-court interview. “I'm happy to be through to the second week, happy with my level, and to be able to handle the fight that she brought and get a straight-sets win. Thank you (to the crowd). Honestly, that's just a dream to play in front of you all and feel the support.”

The 28-year-old was reminded that it was her 100th victory as the world number one, making her the ninth player to achieve the feat since the inception of the WTA rankings. Sabalenka joins Martina Navratilova, Steffi Graf, Chris Evert, Serena Williams, Martina Hingis, Monica Seles, Justine Henin and Iga Swiatek in the honours list.

“I've got goosebumps,” said Sabalenka, who struggled with dips in her form and crippling service issues a few years ago.

“It means the world to me and I'm just happy that in the tough moments I stayed tough. I was fighting and never gave up and that is what it has brought me. I'm superproud of myself and my team. We've reached an amazing level that felt impossible.”

Sabalenka wasted little time to get going on a sun-drenched Court Suzanne Lenglen, winning the opening five games with a mix of power from the baseline and precision at the net, before she fought from 15-40 down in the next to secure a bagel.

WRESTLING TRIALS

Panghal sidesteps Phogat show to book her Asian Games ticket

Beats Meenakshi in the final of the 53 kg to avenge her loss to the same wrestler in the Asian C'ship trials

Prithish Raj
New Delhi, May 30

ON A day when the presence of ace wrestler Vinesh Phogat hogged the limelight, two-time World Championships bronze medallist Antim Panghal reclaimed her standing in the 53 kg category after defeating Meenakshi Goyat in the Asian Games trials final at the IG Indoor Stadium.

Antim, who represented India in the 53 kg category at the 2024 Paris Olympics, suffered a shocking loss against Meenakshi Goyat in the Asian Championships trial earlier this year. In the absence of Vinesh, Antim had owned the 53 kg category for the past two years before losing to Meenakshi.

The loss against Meenakshi in the Asian Championships trial had hit Antim like a roadblock. “I lost to Meenakshi di last time in the trials. Before that I rarely lost in the trials and was going to international tours. When I lost the last time, it hit me a little hard,” said Antim. “I realised the importance of winning and worked extra hard this time.”

On Saturday, Antim came up with a new strategy to counter Meenakshi's game. During the six-minute bout, contrary to her playing style, Antim defended stoutly and foiled any attacking moves made by Meenakshi. “I lost to her last time while trying to attack but this time my plan was simple, not to give her my legs. Once I got that right, she tried other attacks but couldn't get it done,” explained Antim.

Last time, Antim tried to attack Meenakshi's legs but paid the price and Meenakshi had countered her in the last moment to pin her. “The idea was to sit patiently and let her at-

During the six-minute bout, contrary to her playing style, Antim defended stoutly and foiled any attacking moves made by Meenakshi.

tack. When the opponent doesn't get many chances, they panic and the same happened today,” Antim's coach Siyanand Dahiya said.

While Antim successfully executed her strategy, the bout was ultra defensive with the scoreline reading 3-2. Antim didn't put forward any attacks and the three points she got were all technical points which resulted in Meenakshi protesting at the end of the bout. Meenakshi alleged that none of the decisions went in her favour. However, Wrestling Federation of India (WFI), after a review, said the bout was won fairly by Antim.

Business as usual

Before the trials started, the atmosphere inside the KD Jadhav Indoor hall was already heated. However, Antim didn't let the drama happening around affect her and continued her usual business.

She started her trials in dominant fashion taking down Tannu in 34 seconds. As the bout started, Antim grabbed onto her ankles and turned her over five times to take the win on technical superiority. After that, she pinned Himanshi with just as much ease to enter the semifinals.

In the Last-4 encounter, she faced Commonwealth Games medallist Pooja Gehlot who put up some resistance. For the



Antim Panghal after winning the 53-kg final against Meenakshi Goyat during Asiad trials. GAJENDRA YADAV

larger part of the bout, both wrestlers were locked at 1-1, however, Pooja's attempt to attack Antim in the last moments resulted in the 2025 Worlds bronze medallist reversing it to take her down and make it 5-1.

“My bouts were good and it was a competitive category. I think I executed my plans well and my final went really well,” said Antim, who will be one of India's biggest medal hopes at the upcoming Asian Games.

When asked about if the whole saga of Vinesh returning to the mat affected her performance, Antim said, “It is just another bout and when we are in a competition, we have to fight anyway.”

With the Asian Games three months away, Antim has just played one international tournament this year. But with her regular presence at the international level, it is expected that she can provide some resistance against the wrestlers from Japan, China and North Korea at the continental showpiece.

Have the confidence I can beat younger girls: Vinesh

Prithish Raj
New Delhi, May 30

VINESH Phogat's comeback to the wrestling mat ended in heartbreak as Asian Championships silver medallist Meenakshi Goyat defeated her in the semi-final of the Asian Games trials on Saturday at the Indira Gandhi Indoor Stadium, New Delhi.

“In India, any athlete wins medals not with the system but despite the system,” Vinesh said to the media after her loss, signalling her ongoing stand-off with the Wrestling Federation of India.

“I don't mind losing but when the whole system is against you and still you fight, it is a win. I am grateful that I was able to return to the mat after almost two years,” she

added further.

However, she didn't bow out without a declaration of making a comeback. “I will come back soon. I have not failed. I was fighting a whole system. I was on one side and everyone else on the other,” said Vinesh.

“WFI was actively trying to sabotage my return to the mat but it is sad that the government, SAI, or IOA is not taking a stand,” Vinesh added.

It was an emotional return for Vinesh who put her foot on a mat competitively for the first time after her Paris Olympics heartbreak. Vinesh said that these trials have motivated her. “I can see my body is moving well. I have the confidence that I can beat these young girls and do much better in the upcoming events.”

NORWAY CHESS

Armageddon exhausts the players and thrills the crowd... that's exactly the point

Amit Kamath
Oslo, May 30

AFTER DIVYA Deshmukh prevailed in a nerve-wracking Armageddon game against compatriot Koneru Humpy, she turned up for media interactions with tiny droplets of tears in her eyes. Not emotion. Not happiness. “I'm just exhausted,” she said.

In her first appearance at Norway Chess, one of the strongest invitational tournaments she has been part of, Deshmukh had gone through the Armageddon four times in four days — prevailing three

times before her luck ran out in the fourth. The tears were not dramatic. They were simply what four consecutive days of maximum pressure looked like on a human face.

The Armageddon has been Norway Chess' defining innovation since 2019. When a classical game ends in a draw, players have a few minutes to compose themselves and draw up battle plans before returning for a sudden-death tiebreaker. White gets 10 minutes on the clock.

Black gets seven. But black only needs a draw to win the Armageddon. White must win



Divya has won three of four Armageddon's. MICHAL WALUSZA/FIDE

outright. It has all the harakiri of a penalty shootout in football, or a bowl-out in a T20 World Cup — except the asymmetry makes it something more interesting than pure nerves. Norway Chess' own stats show white maintains only a slight edge: 52 percent.

In the first four rounds of Norway Chess 2026, 19 of the 24 games have been decided by the Armageddon. The classical games are almost a prelude.

Each player has found a favourite corner of the Deichman Bjørvika — the spacious five-storey public library in Oslo where the tournament is taking

place — to retreat to when the draw is signed and the tiebreak looms. Gukesh and his coach Grzegorz Gajewski disappeared to a cosy corner on the third floor, on the other side of the playing arena. Deshmukh takes the leather chairs that overlook the glistening waters of the Oslofjord, discussing tactics with her coach over the phone. The library, built for quiet contemplation, has become a war room.

Indian players have developed a reputation in the format. At last year's edition, Arjun Erigaisi won four of his five Armageddon games. Before this season — where Gukesh has

lost two of his three — the world champion had won six of eight across two appearances, a remarkable record given that faster time controls are not considered his strength.

Magnus Carlsen, who has his own exceptional record in the format, was asked about it. “As a Norwegian speaking in the birthplace of this format, it's pretty exhausting for the players to play that every day. It's just a maximum of 17 minutes, but it's pretty tough on the nervous system. It's more intense than the classical games for sure.”

He noted that Norway

Chess' own time controls — 120 minutes with a 10-second increment from move 41 — were already designed to create wild time scrambles at the end. Then he added: “But I also think that it's excellent entertainment and we are an entertainment product after all.” Deshmukh, sitting by the Oslofjord with tears of exhaustion still drying, would probably agree with the first part. The crowds watching her survive three of four would agree with the second.

(THE WRITER IS IN OSLO AT THE INVITATION OF NORWAY CHESS)

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‘For me, the past is very vivid’

Ruskin Bond on turning 92, his new book and why he can’t stop writing

Shape of Momo’s
Tribeny Rai on the
politics of life



Cricketer Vaibhav Sooryavanshi at 15 has proved that it takes more than a village to raise a champion. With hand-eye balance and powerful bat-swing, his game has a fearful symmetry that has cricket’s greats applauding the ‘new six machine’

Sandip G

A CENTURY-OLD temple comes first, then the house, then the cricketing shrine. A sharp deviation past the signage that marks the entry into Tajpur block in Samastipur district, Bihar, breaks into a narrow rugged path, its tarred flesh receding at the edges, stops at the temple. During the annual festival, thousands flock to the Shiva temple inside the canopied plot. The house on the edge of the temple is modest and unfenced; the first floor gleams in bright pink, matching the shirt colour of the locality’s most famous resident, Vaibhav Sooryavanshi, who is shattering records like breaking chalks in a classroom.

Hugging the house, separated by translucent metallic sheets, is a rectangular cage that resembles a freight container. It’s the cricketing shrine, where Vaibhav spent hours honing his strokes. A set of plastic stumps are intact. One end is a concrete surface, without a crack. The other end is turf, the black soil layer whipping up dust and debris when a breeze sweeps by. During the pandemic, his father Sanjeev and relatives laboured for nearly a month to set up the initial structure, so that his practice would not lag.

Even when Vaibhav is not around, his relatives and boys in the neighbourhood tend to the pitches, as though it is a holy spot. “It’s an emotional place for Vaibhav. Even after he has become a star, he practises here when he is around,” says uncle Pintu Singh. “With him, the atmosphere becomes vibrant. The chats, banter, the stories, they would go on,” he adds. The boys in the neighbourhood would pass by, hoping to catch a glimpse of him. Some of them have bowled to him, some idolise him. One of them, Munna, is a helper in a nearby photocopy shop. “I am 25, used to play club cricket and consider myself a decent off-spinner. I clearly remember getting him out bowled, because it was the only time I had bowled him!”

The sweet sound of leather on wood is the siren that blares the news of Vaibhav’s arrival. “Ours is a quiet village, so you hear every sound in the vicinity. Harvest time, it’s the sound of tractors. So when Vaibhav is around, you hear the sound of him hitting the ball,” says Shrikant Jha, a local resident and a freelance journalist. “At first, it seemed strange like someone pelting stones at your wall, because most of us have not even seen a real cricket ball in our life. Only on television,” he adds. “Even cable television, internet and mobile connectivity are recent arrivals. It’s only in the last 15-20 years that we started getting a stable electricity connection. We were not quite backward but were stuck in the past. Now, we have the future of cricket,” he says.

Now, between the temple and the cricketing shrine, the locals have a little deity. “Only that we watch him on TV than in real life,” says Shrikant.

THE BOSS Baby. Mr Universe. These are epithets bestowed upon Vaibhav Sooryavanshi after he broke the record six haul of Chris Gayle, the Universe Boss in the Indian Premier League (IPL). The Jamaican smacked 59 maximums in 2012; Vaibhav’s six-metre had nudged 65 (until the second qualifier). Gayle, his IPL days long gone, feted him: “What a phenomenal player Vaibhav is. Great entertainment young man! New Six machine,” Gayle wrote on X.

He hits like a machine, a programmable six-hitting machine rather. The frequency is bewildering. He has struck one every fourth ball; Gayle, the most voracious six-hitter of all time, swiped one every ninth ball. Vaibhav’s sixes come in all sorts, through drives, cuts, pulls, slogs, and ramps. He hasn’t spared the deadliest and the most decorated fast bowlers. This season, he has pillaged Jasprit Bumrah, Pat Cummins, Kagiso Rabada and Josh Hazlewood, the four great all-format bowlers of the era. His IPL career is just 33 games old but he has the highest strike in the world in the shortest format (221.6).

The greats of the game have not stopped



DEEPAK MALIK/CREIMAS FOR IPL

showering superlatives. Kevin Pietersen, who signed a jersey from him, raved on X: “Sooryavanshi is an absolute joke! My goodness.” He invited him to his show *Switch*, where the 15-year-old outlined his big dream: “I want to score a double hundred in T20s. If I bat all 20 overs, I can.” He uttered those words with a Buddha-like detachment. He has a poise that belies his age.

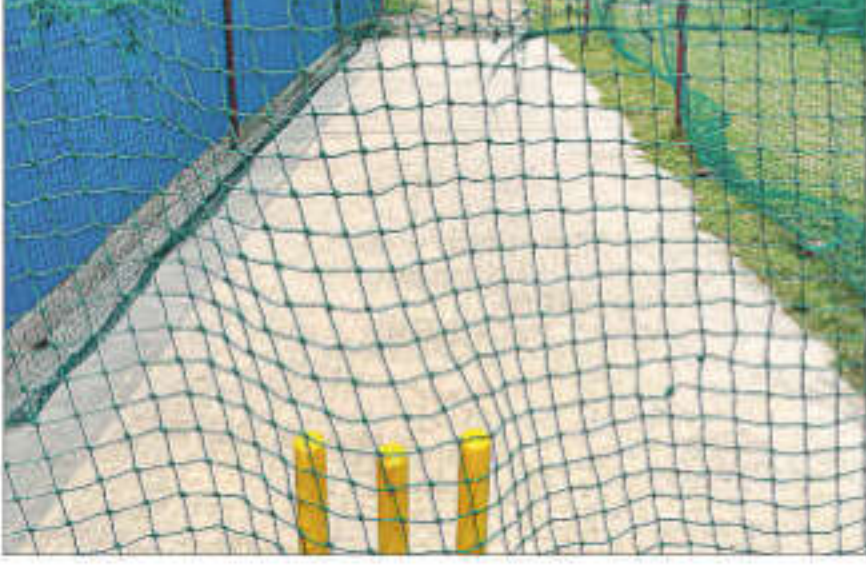
Sachin Tendulkar was quick to point out the finesse of his technique. “Vaibhav’s bat swing has been outstanding. What’s even more remarkable is how beautifully he clears his front foot to create room for balls aimed at his legs. This freedom allows him to play the way he does,” he posted on X after his 97 against Sunrisers Hyderabad (SRH).

One of Vaibhav’s coaches who had worked with him at Royals, Zubin Bharucha, says that his hands and technique remind him of Brian Lara, the 15-year-old’s idol, and the head of Tendulkar. “The boy is very aware of his game. Such a sharp head,” Bharucha observes. He has the same relationship with time and space like most great batsmen; a kind of fly-vision, the ability to strip it all in slow motion. The fundamentals are strong to suggest that his bubble will not burst. Eyes, balance, hand, power, bat-swing, dreamy contact — his game has a fearful symmetry.

His batting is not yet a finished product — a frightening thought for the bowlers’ union. Imperfections would be ironed out; the repertoire enhanced. His Royals coach Kumar Sangakkara has just one piece of advice: “Just enjoy the game.” He certainly is,



PHOTOS: SANDIP G



THE ROYAL ABODE
(From top)
Vaibhav Sooryavanshi; his home in Samastipur, Bihar; his practising space adjoining the house

and he is making watching the game enjoyable too. But the world around him is careful to not overburden him with hype and attention. The dizzying success has those around him worried if the pressure and hype would crush him. His parents are prohibited from talking to the media during the IPL or any other tournament; the beeline of advertisers queuing up for him has been politely turned away. This is an age where most teenagers of his age would be busy preparing for board exams. Outside the arena, he is like a careworn teenager, polishing off ice creams, experimenting with different cuisines, bantering with his teammates and switching off from the sport.

Heavy is the head that wears the crown. But Vaibhav is willing to wear it. In the few interactions he had with the media, often during the post-match presentation ceremony, he has shown a level of maturity that some sportsmen take ages to develop. He is neither nervous nor over-excited with a microphone in hand. The words are firm and clear. His method, he said at the presentation ceremony, are uncomplicated. “I just think about who the bowlers are on the opposition team, how I can face them on this wicket, how big the boundaries are, just these kinds of things. I just try to stay positive with my intent. When I do that, the bowlers stay under pressure. So I try to continue that and dominate the game,” he said. The pre-game visualisation reminded South Africa great AB de Villiers of Matthew Hayden.

It’s untrue that he is too young to feel the pressure. It’s just that he is utterly fearless.

His teammate Dhruv Jurel threw light on his method. “The best thing about Vaibhav is that he doesn’t plan anything,” Jurel says. “Because he practises a lot and he always backs himself. That’s what he does every time he goes out and plays. He backs himself. He doesn’t even have a shadow of doubt that ‘I am not able to do it.’”

V AIBHAV’S EMERGENCE has to be viewed through the social and cultural milieu of his village and region. The Sooryavanshis are landed and have been running a fairly successful jewellery business, not extremely prosperous but enough to meet ends. The surroundings, though, were different. The town had just a cluster of basic shops, the *kirana* and *dawai* stalls. Mobile recharging and repairing shops have sprung up. “Most rely on agriculture but in the ‘90s, we had extreme weather conditions and people started to migrate,” says Shrikant.

A sporting career was unimaginable in Samastipur before Vaibhav burst on the scene. “Cricket was no more than a distraction or a pastime, which the men from cities played,” says Shrikant. But in Mumbai, where Sanjeev landed with Bollywood dreams at the age of 19, the city’s devotion for the game left a lasting impression on him. He did odd jobs like working as a bouncer at a nightclub in Colaba, as a janitor in the city’s port. In spare time, he rushed to the Oval Maidan. “There, young kids playing cricket would be wearing pads and helmets. A few of them were so good that one could watch them for hours. I decided then that be it a son or a daughter, I will make my children cricketers,” Sanjeev had told *The Indian Express* in the past.

When Sanjeev ventured into realising his dreams, he stumbled onto practical difficulties. Samastipur, the district headquarters, had humble facilities. He took him to the most reputed coach in the town, Brajesh Jha, a former district and club cricketer, teaching kids informally. Brajesh was reluctant, because Vaibhav was barely eight and looked even younger. “But what I saw surprised me. Vaibhav had natural movements, was flexible even though he was chubby and learned everything fast,” the coach says. Like a blotting paper, he would stress.

The academy, in Patel Field near the Samastipur bus stand, was roughly 15 km away. Travel would consume anywhere from 30-90 minutes depending on weather and the state of the road. In monsoon, the drains overflowed; in peak hours, traffic jams were frequent; heavy showers would damage roads, months would pass before they were repaired. “Sometimes, we had to wait till the government changed,” says Ram Chaudhary, careening his rickety electric rickshaw past a pothole in the middle of the road. He rattles out a local proverb: “The roads look straight but the routes are crooked.” It fits smugly with Vaibhav’s narrative too.

Shortly, Sanjeev realised that his son should be raised in a more competitive environment, lest he be wasted in Tajpur’s obscurity. So every weekend, he took him to the GenNext Academy in Patna. The 90-km ride, often in ramshackle buses, changed his destiny. Patna was more competitive and aggressive; there was no consideration for his age and the infrastructure was better. His coach Manish Ojha, a former Ranji player, threw him to boys twice his age. He didn’t flinch. He noticed the same trait as Brajesh did. The ability to absorb details fast. “You just teach him something, and the next moment you see the change in his game. I don’t remember teaching him something more than once: he would pick it up and not only practise but perfect it in matches. He always had this ability to play according to the demands of the ball or the situation and come up with a perfect response,” says Manish.

With stunned eyes, Manish saw him blossom and shatter bowlers and records without fuss. “He is easily 3-4 years ahead of his age. Not just in his batting but also in his mind. He is disciplined, does not get carried away and works really hard in the nets,” says Manish. Brajesh remembers the difficulty in dragging him out of the nets. “We had just one pitch and he batted for hours. No one would get him out and the others wouldn’t get to bat,” he says.

In the Sooryavanshi household, the nights were short and the days long. “Whatever I am today, wherever I stand, it’s because of them. My mother would sleep at 11 at night and wake up at 2 in the morning so that she could cook for me. My father quit his job, woke up early in the morning. My elder brother took over my father’s responsibilities. It was tough at home but my father insisted, ‘You’ll make it,’” Vaibhav recalled in a podcast.

The word spread in Patna’s cricket circles about the boy who is humbling men twice his age. The turning point came when someone informed former Jharkhand cricketer and Rajasthan Royals’ scout Samar Qadri about him. He decided to have a look, watched him closely, bowled at him and, at the end of day, excitedly informed the team management about the boy who could be king. He was 13 when Royals snaffled him. He made his debut at 14 and at 15, the world is gazing at him with wonder.

Some make age look like just a number; some make it look like a wonder. Tajpur now has a holy trinity of temple, cricketing shrine and a deity.

Destiny: It's a Choice

Featuring essays by retired civil servants who served in the state, The Kerala Club combines administrative experience with literary flair to chart Kerala's achievements in terms of human well-being

AJ Philip

THERE IS something uniquely Malayali about retired civil servants forming a WhatsApp group and eventually producing an anthology on Kerala's past, present and future. It combines nostalgia with intellectual restlessness, administrative experience with literary flair, and above all an abiding concern for the destiny of the State they served. *The Kerala Club: Keepers of the Flame*, edited by KM Chandrasekhar and TP Sreenivasan, is the impressive outcome of that collective enterprise.

Published by Bloomsbury, the volume brings together 29 essays that examine the Kerala model critically and suggest ways to preserve and strengthen what has made the State exceptional. Kerala itself is a fascinating paradox. The very word Kerala is believed to derive from Kera, or coconut, though the coconut was not even endemic to the region. Formed by the merger of Travancore, Kochi and Malabar, Kerala is less a monolith than a mosaic of religions, customs, cuisines and cultural practices held together by the Malayalam language, now recognised as a *Shrestha Bhasha* by the Centre.

Once among the poorest regions in India, Kerala has become a State virtually free of extreme poverty. Economists and sociologists frequently celebrate the "Kerala Model" but this book refuses to indulge in self-congratulation. Beneath the gleaming malls and lavish houses lining Kerala's highways, the writers detect structural weaknesses that cannot be ignored indefinitely. S Subbiah points out one such weakness: the absence of any reliable mechanism to verify if government programmes actually reach the last beneficiary. Equally revealing is Sreenivasan's account of his difficult post-retirement experience in Kerala's higher education sector. His reformist suggestions were fiercely resisted and he himself was

manhandled. Financial imprudence is another recurring concern in the writings of T Nandakumar and N Ramachandran.

Several essays stand out for their practical wisdom. KB Valsala Kumari sees the success of the Kudumbashree programme as proof that genuine gender equity is possible only when women are entrusted with leadership. Dr K Ellangovan makes a persuasive case for empowering nurses to handle minor procedures and emergencies, especially in rural areas where doctors are scarce. Environmental anxieties too run through the book. Brandon Corrie's essay on forests is among the most evocative. Beginning with the observation that "forests have neither voice nor votes", he appeals that humans must speak for them because only through people can forests be heard. Former IAS officer and Union Minister KJ Alphons sounds an alarm over the Mullaperiyar dam, calling it a "ticking bomb". His proposal that Kerala offer free water and electricity to Tamil Nadu in exchange for constructing a new downstream dam reflects the seriousness of the issue.

Throughout the volume, the intellectual shadow of Amartya Sen looms large. His "capability approach" to development finds repeated mention because Kerala's achievements are ultimately measured less in terms of wealth and more in terms of human well-being. Joy Vazhayil hopes Kerala can restrain the growing influence of pressure groups with narrow agenda and evolve into an egalitarian society marked by a high happiness index. Urbanisation, entrepreneurship and decentralisation are examined with similar candour. P Joy Oommen sees opportunity in Kerala becoming one continuous urban corridor from the north-end to the south-end. T Balakrishnan worries about mounting debt but finds hope in a younger generation willing to embrace entrepreneurship.

The personal narratives lend the anthology warmth and readability. Vinod Rai recounts how, though originally allotted Nagaland, he eventually joined the Kerala cadre. Rajan Medhekar offers perhaps the volume's most delightful anecdote: a science student topping Ancient Indian History in the civil services examination after devouring *Amar Chitra Katha* comics.

Though written largely by former bureaucrats, the essays rarely lapse into officialese. They write with humour, erudition and emotional investment in the State's future, making it both a serious reflection on the Kerala model and a collection of memories.

Philip is the president of Kerala Club

Amitabh Kant

TUSHAR MEHTA'S new books, *The Bench, the Bar and the Bizarre: The Unfamiliar, the Curious and the Extraordinary in Law* and *The Lawful and the Awful: Quirky Tales from the World of Law*, are unusual and welcome additions to contemporary legal writing. They arrive when most conversations around the justice system are centred on reform, pendency, digitisation, access and institutional capacity. These are necessary conversations but the books remind us that the law is not only a system of rules, procedures and precedents. It is also a human institution, shaped by temperament, humour, language, habit and experience. And occasionally, it is willing to loosen its collar a little.

This candid, self-aware view of the law has a long lineage. Fali Sam Nariman, one of the great stylists of the Indian Bar, famously remarked that "lawyers in India never retire; they simply drop dead," a line that captures both the stamina and the self-deprecation of the profession. His witticisms sit alongside a wider tradition of legal humour and satire, ranging from courtroom anecdotes to RK Laxman's cartoons that gently sent up bureaucrats, politicians and, at times, the legal system itself, show that institutions can be both dignified and capable of laughing at their own excesses. Mehta's books belong squarely in that tradition of looking at the Bench and the Bar with affection, irony and an eye for the quietly absurd.

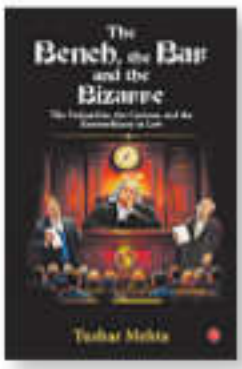
The courtroom is usually imagined as a place of solemnity. It has its own rituals, hierarchy, vocabulary and traditions. The robes, arguments, citations and judgments reinforce the sense that the law is serious, ordered and exacting. But anyone who has spent time in and around courts knows that the legal world is also full of surprise, wit, eccentricity and contradiction. Even grave proceedings can produce moments that are odd, revealing or unexpectedly amusing.

These books capture that world with affection and restraint. They do not make light of the law. Rather, they make the law more accessible. They show that the dignity of the legal system is not weakened by acknowledging its quirks. If anything, institutions become more credible when they can look at themselves honestly, and with some humour. The law deals with human behaviour in all its complexity. It is natural that the world of law should also contain wit, vanity, brilliance, confusion, vulnerability and occasional absurdity.

The Bench, the Bar and the Bizarre covers a wide canvas, including judges beyond borders, judicial eccentricities, courtroom

HUMANE FACE OF THE LAW

Solicitor General of India Tushar Mehta's books show the legal world in full colour: serious but not humourless, disciplined but not mechanical, majestic but not infallible



THE BENCH, THE BAR AND THE BIZARRE: THE UNFAMILIAR, THE CURIOUS, AND THE EXTRAORDINARY IN LAW

TUSHAR MEHTA
Rupa
328 pages
₹995

ORDER, ORDER
Outside the Supreme Court in New Delhi

wit, freedom of expression by judges, judicial jargon and the craft of opening a judgment. *The Lawful and the Awful* extends the range further, with reflections on bullying from the Bench, mobile phones and social media in the judiciary, dissenting judgments, demons and ghosts in court, artificial intelligence, fake citations, courtroom decorum and the frailties that sometimes enter even the most formal spaces of justice.

This is important because legal systems

are not built only by statutes and judgments. They are also built by conventions, temperament, conduct and memory. The best institutions combine authority with humility, discipline with openness, and seriousness with a capacity for self-reflection. These books show the Bench and the Bar not as distant abstractions but as communities of people engaged in interpreting law, resolving conflict and maintaining public trust.

The timing of these books is also relevant.

India's justice system is at an important stage in its evolution. As the economy grows, formalises and digitises, more citizens and businesses will enter formal legal and economic systems. There will be more contracts, transactions, enterprises, platforms and, inevitably, more disputes. That is part of the life of a growing society. But it also places greater pressure on the legal system to be faster, more predictable, more accessible and more citizen-focused.

This is where conversations around mediation, online dispute resolution, e-courts, technology-enabled case management and improved court administration become significant. India cannot realise its full economic and social potential unless dispute resolution becomes more efficient and affordable. Delay in justice affects not only individual litigants but also enterprise, investment, innovation and public trust.

But technology is not a substitute for justice. It is only an enabler. It can reduce delay, lower costs, improve access and bring greater transparency. But it cannot replace fairness, reason, restraint, integrity and compassion. These books, in a lighter and more anecdotal way, reinforce that law cannot be reduced to

process alone. It is ultimately about judgment, trust and institutional character.

As AI enters legal research, drafting, education and even adjudicatory support, it will bring opportunity and risk. Legal research must remain reliable. Citations honest and arguments disciplined.

For lawyers, these books will bring recognition and amusement. For students, they will make the law feel less intimidating. For general readers,

they open a world that often appears distant and inaccessible. For those interested in reform, they offer a useful reminder that systems are improved not only through rules, infrastructure and technology but also through a better understanding of culture, incentives, habits and human behaviour.

It is perhaps fitting that at the book launch at Bharat Mandapam, the addresses by Home Minister Amit Shah, Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and Attorney General R Venkataramani were extremely candid, funny and showed incredible wit, echoing the spirit of the books themselves.

India's legal system must become faster, more modern, more transparent and more accessible. But it must also remain humane. These books show the legal world in full colour: serious but not humourless, disciplined but not mechanical, majestic but not infallible. Their quiet achievement is that they bring the Bench and the Bar closer to the people they ultimately serve.

Kant is Chancellor, NIIT University; Chairman, Fairfax Centre for Free Enterprise; former G20 Sherpa, India, and former CEO, NITI Aayog

average lifespan of a CEO in the corporate jungle is 18 months, which is less than the warranty card on the office computer. He also weighs in on the pressing questions of our times: Can one have friends at work? Do barking bosses bite? Am I or AI? and, last but not least, Karma for professionals.

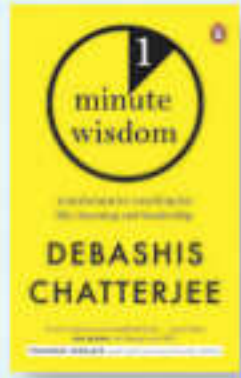
Much like the fables of yore, chimpanzees, horses, elephants, honey bees and cobras make an appearance, imparting wisdom of the ages, as do the lessons taught by blackberries and watermelons.

Feminine leadership and MeToo also get a mention. My grouse is that while Chatterjee asks us to beware of the Queen Bee Syndrome, he does not dedicate a snippet to what he, in passing, refers to as the 'King Cobras,' which feels unfair. After all, the creatures are venomous and partial to the corner (office) to boot.

AISHWARYA KHOSLA

SHELF LIFE

Follow the Tail



ONE MINUTE WISDOM
DEBASHIS CHATTERJEE
Penguin
268 pages
₹499

A MENAGERIE of *Panchatantra* animals — a talkative turtle, greedy crocodile, loyal mongoose and jealous fox — paired with a sprinkling of parables and excerpts from scriptures have, for generations, introduced children to the treacherous world. But where are the pithy stories for those navigating office politics, leadership quagmires and the general conundrum of being an adult?

Debashis Chatterjee's *One-Minute*

Wisdom — an eclectic collection of slice-of-life micro-essays that offer "core insights and transformative coaching techniques" — is the answer, tailored for the harried professional, who neither has the time to read nor philosophise the long queues, a half-finished statue propped up with a rod, the transit lounge at the airport or even wabi-sabi.

Chatterjee, who was the longest-serving director of Indian Institute of Management, Kozhikode, and has spent three decades in leadership, education and personal development, certainly has the credentials to guide young professionals through his musings, both serene and experiential.

The book contains 158 vignettes parsed into three categories: life, learning and leadership. Much like the 'talkative tortoise' of the *Panchatantra*, his first piece of advice to reach one's peak po-

tential is to "keep quiet," not just one's mouth trap, which he also recommends, but the mind, as "a restless mind becomes a liability."

In one of the micro-essays, he compares competitive life to kickboxing but advises taking up collaborative dancing instead; in another, he calls altruism the antidote to the algorithm; in the next, he compares an entrepreneur to a monk; and in still another, he compares information flow to the top of an iceberg. Each snippet is rich in imagery and metaphor.

There are some aphorisms one can pocket too, such as 'there are two kinds of bosses in this world: windows and walls'; 'life is at best one per cent competition and 99 per cent cooperation' and, my favourite, 'there is one Buddha and billions of buddhas.'

At one point, he observes that the



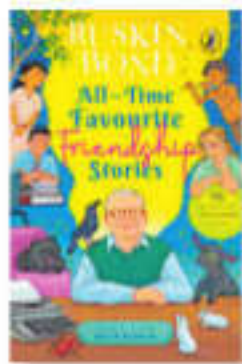
STONEX GLOBAL

A FRIEND INDEED
Ruskin Bond

explores the theme of friendship. Friends have been a constant in many of Bond's works — some have been fictional while others have been real figures. "Soni was very real," says Bond, of one of the key characters in his first book, the semi-autobiographical, *The Room on the Roof* (1956), written when he was just 17. "It was in 1951 and I had just finished my schooling and

came to Dehradun, trying to write. Soni was from a Sikh family who came here as refugees during the Partition," says Bond of the younger brother of Everester Major HPS Ahluwalia. "He is settled in America but seven or eight years ago, he came to see me after nearly 70 years. He had grey hair and I had grey hair but we were the same," he laughs.

While some bonds endured, others got lost in the passage of time and history. Omar from the story, *The Playing Fields of Simla*, was one such friend. "He was actually Azhar. Up to 1947, one-third of the boys in our school (Bishop Cotton School) were Muslims, from Lahore, from as far as Peshawar. When Partition came, they had to be evacuated overnight in trucks under military escort. We lost one-third of our school and many friends," he says. As he writes in the story, he heard of Omar some 17 or 18 years later when India and Pakistan were at war. "...In a bombing raid over Ambala, not far from Simla, a Pakistani plane was shot down. Its crew died later in the crash. One of them, I learnt later, was Omar...Did he, I wonder, get a glimpse of the playing fields we knew so well as boys?" he writes.



ALL-TIME FAVOURITE FRIENDSHIP STORIES
RUSKIN BOND
Penguin
240 pages
₹399

Making friends is no longer so easy though. "To begin with, I was a shy boy till I was 15 or 16. Then I started making friends more easily. Now I am going back to my childhood days, I am finding it difficult to make friends again. There has to be a meeting ground. There is so much materialism now. In our time, money didn't come to our mind when making friends," he says.

Confined mainly to the house, Bond finds himself going back often in time. The past also resurfaced recently in his book *The Ghosts of Indian Small Towns: A Journey Through Time* (Aleph, 2026).

"I know fewer people to write about so one writes about the past which, for me, is very vivid. I have a very good memory. I used to be a film buff. I can tell you the cast of almost all the films made in the 1940s and early 50s," he says.

It's the past that he continues to turn to for memories and storylines. "But I am not writing a novel or anything long. I may not be able to finish it because after all, I cannot live forever. I am just flitting ahead, week by week, month by month and that's nice in a way because you don't have to make too many plans," laughs Bond.

'It's hard to stop me from writing'

Ruskin Bond on turning 92, his new book of friendship stories and why he simply can't stop writing

Devyani Onial

A BOY with an extra thumb who excels in spin bowling and a beauty contest of birds with an owl for a judge and a tiny restart for a winner. These are just two of the half-a-dozen stories that Ruskin Bond has conjured up, propped in his bed in a spacious room in a leafy villa in Dehradun's tony Dalanwala as he recovers from a spinal surgery he underwent a few months ago. "Lying here, my imagination works overtime," he smiles. "I can't walk up the steep stairs of my house in Mussoorie but I don't mind being here. After all, I grew up here. My grandfather settled here in the 1900s, he was here from the time that the

CONFINED MAINLY TO THE HOUSE, BOND FINDS HIMSELF RETURNING TO THE PAST FOR MEMORIES AND STORYLINES

first train came in," says the author of *Our Trees Still Grow in Dehra* (1991), who turned 92 on May 19.

The surgery may have confined him mainly to a room, but his mind has been free to roam around everywhere. "It's hard to stop me from writing. Even though now I can't see well enough to write by hand as I used to, I dictate my stories to my granddaughter," says Bond, speaking on the sidelines of The Ruskin Bond Literature Festival held in Dehradun, presented by StoneX Global and The Ruskin Bond Foundation. One of India's most prolific writers, his recent book, *All-Time Favourite Friendship Stories* (Penguin), a collection of stories, some new, some old,

This is the forgotten story of Kachaudi Gali, a century-old folk song, which documents the anguish of women during the migration in Purvanchal, when men from the region were shipped to present-day Myanmar under British rule

From Kachaudi Gali to Coke Studio

Suanshu Khurana

FOR THE better part of its existence, the catalogue of Coke Studio Bharat has remained closer to mainstream artists and indie music than to regional folk traditions. After struggling to find a firm footing with its previous editions, its latest release, titled *Kachaudi Gali*, is a marked shift in approach with a soundscape rooted in authentic folk. The show has brought a melody from the bylanes of Varanasi in the delicate cadence of Bhojpuri.

Sung by playback singer Rekha Bhardwaj and Utpal Udit, a folksinger from Bihar, and put together by music producer Nishant Nagar, with the distinct Purabiya lilt in tow, *Kachaudi Gali* has attempted to resurrect a time and story that once was and a song that has survived for over a century through oral legacy. It opens with the line *Sejta pe lote kala naag, Kachaudi Gali sooni kaila balamu* (On the bed, a black serpent creeps slowly, Kachaudi Gali waits silent, missing your glow), which metaphorically speaks of a woman's desire for her beloved who's migrated to Mirzapur, a major industrial and trading hub back in the day, where many men from Purvanchal (eastern Uttar

Pradesh) went to work.

Varanasi's Kachaudi Gali, which still survives, is a narrow lane tucked away in an area called Lahore Tola near Kashi Vishwanath Temple. The street got its name from the famed kachaudis fried in large *kadhais* and was once a vibrant hub for freedom fighters, academics and artistes, who would gather to discuss politics and culture over chai. Also, unlike the usual innuendo-laden

A forgotten Bhojpuri folk ballad revives histories of love, migration and longing

Bhojpuri music, the song highlights the tender and eloquent idiom of Bhojpuri folk tradition.

Its authorship and popularity

Likely to have been written and composed in the 19th century, the *kajri* (a folk tradition sung in the monsoon) emerged from the ache of separation of a woman, possibly a courtesan from Banaras. The piece is also sometimes called *Kajri*

Gauhar Jaan. But it was not written or sung by the famous Gauhar Jaan of Calcutta, the first Indian musician to record her voice commercially on the gramophone. As legend goes, this is the story of another Gauhar Jaan who lived in Dalmadi in Banaras. "It is believed that she used to go out in her palanquin in Kachaudi Gali and would pass by a man named Aslam, a patriot, near the *chowk*. There was no conversation but she was enamoured by him and fell deeply in love. One day, he disappeared. On asking around, she was told he had gone to Mirzapur to work, hence its mention in the song. Much later, she came to know that the British had deported him to Rangoon," says Delhi-based Nirala Bidesia, an expert on Bhojpuri music and literature. He adds that the lines *Hathwa mein hoti jo hamare kartariya, baha dete gorvan ke khoon* (If a blade had rested within my hand/ I would have shed the blood of the White man), come from that sense of wanting to avenge the injustice of her beloved being taken away to Rangoon (present day Myanmar). "Folk is an oral legacy, new lines and contexts get added with time," says Bidesia.

Another story around the song is of it being a *Girmitya geet* (a song about the migration of the indentured labourers trans-

LOVE INTERRUPTED
Rekha Bhardwaj; Utpal Udit and Nishant Nagar in *Kachaudi Gali*

ported overseas). Much of the migration was also to find some work for small wages. The song has been associated with this phase.

Shehnai stalwart Ustad Bismillah Khan used to play this *kajri* in his concerts and would often say that he had heard it since he was a child in Banaras. His adopted daughter, Soma Ghosh, would perform this with him in numerous concerts. Folk singer Malini Awasthi has also sung the *kajri* and has mentioned the Gauhar Jaan story in her memoir *Chandan Kiwad*, in which she has traced the stories behind the songs.

The Purvanchali migration

Folk music has remained one of the purest forms of storytelling, where melody, rhythm and lyrics are often used to document life. Using poetry and song as a narrative tool, the song moves further with the lines *Aehi Mirzapur se udal jahajiya, Sayiyaan chal gayin Rangoon ho...* (From Mirzapur, a plane took flight, My beloved has gone away to Rangoon).

This is a reference to the continuous migration of thousands of men from Purvanchal, stretching across eastern Uttar Pradesh and parts of Bihar, which began during the Anglo-Burmese War of the 19th

century. Ordinary citizens were forcefully sent by the Britishers to Rangoon or Burma as sepoy. From 1824 to 1937, Burma was under British rule. Even though the song uses the phrase '*udal jahajiya*', these men were often sent aboard crowded steamships that would depart from what was once Calcutta. "Earlier, it was *chalal jahajwa*. With changing times, *chalal* became *udal*," says Bidesia.

Of the 40,000 troops, 15,000 perished due to malaria, dysentery and fighting amid terrain thick with jungles. While the war ended in 1885, the migration continued through the early 1900s as a result of British colonial policies, which administered Burma as a province of India. The war brought with it massive economic instability and Burma offered prospects for employment in port cities. These men worked in docks, rice mills and as manual labourers. Burma was also a transit point for the British system for Kaala Paani, the exile and imprisonment of Indian prisoners in the Cellular Jail in the Andamans.

"Even today, many people who came back from Burma, use 'Burma' as their surname. This refreshed version of the song has brought age-old Bhojpuri folk and the historical context to the fore," says Bidesia.

'Politics is also in how you lead your life'

Director Tribeny Rai joins Zoya Akhtar, Reema Kagti and Payal Kapadia to talk about her debut feature *Shape of Momo*, indie filmmaking, theatrical culture, the need to nurture writers and politics in cinema

Alaka Sahani

AFTER TRAVELLING to several international festivals and winning accolades, Tribeny Rai's *Shape of Momo* released in theatres on May 29. The Nepali-language film, set in a Sikkim village, is distributed theatrically by Rana Daggubati's Spirit Media. It is supported by Zoya Akhtar, Reema Kagti and Payal Kapadia, who have come on board as executive producers.

The film follows the story of 32-year-old Bishnu (Gaumaya Gurung) who returns to her ancestral Himalayan village after quitting her city job, only to face multiple family pressures and rigid societal expectations. At home are her grandmother, who hopes her son will return from Dubai; her mother, eager to see Bishnu settled and married; and her pregnant sister Junu, who has come seeking refuge due to tensions at her in-laws' home. Even as Bishnu navigates expectations, she must choose to conform or forge her own path.

In a conversation about the film, Zoya, Reema, Tribeny and Payal, who joined via Zoom from France, talk about women's stories and creating room for independent voices. Excerpts:

What made Zoya, Reema and Payal join hands to support the release

Social realities are quite different for women like us, who want to make their choices

TRIBENY RAI

Director, *Shape Of Momo*

of Tribeny's first feature, *Shape of Momo*?

Zoya Akhtar: I love the story and the intimacy of it. The movie transported me to Sikkim, which I have not visited. It presents a lived-experience that was familiar and foreign. I liked the kind women the film shows and the conflicts they are going through. I like how the gender and class narrative intersects in the film. So, when the opportunity came that I could nudge it towards its release, I grabbed it.

Reema Kagti: It is important to have all kinds of films; independent films which need that kind of support.

Payal Kapadia: When I travel (to festivals), I get to see more independent movies from India than I do when I am in the country. It is a pity when you can watch this kind of a movie only in niche screenings. I was excited that the film will be released in theatres and people will buy a ticket to watch it.

Tribeny Rai: I am fortunate to have such voices championing *Shape of Momo*.



like. It is engaging with all kinds of movies. I would like an audience which encourages both niche and tentpole movies.

Recently, a bunch of filmmakers has been throwing their weight behind independent movies such as *Stolen*, *Humans in the Loop* and *Sabar Bonda*?

Reema: We are all selfish and at the end of the day, we want to watch these movies on screen. That's why everyone steps up to make that happen. To have a thriving industry, we can't have just one kind of movie release. The Indian audience has an appetite for a lot more.

After the statements made at Berlinale that cinema should stay away from politics, the Cannes Film Festival has made its leaning toward politics evident while selecting its winners and making certain statements. What's your take?

Payal: Cinema can't be devoid of politics. You see that in *Shape of Momo*, which can be seen as supremely political. Politics is not always associated with parties. It's also about how you lead your life and the choices you make.

Zoya: You can take any film, including one that does not have anything overtly political, yet you will get a sense of their politics, their views of women or how they view class conflicts. You can understand a person's value system from their work.

Reema: No art can exist in a vacuum. It's all political. If you are consciously omitting any political commentary in your art or writing, that itself is a political choice.

Tribeny: In an initial interview, I had said that in this film, 'personal becomes political'. When you watch the film, you know my stand in life.

This enables many filmmakers of India, especially from my region (Northeast) to tell stories like this.

Your protagonist is a 32-year-old woman who does not make conventional choices.

Tribeny: I wanted this kind of representation on screen. While watching movies, I did not find a protagonist like her. Since society expects us to behave in a certain way, we don't cheer for a female protagonist unless she is righteous like a mother who feeds her son before eating herself. Social realities are quite different for women like us, who want to make their choices, I really wanted to project those experiences.

We have big-budget movies like *Dhurandhar* making waves while *Shape of Momo* is now in cinemas. Should the endeavour also be to draw the audience?

Reema: Between *Dhurandhar* and *Shape of Momo*, they cover the entire spectrum. To me, that's how a healthy industry looks



The daring of a moment's surrender

From sleeping through Carnatic vocal classes to redefining the indie Malayalam music scene, Aron Kollassani Selestin aka Aksomaniac on *Amsham* that ranked No 4 on Spotify's Viral 50 Global charts

Anusree KC

WHEN COVID hit in 2020, many Class XII students were navigating online learning. Some were sleeping through their classes, some were playing online games but Aron Kollassani Selestin (pictured) was on the piano. "I would prop my iPad on top of my piano, log in for online classes with the video off while I played. I didn't care much about my academics at that time," he says with a laugh and not an ounce of regret. "Though eventually, I studied and got good marks," he adds.

Aron, better known by his stage name, Aksomaniac, is singer-songwriter and producer from Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala, basking in the success of his viral track *Amsham* which released last month. The track was ranked No 4 on Spotify's Viral 50 Global charts earlier in May, with over 15 million streams on Spotify and more than 13 million views on YouTube.

The track, which has been viral on Instagram since then, seamlessly transitions across genres such as R&B and hip-hop. With verses in Malayalam and Tamil, the song also features indie artists M.H.R., Bhumi and Circle Tone. "With music, I have an incentive to understand my language better," he says.

Amsham was meant as a love song. "I started out as a track to tease my partner," he says. Aron had been thinking about the mythological figures of Manmadhan or Kamadevan — beings who awaken love in others but are denied it themselves. He says, "Manmadhan embodies a cruel paradox. I first encountered him in the 1991 Malayalam film, *Njan Gandharvan*." The movie gave him what he needed. *Amsham* thus became an attempt to ease into the idea of love and bonding. "You have to push the story forward in steps and make people more comfortable slowly," says the 22-year-old.

Aron was the reluctant school boy who had Carnatic vocal and tabla classes, which held no interest for the then seven-year-old. But the turning point came when his music teacher realised he had an instinct for music. She suggested that he learn the keyboard and piano. He was surprised when his family agreed to buy him a piano because it cost them a lot. They had to take a small loan for it. But that changed things for him. "A piano is a large instrument. You walk toward it, sit in front of it, and it's like a form of surrender when you practise. I started practising for nine hours every single day," he adds.

It was like music had become his life breath. "I was listening to three or four albums a day, like having three meals. I felt like I had missed out and was catching up on lost

time," says Aron, who by ninth grade had started writing poetry too. He did enrol for Computer Science in TKM College of Engineering, Thiruvananthapuram, but dropped out in the third year to pursue music. Last year, he moved to Mumbai.

Building *Amsham* with M.H.R or Mohammed Hussain Rahman (popular hip-hop and EDM producer from Malappuram, known for popular tracks such as *Malabari Banger* and *Munthirichar*)

was not always easy. "I didn't like the first drop he made, and he didn't like the drop I made," he says. So they sat together and listened to the song until something better came out. "I love that disagreement. I am someone who loves disagreement and the way it allows a person to grow." The name Aksomaniac comes from AKS, his initials, fused with his mother's name Soma in the middle, finished off with "maniac" that he already had on his Instagram handle. "There isn't an alignment between the music and the name," he admits, "But keeping it is a way of validating that child who was doing cover songs back then."

That child isn't far from the person on this call.

You have to push the story forward in steps, and make people more comfortable slowly

ARON KOLLASSANI SELESTIN



Heena Khandelwal

CHEF AT HOME

The Real Chow Man

How the street-style chowmein and a Covid-induced YouTube channel paved the way for Ajay Chopra's rise as one of India's top celebrity chefs



SANKHADEEP BANERJEE

Realising the need for multiple income sources during Covid, Chopra launched his YouTube channel. Today, it has over a million followers

He failed the entrance exam, enrolled in BSc instead, then learnt about the IHM Pusa exam. "I cleared it. But my mother would say, 'Bawarchi banega, karchi chalayega'." He went anyway in 1995 and, by his second year, he knew he would be a chef. He graduated with a gold medal but no job in sight.

After several rejections, he joined TGIF in Delhi in 1998, spent six months shredding cabbage, slicing cheese and packing pasta. Later that year, he received a call at 5 pm from The Oberoi Cecil in Shimla, asking him to be present the next morning at nine. He borrowed a coat, boarded an overnight bus, bathed in warm water a kind nurse arranged at a Christian hospital nearby, arrived at Cecil, only to be told that 'Mr. Oberoi was in-house.' They would have to reschedule.

"I said, 'I don't think I can come back again... I have bunked many times for interviews. This is my last bunk, after this I will be thrown out. So if you are giving me a job, I will stay back. If not, I might as well go.' The manager asked him to wait. Chopra slept on the

table. "At 11.30 am, the manager returned. 'Should we do the interview?' and half an hour later, I had the job."

He spent a year-and-a-half at Cecil, where, in his words, for the first time, a chef took a commis and genuinely prepared him for OCLD (Oberoi Centre of Learning and Development). Without it, the path to sous-chef takes eight to nine years. Through it, only two years. Then came London. Before he arrived, he had been cooking at Saffron at JW Marriott, serving Akshay Kumar, Amitabh Bachchan and Hrithik Roshan. "But in London, there were complaints every day." He called chef Atul Kochhar, who has been working in London since 1994. "He said, 'buddy, when in Rome, do as Romans

LIGHTS CAMERA ACTION
Chef Ajay Chopra shooting a cooking video at his studio in Mumbai

do. These goras love their meat but they want to taste the flavour of the meat.' So I put the sauce, made it more intense, and cooked the lamb chops separately with some spices. That gave me a spark—How can Indian food be seen differently? The thought for modern Indian food actually started then."

London was also nurturing in ways that had nothing to do with food. He and his wife Amrita had married only a year before, in 2006. "We were discovering a new country together. That togetherness was the foundation of our marriage." That she has been his partner—at home, in the kitchen and in the consultancy business—is evident.

Back in India, while working with Marriott in 2010, a production house called.

MasterChef was coming to India. Three months of training followed. "It opened up my personality. I was an introvert. Today I have no inhibitions." Post MasterChef (where he co-host and judge) came a series of culinary shows on television—Hi Tea, Northern Flavours, Papad Pickles Aur Pyaala among others. "Television opened something my hotel job would have never done. My wife prayed what seemed like an impossible prayer—Sunday offs. I told her, Sunday is the busiest day. But from 2015 onwards, for 11 years now, every Sunday is off."

YouTube began at the very dining table in his house in Mumbai's Kandivali during COVID. "Amrita would shoot with one phone in her hand, another on a side stand. My



RECIPE FOR VEG CHOWMEIN

INGREDIENTS

Noodles – 1 packet, Oil – 4 tbsp, Garlic (chopped) – 2 tbsp, Ginger & green chilli (chopped) – 1 tbsp, Onion (sliced) – ½ cup, Capsicum (juliennes) – ½ cup, Carrot (juliennes) – ¼ cup, Cabbage (shredded) – 1 cup, Soya sauce – 1 tsp, Red chilli sauce – 1 tsp, Schezwan sauce – 2 tbsp, Vinegar – 1 tsp, Black pepper powder – 1 tsp, MSG – 1 tsp, Spring onion (chopped) – 2 tbsp, Salt – to taste, water – as required

METHOD

TO COOK the noodles, bring water to a boil. Add salt and ½ tsp oil. Add the noodles and cook until 80–90 per cent done (slightly firm). Drain and spread on a plate. Toss with 1/2 tsp oil and let cool to prevent sticking

HEAT A wok on high flame. Add about 3 tsp oil. Add garlic, ginger and green chilli; sauté briefly. Add onions and toss for a few seconds. Add capsicum, carrot and cabbage. Stir-fry on high heat, keeping the vegetables slightly crunchy

NOW ADD the cooked noodles. Then add soya sauce, red chilli sauce, Schezwan sauce, vinegar, salt, black pepper, and MSG (if using). Toss well on high flame until evenly coated

ADD SPRING onions and give a final toss. Garnish with more spring onions and serve hot

team was my two kids." The couple learnt editing together, bought a mic, then a camera, slowly understood lights and sound. "During COVID, restaurant consultants were the first to let go of. Our business went to a grinding halt. And we realised we needed multiple income sources," says Chopra.

In the kitchen, he takes a thick-bottomed pan, adds a little oil, all the chopped vegetables, boiled noodles, sauces, salt, MSG, and stirs. "I like that it can be made in one pot and so quickly." His kids arrive from school. He asks if they want noodles. "Not again," they laugh. During the meal, the conversation turns to parenting—Amrita and Chopra are taking classes on it. Like always, they are on the same page.



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I want to start with a question. Think about your last holiday, not the photos you posted, not the highlights reel you narrated to friends and family when you got back. Think about the other parts. The small, frustrating, sometimes absurd moments that filled the gap between arriving and actually enjoying yourself. Sound familiar?

Here is what I have come to realise after years of travelling, both personally and professionally: the gap between a holiday in our imagination and a holiday in reality is almost always filled with frustrating moments. Not the kind that ruin everything, not disaster-level chaos, but a steady drip of small, avoidable, sometimes hilarious things that erode the first day or two of a trip before the holiday finally finds its rhythm.

I wrote an article some time ago about flying frustrations, the four phases of a flight experience and how to navigate each one without losing your mind. The response was remarkable, because almost everyone, regardless of whether they fly once a year or once a month, had a story. A missed gate. A destroyed suitcase. A middle seat on a fourteen-hour flight next to someone who immediately wanted to have a conversation. And the thing is, more often than not, these frustrations don't stop at the airport. They continue, right into the holiday itself.

So today, I want to talk about this, the holiday frustrations that we don't discuss enough, because we're too busy curating the good parts, and what I have personally learned to do about them.

The Planning Trap

It starts before you even leave home. In fact, it starts the moment you decide to go somewhere. Planning a holiday today means dealing with information overload: multiple booking platforms showing different prices for the same hotel, reviews that contradict each other, and recommendations from friends who visited years ago and whose

favourite restaurant has since shut down. I have, as part of my job, spent entire evenings researching a destination, bookmarked a dozen hotels, and closed my laptop having booked nothing, paralysed by two options that were essentially identical.

The advice problem is real. You mention you are going somewhere and within a day your phone is full of WhatsApp messages from people recommending places, half of which are outdated or based on a completely different kind of trip. I now ask for recommendations from one or two people whose travel sensibility I actually trust and who have been there recently. That's it.

The other trap is over-scheduling. When you have spent a significant amount on flights and accommodation, there is a natural urge to fill every hour and see everything. What actually happens is that you exhaust yourself by Day Two trying to execute a plan that was never realistic. Some of the best moments on any trip come from having no plan at all, and that requires deliberately leaving space for it.

The Hotel Surprise

Hotel photos are optimistic at best. The wide-angle lens, the carefully chosen lighting, the one corner of the room that photographs well. I have checked into rooms that looked spacious and bright in the listing and turned out to be neither. 'Sea views' that require you to lean out the window at a specific angle. 'City views' that face a car park. Heta has become very good at identifying the tell-tale signs in hotel photos before we book, and she is almost always right about what we will actually find.

The check-in time problem is one that doesn't get talked about enough. You land at 9am, check-in is at 2pm, and you now have several hours in a new city with your luggage and nowhere to leave it. I now either book the previous night's room if I know I am arriving early, or I email the hotel in advance to ask about early check-in. It works more often than most people expect, and the alternative, dragging bags around all morning, is simply not worth it.

There is a third thing worth mentioning: the negative review you chose to ignore. Every hotel listing has at least one review mentioning noise, ongoing construction, or thin walls, and almost every traveller has at some point decided it probably won't be an issue, and then spent a night discovering that



it very much is. I read those reviews carefully now and take them seriously. If multiple people mention the same problem, it is a problem.

The Sightseeing Ambush

This is where holidays get properly humbling. You have done the research, you know what you want to see, and you have a rough order in mind. Day One: the famous old town. Day Two: the museum everyone talks about. Day Three: the viewpoint at sunset. You feel prepared. And then the destination politely dismantles your plan. The museum is closed on Tuesdays. It is Tuesday.

The landmark under renovation. The attraction closed for a local holiday you didn't know about. The viewpoint accessible only by a trail that, per a sign at the trailhead, is currently closed for maintenance. The old town market that runs only on weekends, and you are there on a Thursday. None of these things are disasters. All of them are entirely avoidable, and yet almost all of us fall prey to at least one of them at some point during a holiday.

And then there is the queue problem. The world's most visited attractions are popular for good reason. They are genuinely extraordinary. But between you and the extraordinary thing is often a line of fellow human beings stretching far enough to make you question your life choices. I have stood in queues at the Vatican, at the Eiffel Tower, at various temples and palaces and natural wonders, watching the minutes tick by,

calculating whether I will make it in before closing time. Timed entry tickets, booked in advance, have transformed my sightseeing life. Not every attraction offers them, but for the major ones, the Colosseum in Rome, the Uffizi in Florence, Machu Picchu, the Louvre, they are almost always available, often for the same price as a walk-in ticket, and the difference in experience is enormous. You walk in. Other people are still in the queue. You feel, briefly, like you have figured something out.

The other sightseeing reality that guidebooks somehow never fully prepare you for is distances. Google Maps will tell you that two attractions are a twelve-minute walk apart. What it will not tell you is that the walk is uphill, on uneven cobblestones, in the full afternoon sun, and that you are wearing shoes that were entirely reasonable this morning and are now your enemies. I now wear comfortable shoes every single day of a holiday, without exception, regardless of what we are doing in the evening. It is a small decision that has had an outsized impact on my enjoyment of every trip since I made it.

The Food Gamble

This one is deeply personal to me, because I care about food probably more than I should. When I travel, eating well is not optional. It is, for me, one of the primary reasons to go somewhere. The food of a place tells you something about its history, its geography, its culture, and its people that no museum

can match. A bowl of pho in Hanoi, a plate of fresh seafood in a coastal town in Spain, a wood-fired pizza in Naples. These are experiences I look forward to for weeks in advance and remember for years afterwards.

Which makes the bad food experiences sting a little more than they probably should. Here is a situation I have been in more times than I would like: you have done your research, you have a list of restaurants you want to try, and you arrive at the first one to find a ninety-minute wait with no reservations accepted. Fair enough. You didn't book. You move to the second option. Also full. By this point it is 9pm, you are tired, and you end up at a place nearby that looked acceptable from the outside. The food is fine. Not bad. Just fine. And you sit there eating fine food, knowing that somewhere in this city there is a perfect meal happening without you.

I pre-book at least one restaurant per day now. Not every meal. I like the spontaneity of wandering and finding something that looks good. But one meal per day, the one I am most looking forward to, gets a reservation. It is a small habit that has removed more frustration than almost anything else on this list.

The other food frustration worth naming honestly is the vegetarian problem. Heta is a vegetarian, and while the world has made enormous progress on this front, major cities everywhere now have excellent vegetarian options, there are still destinations, restaurants, and airlines where being vegetarian is treated as an unusual preference that nobody quite planned for. I have had the experience of being handed a menu and finding that the vegetarian section consists of french fries and a salad. I have pre-ordered vegetarian meals on long flights for Heta only to be told, somewhere over the middle of an ocean, that they have run out. I now always confirm our meal selections before boarding, and when travelling to destinations where vegetarian food requires more effort to find, I do that research seriously before we arrive, not optimistically on my phone at lunchtime when we are already hungry.

The Group Dynamic

Travelling with family or a group of friends has its own category of frustrations that have nothing to do with the destination. Someone wants to sleep in; someone wants to leave at 8am. Someone wants to shop; someone wants to sightsee. No one is ever hungry at the

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same time. The lunch decision alone can consume forty-five minutes of a perfectly good travel day.

The one thing I have found that genuinely helps is building deliberate free time into the itinerary. A few hours each day, or at least one half-day, where everyone splits up and does their own thing. You reconvene for dinner with stories to tell and without the accumulated friction of trying to keep everyone happy all day. It sounds obvious, but most group trips never do this, and that is usually where the tension comes from.

And Yet, It's Always Worth It

Despite everything I have described, the trips I remember most vividly are rarely the ones that went smoothly. They are the ones where something went sideways and we adapted. The restaurant that was full, so we ended up at a street stall that turned out to serve the best meal of the trip. The closed viewpoint that sent us down a different path entirely. The over-scheduled day that collapsed, and we spent the afternoon just sitting somewhere doing nothing, which, honestly, was exactly what we needed.

Frustrations are part of travel. Checklists help reduce them, but they won't eliminate them. What they do is protect the parts of the holiday that matter most, so that when something unexpected does happen, you have the energy and the good humour to deal with it.

So, how many of these did you recognise from your last trip? And what have I missed? I would love to hear your frustrations and, more importantly, what you have learned to do about them. See you next week.

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